

TANTRIC WOMEN TELL THEIR STORIES

**Jennifer Jayanti Fitzgerald
& Marcus Bussey (editors)**



Gurukula Press

Fire in Our Eyes, Flowers in Our Hearts

Tantric Women Tell Their Stories

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Edited by
Jennifer Jayanti Fitzgerald & Marcus Bussey

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Acknowledgements

Creating a book is like lighting a karmic match. Conceived of nine years ago, this book became a tapestry of promise and passion as people's stories criss-crossed throughout it.

Specific people stand out however, notably: Kamala Alister and Gaotamii Pfeiffer, who both believed in the book from the beginning and helped in so many ways to see it to fruition; Didi Ananda Gaorii, who gently reminded me over the years and who proofread the entire text in various incarnations; the Ananda Palli Master Unit, who were so inspired by the project that they helped fund the publishing; my family members Victor, Marjorie and Chiara Bussey, who worked on the cover; my wife Alison, who provided illustrations for the sections; and Eve Witney, who pored over the text and brought consistency to the voice. Of course the book would be nothing without the women whose stories bring it to life. Many thanks to all the contributors.

Finally, and most significantly, there are two who need special recognition. To Jennifer Jayanti Fitzgerald, whose story this book revolves around, we owe our collective thanks. To the Guru, Shrii Shrii Anandamurti, Baba, whose life and presence inspired the stories told here, let us present in gratitude the garland of inspiration that we draw from these words.

Preface

This book began nine years ago when my wife Jayanti was struggling with breast cancer. She had been reading *Buddhist Women on the Edge* (edited by Marianne Dresser, 1996) and was struck by the intellectual nature of the stories. Her experience of spirituality was very different. For her, spirituality was intensely personal and revolved around an intimate relationship with her Divine guru, Baba. She was ultimately a *bhakta yogi*, one who approaches the Divine as lover, intimate friend and confidant.

She could be a *jinana yogi*, one who finds the Divine through the use of intellect. She could also be a *karma yogi*, one who achieves Divinity through physical action. But essentially she was a *bhakta*: one bound in a romantic relationship with Divinity. This romance was a passionate dance that was filled with struggle and personal conflict as she strove to overcome the impediments of her own body's illness and of her ambivalent relationship with the world. She felt everything intensely: the injustices suffered by the powerless, the injuries inflicted on body and soul by the structures of the world (patriarchy, institutionalism, nationalism) and the difficulty of balancing family life, work and her own spiritual drive.

So as she sat, crossed-legged on the lounge room floor, and talked with me about her dissatisfaction with the book

she was reading, we decided it would be good to create a book that drew on the Tantric tradition she knew and lived. A book that was built around the unique experiences of women on the spiritual path of Ananda Marga. Once conceived, the idea gripped her with immense force and she pursued it until the pain and force of her illness brought her work on the book to an end in the months before she died in September 2000. She left a collection of stories from women from all over the world. So the task lay unfinished.

After one year I took up the pieces and, following her guidelines, shaped them into three sections. I then looked around for other women to work on the text. I felt that as a man it was not appropriate for me to drive the project forward. This was women's business. Many offered to help but the project stalled before again falling into a deep slumber.

Dreams are a recurring theme in this book, generally heralding a significant insight or transformation within the dreamer. So it is fitting that the first dream recounted here should involve Jayanti herself. She came to me in a dream and asked how the editing was going! I awoke immediately, aware that it was now my job. Other factors also converged to make it clear that I had missed a significant point: I had been with Jayanti when the project was first conceptualised and now it was up to me to complete it. Gender had nothing to do with it. This was a personal service to her memory and to the work of all those who contributed to the text while Jayanti was alive.

If there is a law of the universe it must include change and the challenge and struggle that accompanies change. Without meaning, struggle and suffering appear as random

Preface

events. For a *Tantrika*, one who practices tantric meditation, all experience is rich in meaning. Experience is woven into the fabric of life as a conversation with the Divine, as a process that builds depth into all we do and cements a relationship with the Divine, the Beloved that becomes the essence of who we are.

For Jayanti, her struggle with cancer was one such quest for meaning. Two of her poems which appear in this book were written in the months leading up to her death, as she watched the inevitable approach. In these poems, the personal is burnt away, shrivelled by an eternal now that cannot be escaped. She was patient and dignified to the very end, clinging desperately to her two sons (Ajit who was 13 and Krishna who was 10) and all those she loved, but fiercely shifting her love from the possessive tense to a more expansive expression of gratitude and surrender – the eternal tense.

She marked the following passage in one of Baba's books (*Subhasita Samgraha Part 1*, 1992: p.78):

Do you love your son? No, no, you don't love your son. You love Brahma in the form of your son. By loving your son as a son, you cannot love the Lord. Where there is the feeling of son, there is no Lord, and where there is the Lord, there is no son. Where you exist He does not and where He exists you are no more.

This was her final understanding as she melted into the Divine. The *bhakta* in her was all that was left at the end, beyond the intellectualisation and long after she was able to perform physical tasks, it was her love that shone from

her. This feeling is captured in the songs she loved so dearly, the *Prabhat Samgiita* of her Guru, Shrii Shrii Anandamurti: *Basiya bijane tahari dhyane...*

*Alone, absorbed in deep contemplation of Him
I have woven a garland for Him.
Only His shadow was to be seen on the riverbanks
as the southern wind blew.
The bubbling water said, 'Listen, my friend,
your Friend is the friend of all;
You will not get the chance to see Him alone.'
The southern breeze whispered,
'It would be better you had not loved Him;
He is like a star in the sky – a distant nebula;
He sends His sweet smile from afar.'
I shall yet attain Him through my love,
And I learned this lesson from Him!*

Shrii Shrii Anandamurti
Prabhat Samgiita, 1031
(in *The Awakening of Women* 1995)

Marcus Bussey
July 2007



Jayanti's preface

In *Fire in Our Eyes, Flowers in Our Hearts*, thirty women speak of their spiritual journeys along the Tantric path of Ananda Marga. This book explores feminine spirituality within Ananda Marga – the ways in which we, as women, experience and express our spirituality.

Women who are both new to the spiritual path and those who have lived it for many years share their stories. The diversity of these women's experiences is revealed in many ways, from their differing cultural backgrounds to the ways in which their spirituality is expressed – as nuns, as mothers, as gardeners, as artists, as musicians, as cleaners, as academics, as teachers, as missionaries, as patients.

To all who take up this book I'd like to relate the following:

Things have been so very difficult for me this last month. I think some strength emerges in me, but only after lots of other more negative things have surfaced too – fear and despair, hopelessness, anger, exhaustion – and finally at the end comes a little bit of surrender. But I guess life is like that, and Tantra in particular; we only grow by uncovering our weaknesses and having them laid bare before us. For the past few weeks, I have been going through increasing hardship and pain. At times it has reached a point that I have found unbearable and I wonder at Baba's dispassionate silence in the face of my pain. I wonder how He can just

watch me suffer and suffer and suffer, with seemingly no end in sight. I have come to a point of almost giving up.

Last night He came in my dreams. It was a *darshan* (visit by the Guru to his disciples) in Australia. There were not many people there and most of them were not Margiis that I knew; one was my next-door neighbour from childhood, others were people with disability whom I had known through my work, and the woman next to me I knew to be new to the spiritual path.

We were sitting in tiered seats in a hall rather like a stadium, though small. Baba sat below us. Some people with disability were asking him questions. It took them a long time to get their words out, but he just listened patiently and then gave them brief responses. Then Baba went out to take a break. The woman next to me complained we were not getting the opportunity to experience the full extent of Baba's personality because so much time went into listening to these people with disability that Baba had little time left for his response. I simply replied that in my experience of being with Baba you had to go deep within yourself to see him fully; it was not that he would reveal himself for you, but that you had to find him inside yourself.

Then I also left the hall for a break before Baba returned. I was standing at the bottom of the stairs at the end of a kind of passageway. A door to the right led to stairs which Baba would use to return to the room. Suddenly I realised that Baba was upon me. I tried to melt into the wall, to give him space to pass and to not bother him with my presence. But it almost seemed that his bodyguard guided Baba into position right in front of me. I was pinned to the wall by Baba's imposing physical presence. He seemed huge, abso-

lutely huge. Then he put his arms around me and surrounded my whole body in a hug that felt like the whole universe was embracing me. He said, 'How could you think that I don't love you? I am like your closest family'. I was left with an overwhelming feeling of lightness.

I awoke immediately and felt thrilled by the energy running through me, but also a little afraid that I might merge into that energy and leave this world. I tried to keep my eyes open, looking at the stars, trying to anchor myself in this world because I feared the total loss of myself.

But I drifted back to sleep again. This time I found myself walking down a street. I came upon a driveway and knew it was Baba's driveway. The formal structure of the garden had an Indian style to it and I knew that it was his. The sides of this driveway were lined by beautiful flowers coloured from a palette completely unknown to us – iridescent other-worldly brilliant colours that captivated my eye and mind. It was a long, long driveway and at the end of it was a kind of cave or tunnel filled with brilliant white light. It was so soft and peaceful. I was attracted so much, yet I held back. I remember saying in my mind, 'Not yet, not yet! There's still so much more I want to do for You'. I could feel the pull of this world and the attraction of the other.

Later I woke and got up to go to the toilet. Experiencing incredible pain in my pelvis, I could barely walk to the bathroom. I was in agony. Each step seemed to take an eternity. I wondered why I had chosen to stay...

Take care. My love to you, in Him and with you.

Jennifer Jayanti Fitzgerald

28th July 2000

How to read this book

Tantra

Tantra, as it is understood in this book, is an approach to life rooted in the struggle to overcome inner and outer obstacles to self-realisation.

Some readers will be intrigued, perhaps even confronted, by the word Tantra. For many westerners, Tantra is associated with 'esoteric sex' or simply 'sex'. This association grew out of the Orientalist practices of the 19th Century scholars who introduced Tantra to the West (discussed further, for example, by Edward Said in *Orientalism* 1979). The effect was to diminish both the tradition itself and the culture from which it grew. A minor branch of Tantra does explore the sexual dimension of human reality and it has resulted in wonderful art and poetry, but this practice was not central to Tantra.

Tantra is a fight to overcome the darkness of spiritual ignorance. Such ignorance is represented in the personal field of action as our neuroses and fears, our attachments and cultures, and our internal contradictions and ego-centeredness. At the social level it takes the form of exploitation of peoples and the environment, attachments to class, culture, social status, ethnicity and gender, and all forms of structural violence.

The women in this book fight against such forms of ignorance, hence the fire in their eyes. Yet they do so with love in their hearts, love for Guru and all manifestations of divinity within their lives. Theirs is a struggle to bring a unity to this vision. It is a human struggle and hence has no beginning and no end. As we are fond of saying today: it is all about the journey.

The Guru

The stories in this text revolve around the person of Prabhāt Rainjan Sarkar, 1921–1990. Though Sarkar the man appears at times in his historical form, the stories mostly focus on his transcendent form as Taraka Brahma. This is the mysterious and eternal super-persona of Shrii Shrii Anandamurtijii, the Guru. The Guru is that entity that resides paradoxically within us and all about us; that entity that links the local, the time-bound, the mutable and ephemeral now, with the infinite, eternal, transcendent and unchanging present.

Guru is that Being both in and beyond life and history with whom a devotee forges a relationship as a disciple. The Guru has a duty to his/her disciple: to ensure they stay focused on the Path, to pour Grace and Bliss upon them, and to be with them in times of crisis. The disciple reciprocates by obeying the Guru's instructions, following the code of conduct laid down by Guru to strengthen and purify (and protect) the disciple, and to serve the universe in all its forms as a manifestation of the Guru. Both are selfless roles. Both are roles suffused with Love and deep attraction.

Shrii Shrii Anandamurtijii transformed the ancient practice of Tantra by linking self-realisation with service to

humanity. The cult he founded is Ananda Marga. It is essentially a devotional engagement with transformative living in which the fate of the individual is linked to the fate of the whole.

Shrii Shrii Anandamurtijii appears to the disciple in the form that they are linked to by the force and nature of their own past actions (*karma*): their *samskaras*. Thus, we find the women in this book responding to Him as daughter, mother, lover, friend or servant. The relationship is always unique, yet always deeply devotional. They refer to him as Baba, the most beloved, the nearest and dearest one.

Baba used two names when communicating. His spiritual name of Shrii Shrii Anandamurti appears on texts of a spiritual nature. He used his legal name, Prabhat Rainjan Sarkar, when discussing social issues.

Sanskrit

This text is peppered with Sanskrit words. Sanskrit is an ancient and subtle language which has evolved to communicate very specific insights into spirituality and the human condition. The glossary at the end of the book provides usage (as opposed to technical) definitions for these terms, and makes for interesting reading in itself. Some Ananda Marga terminology is also explained.

Let the Sanskrit words run over you like water, allowing them to augment your understanding as you read.





Guru Krpahi Kevalam
Guru's Grace is All

Prologue



Turn and Face the Light

Jennifer Jayanti Fitzgerald

*Dark shadows
cast across my face.
In the darkness,
a tear slips down my cheek.*

*Yet,
I am drawn
by a warmth upon my back,
Calling me,
calling me,
calling me,
to turn and face the light.*

*Golden glow
I can't resist you.
Every part of my body,
my being,
yearning for your warmth,
for your heart, for your soul,
Yearning for your love.*

So,
I turn and face the light.
A leap of faith,
a leap of love,
Your golden orb embraces
I yield to your warmth,
like a lover to her beloved.

I stand naked before you.
My one teardrop
now just a trace of salt upon my skin,
Evaporated by the light of love.

The light of love,
it has so many hues.
The gentle light of the morgen,
shy colours of the dawn,
dewdrop soft,
illumined 'pon a rose petal.
The honest light of the noontime,
when the clear, bright midday sun
tells it like it is.
And in the afternoon,
the western sun plays
with a palette of soft amber hues
that make me want to drift away...

And even in the night time,
as the sun's rays are fading from the sky,
I light a candle,
to illuminate my heart.

Turn and Face the Light

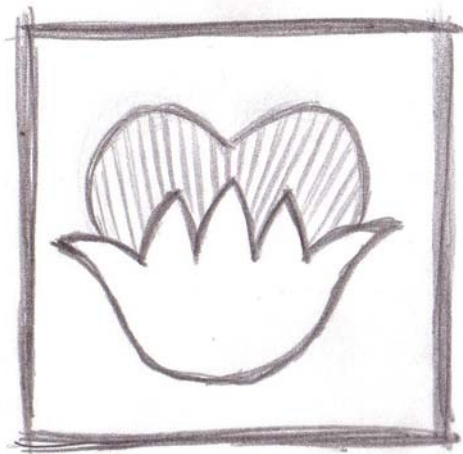
*Then, finally at midnight,
when that last light has been extinguished,
and the darkness descends,
in all her majesty,
There's a light
that shines inside me,
that carries me...
to the dawn.*

11th April 2000



Part One

Finding Our Way





My Path Finds Me

Gaotamii Pfeiffer

‘I’m ready.’ Not yet ten years of age, sitting amongst the granite rocks of our summer cottage in Canada – isolated, no road access, the ruffle of the lakes, soft breath of the pines, the quiet dip of a paddle and call of a loon, and occasionally, much to our interest, the distant drone of a tiny low-powered motor boat inching across the horizon. These were the only intrusions for weeks at a time.

‘Let’s get started. I’m here now. I’m ready.’

Fervent words called to God by a young girl in trust and full faith of being heard and accepted.

‘Where are you? Sorry, I’ve been distracted; I’m ready now.’

But there was no reply.

My disappointment, along with these words, was soon buried in the business of growing up. Those were truly

privileged days – long summers of canoeing, swimming, and hiking; the other three seasons filled with school friends, neighbourhood familiarity, family parties and all the dreams that went with childhood in the 'Fifties. It was quite idyllic. I never once heard a harsh word between my parents. My brothers were miles too sophisticated for the likes of me so I found my own pastimes and companions.

Those early years were followed by private school education in my teens, touring around Europe, then nursing training in Montreal. And all the while I was hearing from the grown-up world around me, 'You have everything. Why aren't you happy?'

Well, why indeed?

Yes, my early years really were a time of privilege. I had been sheltered from all the harsh realities of life and given the opportunity to enjoy the kind of worldly fulfilment that many would die for. Yet abruptly I went from that life of ease to having people die in my arms while training as a nursing sister at the tender age of 17, a change of path that echoed that of my namesake, Prince Sittatha Goatama (the Buddha), who forsook the luxuries of a sheltered and materially abundant life when introduced to the realities of poverty, illness and death.

To say the least I had reached a significant waking point. My need to know the meaning of existence abruptly sprang up before me and took more shape than the vague nameless sense of emptiness that had been my companion for so long. My quest for life's meaning continued on with me to university where, after nursing, I took a faint stab at an Arts degree. I see now that enrolling in university gave me



a respectable permit to be irresponsible – I needed time to recover from the shock of my nursing experiences.

My spiritual quest was intense throughout my hippie days in the 'Sixties and my subsequent travels. Time passed, bringing an impossible marriage, two darling babies, separation, then finally isolation – so very alone in New Zealand with two young children. My search intensified, become desperate, become unbearable in fact.

Finally I reached the end of the road. After a nervous breakdown I found myself with a rising tide of failed endeavours surrounding me. I had lost my health, my marriage, the country of my birth, the respect of my family, and the companionship of friends who were still interested in smoking marijuana.

Life had become so very, very empty but I'd finally reached some kind of compromise within myself. I had come to a point of no return. I had given up the search.

'OK, if this is really what life is about, I'll do it.'

Living had become meaningless, but I was ready to carry on my responsibilities regardless.

By that time I was very 'cool'. I had read all the spiritual books that were popular. I had already practised two meditation styles. I knew the *I Ching* backwards, listened to Baba Ram Dass tapes, and meditated (or tried to) while others were interested in entertainment of various kinds. Yes, I was so very 'cool'. Paradoxically, yet again I had it all, to all appearances. But internally I was also fully resigned to never finding my path, my guru, or the meaning of life after all.

It was 1974 and I was 28 years old and, totally unknownst to me, ripe and ready for spiritual picking.

It was then that I ‘stumbled’ upon a retreat being held by Ananda Marga. My vanity insisted I attend. After all I was ‘cool’, remember? And all my acquaintances just assumed I would attend because of my interest in spirituality which I hadn’t been able to hide. Actually, by this time it was an obsession! And what a shock had been prepared for me. A shock designed to break down all my pre-conceived ideas about spirituality, to empty my cup totally so that I could receive something.

I turned up at the departure site determined to be polite and distant. After all, it was only going to be three days before I was free to say, ‘Thank you very much, but no thanks.’

So there I was, walking up the drive, and the first thing I saw was a strange fellow in an orange shirt playing a broken-down guitar with only a few strings and singing very loudly. Definitely not cool. Then he spoke – in a Texan drawl!

‘What in the world have we here?’ I thought.

My scorn quickly turned to alarm when I discovered he was the teacher for the weekend. Then I learned we were all to call him ‘Dada’, meaning ‘elder brother’, which sounded suspiciously like baby-talk to my already disturbed mind. People were running around apparently clicking their heels and bowing to one another even when they were just asking whether the car had petrol or where the carrots had been put. Actually they were greeting each other with the spiritual salutation of *namaskar*, but my nerves were getting the better of me and my perception was tinted by a spot of total paranoia, which I was sure I was hiding valiantly beneath a composed demeanour.



Eventually we were off in a ragged procession of cars. At the time I was feeling very critical and unsympathetic, not willing to acknowledge just how chaotic organising such an event usually is.

Down the road, down the highway, along a dusty lane, over a sweet little bridge and then, after not too long, we arrived at a secluded set of cabins in the woods. One could not wish for a more heavenly place. We were enclosed by a massive cathedral of New Zealand canopy, accompanied by the lull of a meandering river to soothe the soul and that ever-present silence that permeates the sounds of nature.

However I was still acutely uncomfortable. I kept apart from all group activities – the *kiirtan* and group meditations. My inner tension was thriving. Only on the second day, after repeated requests from one fellow, did I finally accept the opportunity to speak with Dada about my meditation. I actually thought I was doing him a favour – such arrogance, but only due to ignorance as I later realised.

Dada sat before me and asked me, with a purity to which I was unaccustomed in most men, ‘My sister, can I help you?’

I fell into a rush of tears and blubbered that, try as I might, I couldn’t meditate properly but if I didn’t I felt I’d die, and that when I closed my eyes I went insane, and what, oh what, was I to do? He smiled and answered, ‘That’s a very good sign.’

‘No, it’s not good. It’s awful,’ I complained.

We talked for a long time. That talk softened me and opened my heart in a way which I cannot describe. My pride, which had been doing a pretty bad job of protecting

me, melted and was replaced by a genuine willingness to learn.

Interestingly, in the week before this retreat I had woken one morning after an odd dream. ‘Hmpff, fairies dancing on the grass – strange dream.’ And I promptly forgot it.

At the retreat I recognised that my dream had been a preview of *kiirtan*, the chanting and dancing meditation we were taught there. I also recognised, from somewhere, the bath mantra I heard being sung in an adjacent shower. I found that in fact I could sing the entire thing myself! Extra-cerebral memory I believe it’s called. I saw a photograph of the Ananda Marga Master inside a book jacket on display and thought, ‘that one’s familiar’. And the people at the retreat, they too seemed familiar, and the ideas and philosophy, also familiar.

But still I fought it. After so many years of struggle, I did not want to fool myself and surrender to a nice haven simply out of a desire to belong, or just out of the weariness borne of a long search. So, coldly and doggedly, I fought it. However I could not fight the attractive power of my Guru – the Soul of my soul.

On the last day of the retreat, rain poured down on the tin roof and it was nearly impossible to hear, let alone think. We were invited to listen to a tape of the Master talking and then afterwards we might request initiation from Dada. The rain was a constant din. The tape was scratchy. The rain drummed down. The tape was in Bengali to boot and some of the more seasoned devotees punctuated its meaningless sounds by uttering, ‘Oh, Baba!’ now and then. Inside my mind a war was being waged, a war of life and death. Should I, shouldn’t I?



I was in a spiritual pressure cooker trying to plough through an ocean of doubt and fear. Finally, before the next wave of 'no' could stop me, I quickly asked Dada if he would initiate me. He took off his glasses and stared into the back of my skull, and nodded.

Such bliss, such relief, to go along meekly, gratefully, and enter the sacred doors of initiation. And so I became drenched, soaked. During my initiation into the meditation practice, an electric jolt of spiritual energy seized my throat *chakra*. The omnipresent Divine Guru was revealed, leaving me in a state of adoration and almost ill with exalted spiritual vibration.

I was home. Finally, and at long last, my Divine guide had fished me out of the boiling sea of my karma and set me upon my path, paralytic with bliss, but on my feet and on my way.



Love is the Answer

Didi Ananda Giitimainjusa

Love... The Great Mystery. All my life I had been looking for it. Towards the end of my university studies I was feeling despondent, looking back at my life and looking ahead to the future. 'If this is what life is going to be like I don't want to live. I don't want to be here,' I thought. It seemed so boring, so predictable – eating, sleeping, talking. I thought there must be more to this existence; mere physical existence would never satisfy my hunger for beauty, joy, exaltation.

Several years earlier I had read *Siddhartha* by Herman Hesse (1922). The human struggle and the possibility of a realisation more profound than anything else life could offer captivated my mind. It resonated with a deep yearn-



ing within me. I 'swallowed' the book in one night. For two weeks all I could do was talk about the book to anyone willing to listen. At the very bottom of my being a commitment was forming – a commitment to unravel the mystery of existence and to find out who I really was.

I grew up in a Catholic family. My mother, a very pious and God-loving person, taught me the first lessons of devotion. Every night we would pray together before going to bed, and I would sense God so near – a sweet presence. At some point the usual prayer did not satisfy me anymore and afterwards I would lie alone in my bed and continue talking to God. We used to have the most wonderful conversations.

The great doubt came in my teenage years. A deeply painful experience and a growing awareness of the tremendous amount of suffering in the world caused me to do some serious questioning. I asked myself, 'How can there be a loving God who allows so much suffering and pain?' Looking back now I can see I lacked a complete understanding of God and the laws of *karma*, but this confusion in my mind kept me away from spirituality for several years.

As time went on my distance from an awareness of God continued to grow. I was getting more and more depressed until the critical moment came, when I asked, 'Is this all life has to offer?' I seemed to be stuck in a deep, dark hole from which there was no escape. Hopelessness enveloped me – sleepless nights of agony and anguish.

Slowly, very gently, a memory crept into my mind – God. Every night I started to perform a little exercise that appeared to help. I would consciously relax my body, part

by part. I would slow down and deepen my breathing. Then I would imagine God was placing a sheet of light over me that protected me from all negativity so nothing could harm me. As a result I was able to sleep again – my insomnia was gone.

Not long after this I met Rekha, a young woman from my Spanish class. She seemed different – very kind and dignified. There was something else about her which I couldn't pinpoint. Luckily she lived in the same part of the city and we would always travel home together after our class. In this way I had the opportunity to spend time with her and to come to know her better.

Soon I found out she was a vegetarian and that she would fast periodically for one day without even water! Her commitment fascinated me. One day I decided to try the fast. It was a Sunday. It was going well until the end of the day when I started to feel very ill and I had to eat an apple. (I later found out this reaction was not surprising in a beginner. Toxins which have been accumulated in the body over a long period of time are released when one fasts, sometimes resulting in feelings of nausea, headaches and other discomfort. With a vegetarian diet and regular fasting, the body becomes more healthy and these problems disappear.)

On the following day, I met Rekha in class and announced, 'I fasted yesterday.' She appeared truly surprised. 'Really?' she said, 'Yesterday was *ekadashii*!' She told me *ekadashii* is one of the days prescribed for fasting according to the Tantric system; without knowing, I had chosen the right day for fasting.



Soon after I invited Rekha to visit me at my home. Our conversation soon started to revolve around spirituality – the long-forgotten but never fully abandoned subject. We discussed aspects of different spiritual paths.

At some point she started talking about her own practices – practices of Tantra Yoga. As she talked I became more and more fascinated by her words and the energy behind her words. I was overawed and couldn't speak. Wondering about my silence she asked, 'Are you interested at all? Should I continue?'

'Yes, yes,' I said. I asked her, 'Can I also get a *mantra*?' She assured me I could; in fact, a meditation teacher called 'Didi' was arriving soon. Didi was supposed to come on Wednesday. Rekha and I would meet at the class and then, so I thought, we would go to see Didi.

But Rekha didn't come to class! I felt desperately sad, so sad I couldn't understand it. I felt I was missing out on the most important thing in my life. But there was still a little hope that I would see Rekha at the Friday class, and that afterwards we would go and see Didi.

There was no end to my disappointment when Rekha did not show up on Friday either. Finally I saw her again on Monday evening, by which time it seemed an eternity had passed.

'Rekha, is Didi still here?' were the first words I uttered when I saw her.

'No, she left yesterday,' said Rekha, nonchalantly.

'But why didn't you come to the class last week? I wanted to meet Didi!' I asked, troubled.

‘Oh, I didn’t know it was so important to you,’ she responded.

I couldn’t believe it. I was dying to learn how to meditate and she had thought it wasn’t so important to me! Years later I came to understand that my feelings were just the natural feelings of a sincere seeker. God was stretching it out for me, to sharpen my awareness of my intense desire for spirituality.

Rekha was sorry to see me so sad and said, ‘Every Saturday we have a collective meditation (*dharma chakra*). You can come too if you like.’ Of course, I liked.

On my journey through town to meet Rekha that Saturday I was as excited and full of happy expectation as if I was having a first date with a loved one. Until then I did not know what it meant to fall in love with God. Now I was getting my first taste. My body seemed to be dissolving in an ocean of exuberance.

On that day I learnt to meditate using the universal mantra, *baba nam kevalam*, which means ‘love is all there is’. (My initiation was yet to come.) We also chanted *baba nam kevalam* together before meditating. Never before had I heard such a sweet tune. From that day on, I practiced meditation every day, three or four times a day.

On the third day I sat down for my noon meditation and repeated the mantra with great concentration, focusing on the meaning. Suddenly repeating my mantra became completely effortless. It continued by itself and the meaning seemed alive to me – love is all there is. In an instant I experienced a burst in the centre of my chest and my whole being was flooded with bliss – something I had never experienced in my life. How to describe it? Supreme



sweetness, communion with God, the sweet, sweet touch of God's love?

After a long time I started to think again, 'Now I know what happiness is. Everything else is just a shadow of this inexpressible, immeasurable bliss. Nothing else, nothing else...'

From that moment I had an unshakeable certainty that this was what I had been looking for all my life. I had received pure Grace and had been shown the way to God through love and bliss, because God is pure love and pure bliss. For many months I was in a state of utter elation. All I wanted to do was sing God's name and meditate, to find the Divine again and again. Often my singing would be interrupted by sobbing and tears: tears of longing, tears of love. They were sweet, precious tears, not the ones we shed in grief. I was transformed – a lover of God. I was drifting on a wave of great happiness, knowing for certain that God is here, was always here and will always be here, knowing that there is no power in this world that could ever take away my experience, my knowing, my assurance.

Soon after this experience, I received initiation. I was more than ready, overripe in fact. It is said that when the disciple is ready, the perfect Master will come. I attended every collective meditation from then on and I came to learn more about my Master, affectionately called 'Baba'. I was becoming increasingly eager to go to India to see him.

I had only a short period of time to finalise my studies and raise funds for my trip. The incredible speed with which I was able to do all this was certainly supported by the Grace of the Universe. Sitting in the plane next to a Didi I could hardly fathom I was about to take off to meet with

my beloved Master. I could feel intuitively that he knew I was coming and that he was expecting me.

When I went to his house for the first time I saw a crowd of devotees waiting for him to appear for his daily 'field walk'. They were chanting and singing devotional songs, according to the daily routine. Everyone told me to move to the front where I could be close to Baba when he came out of his house. I wanted to go to the front but I was too shy, thinking, 'What will I say if he asks me something? How will I be able to speak?' So I stayed at the back, peering with much trouble through the crowd, trying to catch a glimpse of him. I was a bit envious of those who were standing in front but my fears were stronger than my desire, keeping me at the back of the crowd.

This scenario went on for several days and I was getting increasingly restless to receive some sign of recognition from Baba. Something that would show me he knew I was there, that I had come all this way, overseas, to see him. But no sign came my way; it was impossible for him to even see me behind everyone else.

This was one of my first Tantric tests – to overcome this fear which was keeping me in bondage, stopping me from doing what my heart was urging me to do. After three weeks I was utterly restless and disappointed, with Baba and myself. Then an incident occurred that helped me to remove my blocks.

A woman from Australia was leaving the following day and had a strong desire to receive a farewell from Baba, some acknowledgment of her leaving. She was standing inside the garage peeping through a little window in order to see Baba as he passed by on his way from the entrance of



the house to the courtyard where he would greet all the devotees. We knew Baba had come out of his house but his arrival in the courtyard was for some reason delayed. At last he appeared, greeted everyone with his *namaskar*, and left in the car for his field walk.

The Australian woman came out of the garage, tears rolling down her cheeks. We all knew something very special must have happened. She told us Baba had stopped right in front of the tiny window where she was standing, pointed to a plant with white blossoms and said to a Dada accompanying him, 'See this flower. It is completely white. It has no spots or stripes at all. It is completely white.'

She explained that every time she did *guru puja* (offering flowers to the Divine following meditation), she was unable to imagine a completely white flower. Her flower always had some pink spots, green stripes or some other decoration. No matter how hard she tried, the ornamentation would not disappear. Baba had let her know that he knew about her struggle. The following day she told us that she had at last been able to imagine a purely white flower, free from blemishes or decorations.

That evening I felt deeply sad, thinking, 'Baba loves everyone but me.' I started crying pitifully. I cried all night; I don't remember having slept at all. By morning I had made up my mind; in fact, I was the embodiment of determination. In my mind I said to Baba, 'Baba, today you will have to give me a sign or else I will die. I can't continue like this.'

With this strong resolve in my heart I went to his house early in the afternoon to 'reserve' my place, waiting there for hours until the moment Baba would come. To my surprise and disbelief, everyone else wanted to stand in the

very place I had chosen, trying by all means to convince me to go and stand somewhere else further back. I had to really struggle to maintain my position. In this struggle all fear and shyness left me. All I could think was, 'Today I want a sign from Baba. Today no one will come between us!' As this thought passed through my mind we heard that Baba had come out of his house. The long awaited moment! He appeared and greeted everyone, giving his *namaskar*, but still no sign for me! Then he sat in the back seat of the car. The car backed up a little to allow the gate to be opened. The window on Baba's side was rolled down and suddenly he was just in front of me. He turned towards me and gave me a very slow and very sweet *namaskar*.

For me this was a moment of great celebration, of utter joy, the fulfilment of my dream. He had greeted me! A special *namaskar* just for me! He loves me! There was no limit to my joy. All I could say was, 'Baba!' returning his *namaskar*. From that moment our relationship was sealed.

The relationship between a disciple and the Master is a mystery. It is the deepest and most mysterious relationship – a relationship of souls, complete in itself. The bond of love is deep and strong, so intense that the disciple desires to connect with the innermost essence of the Master, which is Divine. The moment the disciple is successful in this endeavour, a spiritual metamorphosis takes place – a merging, two souls merged into one. In that ecstatic moment the whole universe is perceived as One, a state of Supreme Beatitude. This is the ultimate fulfilment of a soul yearning for God.

III

My Spiritual Journey Unfolds

Didi Ananda Laghima

Sometimes we experience very significant turning points in our life. The years 1986 and 1987 were just such a time for me. In 1986 I was a Spanish teacher working in Tokyo. But I was feeling a deep emptiness inside and I did not understand why. I liked my job and everything in my life was going quite smoothly. So why this dissatisfaction?

Trying to push this feeling aside I headed off for an adventure. I journeyed with a group of friends to Fairbanks, Alaska, at Christmas-time to see the famous Northern Lights. We were fortunate to see this amazingly beautiful dance of colourful lights in the dark sky twice during our stay. I was speechless watching the Northern Lights. For the first time in my life I felt there must be something beyond human understanding or human creation – some-

thing great and noble. Feeling that existence all around me I felt myself to be so small, but at the same time I felt so much attraction towards this greater something. And somehow I was convinced this was a good sign and that my life would soon change.

Just a few months later I met Dada, a monk from Ananda Marga. At first, I didn't realise this meeting would lead me into a completely different world from the one I knew so well. Strangely enough, everything Dada said attracted me immediately, even though I hadn't previously been interested in meditation, yoga, social service or vegetarianism.

I did not know why, but intuitively I knew that I would live like him and that this was what I had been looking for.

It was the summer of 1987. Dada invited me to a yoga and meditation retreat in the mountains near Tokyo. By that time I had learned a simple technique of meditation using the universal mantra, *baba nam kevalam*, and had learnt *kiirtan* also. I thought I would enjoy the retreat and I was not disappointed. I met Didis, many people from different countries, and more Dadas. I felt completely at home! During the retreat I was initiated into the practice of Ananda Marga Tantric meditation. Didi gave me the spiritual name 'Lalita', which means 'the one who dances gracefully'. I was happy, just so happy that my feet didn't seem to be touching the ground. I was flying!

That's how I was introduced to the spiritual life. At the time I had no idea from where that overwhelming feeling of joy had come. Something was awoken which had been hidden for so long deep inside me.



From that moment my life started to change quickly. New inspiration and a new strength inside me pushed away my old shyness and fear. I found myself boldly knocking on the door of a home for children with disability and another home for the elderly, saying, 'I want to do some volunteer work. I am at your service.' That was a totally new experience for me. Although I did not have any experience in this work, when I saw the children with such genuine expressions on their faces and older people confined to their beds, I just knew that my work was to be with them, to smile at them, to hold their hands and sing for them.

Until then my life had always been focused on myself. All my time, my work and my money were just for me. But that did not give me the sense of being connected – the feeling of giving and receiving love unconditionally.

I started to enjoy helping out at all the programs organised by the *acharyas*. When they organised a fundraising concert for relief projects in Burkina Faso, I was very happy to go around putting up posters and selling tickets. When I went to deposit the money raised at the concert into the bank, I realised how wonderful it was to do something to contribute to the happiness of other people even though you may not know them. I felt deeply satisfied that the money we had raised had enabled them to buy a new tractor, knowing this would help improve their lives. I was amazed to realise how such a little effort on our part could make such a difference in other peoples' lives. How significant, how important to think about the happiness of all no matter how far from you they may live. My mind was expanding with each event in which I participated.

As I was walking to the children's home one winter morning, everything appeared crystal clear and pure in the crisp, cold air. Suddenly I became vividly aware of the beauty of everything around me. I felt an over-flowing feeling of love all around me and inside me. I could not move for a while. I stood there feeling as if I had stepped into another world. The feeling of emptiness I had lived with for so long was totally gone. My heart was filled with a very serene, beautiful feeling that is really more than words can describe.

From the day of my initiation I continued my meditation without fail. I also spent a lot of time singing *kiirtan*. It was not that I could meditate well, but I felt a compulsion to keep practicing it. And the more I meditated, the more I wanted to know about my spiritual master, Baba. I developed a deep spiritual longing towards him.

One day I was offered a teaching position at a famous university. This had been my dream for so long and finally I was being offered the opportunity to realise this dream. But my inner voice said, 'no'. It was so hard to say no to that offer, but deep inside me I knew I had to let that opportunity go. I felt I had something more important to do with my life.

By the end of 1987, the year in which I was initiated, I heard that many people were going to India to see Baba, the Guru. I felt I must go too. After a long and tiring journey we arrived at *Ananda Nagar*, a large eco-spiritual centre of Ananda Marga in West Bengal. This was where the spiritual retreat was to be held. When I saw Baba walking inside his room, tears fell on my cheeks and I said to Baba, 'Why did I have to wait so long to see you?' I knew that he



had been a part of me and that I had known him at some level for a long time. I was deeply happy to see him, but at the same time I felt the pain of separation from him. I felt such longing towards him. I wanted to feel still closer to him.

Three months after the retreat I was asked to return to India for my social service work to be reviewed. I had to be there by the end of April, which is when the school year ends in Japan, so I resigned from my teaching job, looked for someone to replace me, and took the plane to India. To quit my job was another big decision but I always felt that someone was guiding me, so I did not hesitate.

By that time my future was becoming clear in my mind. At my first retreat, when I had been initiated, the idea had entered my mind that I would become a Didi. At that time I had told myself, 'What are you thinking? You only met a Didi yesterday for the first time!' and I did not think about it any further. But from then on everything unfolded as though this was what I was supposed to do.

To leave everything I had and become a renunciate, dedicating my life to the uplifting of society, was a very exciting, touching and noble idea. I had always wanted to dedicate my life totally to something meaningful. But now I knew the way in which this desire would manifest itself. I used to think, 'One day when I wake up I want to see everyone smiling, everyone on the planet happy.' I had always thought that everyone deserved to lead a truly happy life. If I could contribute towards this, then my life would have meaning. I wanted to become one stone in an enormous pyramid. As we place the stones one by one,

some day a new society will be built in which everyone feels genuinely fulfilled.

I was able to make the decision to become an *acharya* (a nun with Ananda Marga, trained to teach meditation and yoga) because I felt totally secure and clear. I felt I was not alone. I felt connected to the core of the Universe and I knew I was just an instrument. The inspiration, the strength for me to follow this path came straight from that Cosmic force. There was nothing to be afraid of. Never before had I experienced such a mental state – so calm, serene and peaceful, and yet full of love and feeling for everything. There was no scope for self-pity or negative feelings. From where did this state of mind come? Was it hidden inside me? Yes, it was in me and finally it had been awakened.

After completing my *acharya* training I flew from India to New York in February 1990. From there I went to my first posting as a nun, in Guatemala. There I had so many totally new experiences, but what I remember most were the intense struggles I had and the immense satisfaction I got from those struggles.

One of the elder Didis introduced me to the Margiis and the projects in the area. One of the services we provided was distributing free vegetarian food to people in need. We would go to a huge market and ask for donations of food, carrying the donations back to our centre by bus. The bus station was several blocks away from the market. Often we were given vegetables in two or more huge sacks that seemed to be bigger than ourselves. Carrying them to the bus and then from the bus stop to our house was literally a backbreaking experience. After the elder Didi left for her new posting I had to manage everything by myself. But



when I distributed food to the village people while singing *baba nam kevalam* and saw the faces of the children, mothers and others, all my pain vanished. I could feel they thought this food was very special.

During the years I have worked as an *acharya* I have worked in many areas of service. I have distributed food, clothing, and medicine; run schools; and taught yoga and meditation. At the same time my understanding of my true Self, of the universe and the whole of creation and its interconnectedness, has become deeper and deeper. There have been many times when I have found it difficult to see myself clearly and to understand how to change the way I think and behave. But as my mind expands I cannot help but recognise my limitations and fight to go beyond them. And throughout this process I have developed more and more faith in my Guru.

At one time I had a pressing need for a car to fulfil my responsibilities, so I decided to buy one. I had a firm determination to achieve my goal and I raised the funds I needed. I picked up my car in Denver, USA, and was determined to drive to South Dakota that same day. I measured the distance on the map and calculated it would take about 12 hours to complete the journey. I was a new driver, and I had never driven on a highway. When I started out, I said to Baba in my mind, 'Now it's only you and me. Please take care of me.'

After driving for about three hours I came to a construction area. The road became very narrow. I slowed down but I hit one of the poles dividing the road. The car zig-zagged and finally it went off the road and rolled, coming to rest on its side. I was suspended inside, held in place by

the seat belt. The door was above my head but my arm was hurting too much to push the door open. One of the construction workers helped me from the car. The car was completely smashed. Luckily I had only some bruises and neck pain and nothing was broken.

Strangely, when the car was rolling my mind was totally still. I could clearly see the grass and sand through the windscreen, and I felt no shock at all. My breathing, my heart beat, everything was calmer than ever. I realised that when our mind is very closely connected to the Cosmic entity, we can remain undisturbed even in a most turbulent situation.

*I want to be like you
One of the million shells on the beach
You are the most ordinary
Yet when I pick you up in my hand
You are unique, the only one in the universe*

*I want to be like you
One of the million stars in the sky
You look so small
Yet your light shines through
And reaches into every entity's heart*

*I want to be like you
One tiny flower in the garden
People hardly notice you
Yet you add beauty to the whole garden
With your gentleness and sweetness
You are special, simply because
You are what you are.*

IV

Homeward Bound!

Didi Ananda Ragamaya

Here I was, at the height of my longing and spiritual searching, in Macao, a small Portuguese-owned peninsula off China. A jumble of old cobbled streets and mission buildings, impoverished shacks, rustic apartments and huts shakily swaying on stilts. More recent, and most dominating of all, loomed the high-rise monstrosities wherever there was a few square yards of space. There was constant hustle and bustle, buildings going up daily, banging day and night. Tourists frivolously gambling away their hard-earned money, people from every nook and cranny touching base with this tiny tip of land, commonly known as the 'Soho of the East'. Everyone crammed in, squashed in together. And there I was amidst it all!

I was born in England to fairly open-minded parents – my brother affectionately called them ‘ageing hippies’. We were far from your run-of-the-mill family. My lunch box would include homemade brown bread, raw carrot and yoghurt. I was considered weird at school in those days, but no regrets – not now anyway!

I wasn’t christened although that was the thing to do then. My mother and father wanted me to choose my own religion when I was old enough to decide. My dad didn’t seem religious at all (more spiritual I would say) and Mum dabbled in different things, taking from each one what she felt was right for her. She went from Buddhism to the Bahá’i Faith to Christianity. I remember going to a Catholic Church up the road from us, but I wasn’t impressed by that ‘smelly stuff’ the priest dished out. It was cold, hard and dark in there, and it didn’t make a whole lot of sense to me.

Despite the fact that we weren’t regular churchgoers, the Christian influence was strong. During one period I imagined that God was an old man in the sky on a big throne with, yes, a long white beard. When it rained God was crying because He was sad to see what His children were doing, and when it thundered and there was lightning He was as angry as anything! But that didn’t make sense to me either after a while.

I remember always feeling that I was not alone and that nowhere would I ever be alone. It was good in one sense, always being watched over and cared for, but then there was nothing I could do without being seen! That small voice, my conscience, would catch me when I wanted to go a little astray, but it wasn’t always effective! I would suffer



deep regret at those times when I didn't listen. As in most families, we had our ups and downs and struggles.

When I was studying sociology at college my lecturer was very left wing and existential: 'You live, you die and that's it'. I tried to digest this perspective, but felt it was too final and left no scope for expansion. It was almost unfeeling. I remember taking a hard-line position in a debate on abortion, then one of the debaters showed some pictures of aborted babies and my heart melted. Surely this precious life is a gift from the Divine. This existential mentality didn't sit well with me. There was more, much more! My mind was bursting with questions. Who is God? What is life all about? Why are we here? Where am I going? What is my goal? There were so many questions!

I went to a Spiritualist church meeting with my parents, who were on their own spiritual search at the time. It was in a small old meeting room up some winding stairs. The room was simple and there was space for about 40 people. Mostly it was old folks who had come to hear from their departed loved ones. The people who ran the church were loving and sweet. The services were simple and every week a guest speaker and medium would come and pass certain messages from the 'other world'. Several times I was told my life would be dedicated to spiritual work.

There was an old suitcase at the back of the room, filled with books about people's searches and teachings from all different spiritual paths. I found these books very interesting and appealing, especially the ones on yoga. I even attended yoga classes with my mum and entertained the idea of becoming a yoga teacher one day. The main message I got from the books and the services was that you

have to find the Truth for yourself. From within. And to be discriminating and chose only the very best teacher. That left a deep impression on me.

At the time I was working at the Ministry of Defence. The sight of people plodding through the doors of the establishment, day in and day out, left me feeling dissatisfied. The appeal of fitting into the regular mainstream had barely taken hold before it was erased for good! This life was not for me. I yearned for adventure and purpose! I set out to cover the world.

I'd always been a lover of the arts and that lead me to join the theatre profession. Being paid to travel and meet interesting characters was not a bad deal for someone as adventuresome as me. I travelled for seven years through almost every continent, encountering new adventures and learning new lessons, each one helping me to understand more clearly what I wanted in my life.

When I left home for the 'great big world out there', my parents had given me a copy of *The Prophet* by Kahlil Gibran. It proved to be my most valuable travelling companion. Through my journey of self-discovery this book offered words of wisdom, love and peace, insights and perspective. Every time I read it, according to my situation, it revealed for me new meaning and understanding. I liked the author's universal spirit and deep love, compassion and understanding. I also found the beautiful artwork, with naked bodies merging with nature, liberating and inspiring.

On my visit to Japan I experienced isolation and solitude, and I learnt to be more self-reliant and strong. In the small town where we were staying, very few people spoke



English and there were no English books. Compared to Italy, which we had just left, the people seemed reserved and cool. No expressive gestures and kisses! I was forced to tap into my own inner resources. I wrote a lot and thought a lot. In the bitter cold of winter, I would walk in the mountains, not knowing where I was going, but somehow I would always ending up where I needed to be. I felt the infinite love and guidance of the Divine as I went through this very difficult and strengthening period of my life.

The time came when spring finally emerged after the long and cold winter. The cherry blossoms bloomed, splashing the mountains with delicate pink and white flowers. I went for my usual walk in the hills. In the warmth of the midday sun, my heart feeling lighter and more peaceful. I sat on a hillside looking over a beautiful valley, feeling the sun soak into my every pore. The feeling was so glorious, of unending love, and warmth and light. I felt such expansion and oneness and love for all. A great feeling of compassion and joy passed through me. I wanted this feeling to last forever.

Later in my travels I found myself in South America. There I was surrounded by all the luxuries one could wish for: a beautiful hotel, all the amenities I needed, wonderful people, and enough money to boot. But I was lonely and unhappy. I remember reading a trashy book about a woman who did whatever she could for fame and money: she had died lonely and unhappy. I didn't want to end up like that. I felt an emptiness as I drifted along with the flow. The yearning was getting stronger. Again I realised I needed to dig deeper. At the same time I felt frustrated that

I couldn't just enjoy life like everyone else. But the voice inside was getting stronger, and I couldn't ignore it.

When my journeying took me to Tenerife, a small island in the Canary Islands off Morocco, the time had come to make more conscious efforts to go within. My health was getting shaky after all my touring, high life and foreign foods. I started to practice yoga postures, breath control and relaxation more seriously, and my diet was predominantly vegetarian. I also started to withdraw and take a lot of quite time for reflection, although I was still pulled by the flow to a certain degree.

When the time came for my travelling companions to leave, I decided to stay for some more months. I had a few moments of panic when I realised what it would be like without them, left all alone. I realised I had connected my happiness to their company. Then a beautiful wave of peace flooded through me. My mind's voice gently reminded me that I would only find my true happiness within. For me this was a vital message – to know and to feel from inside that I could be master of my own happiness, wherever I was and in whatever circumstances. I decided that from now on I would only travel in order to deepen my spiritual life.

I reflected on a trip to the Okavango Delta in Botswana when the group of people I was with had been pursued by an angry hippo. We were very frightened as we madly scrambled for our lives. Then I realised that life is one big adventure and that we are always completely at the mercy of the Divine. If my time had come, then I could have been snapped up by those enormous, powerful, hippo jaws then



and there! But the Universe wanted me to hang on and play in life's drama a little longer.

Whilst in Africa, I had met a very wise and kindly man. He had understood my inner longing and quoted a well-known phrase from the Bible, 'Seek and you shall find. Knock and the door shall be opened unto you.' So simple! But those words gave me hope. At any other time I would have shaken off such advice, but at that time the words sunk deep and helped me find the patience, courage, perseverance and determination to keep on going. I knew I was on the right track, and I knew that at the right time my Divine partner would be revealed to me.

After my friends left me in Teneriffe, my health declined dramatically; I found myself going deeper within to find solutions. I began my own form of meditation and gradually incorporated yogic practices into my life. I know this helped me in my long, slow recovery, more than any of the mainstream and alternative medical advice and treatments I received.

So how did my travels led me to Macao? From expansive Africa, a land of beautiful and far-reaching landscapes, of sunsets you want to merge into, a land full of the scents and sounds of the wild, to this tiny, congested peninsula, another kind of wilderness amid the crazy concrete jungle of activity in Macao? God alone knew! Amidst it all I just wanted to find peace. I wanted to find my true self, with all my heart, mind and soul.

By the time I reached Macao, I had already formulated my own system of practices and was sitting for meditation (of my own concoction) twice a day, doing *asanas* (yoga postures) twice a day, fasting once a week and eating a

completely vegetarian diet. I arrived with the resolve to be free of anything that stopped me from reaching my goal of realising God, and to have whatever courage it took to do this. I would be brave and determined and nothing would stand in my way. This was the crunch! So I dug deep into myself and trawled through my past. I pulled apart everything I could, endeavouring to embrace who I was and let go of useless rubbish that was hampering me from being truly me. Of course I have learnt that this is an ongoing endeavour! But I pushed myself through some difficult hurdles desiring only to be free, to be with my Love.

I felt lonely though, and desperate for guidance – a master, someone loving, nurturing and able to guide me and show me the way to my goal. In the yogic teachings, it is said that when there is an intense desire for liberation, the true master will come. Well, in my mind this was well overdue! I felt such a longing and I had gone through so much searching. Finally I had reached a point when I decided I had to have a guide. But not just anyone! I wanted perfection Itself! I was very clear where I was going and no obstacle, no matter how big, would stop me from reaching my Goal.

So when Didi stood before us, a yogic nun of Ananda Marga clad all in orange, radiant in her tranquillity, loveliness, simplicity and strength, I was instantly attracted. She greeted her small audience (there were about six of us in a very big sports hall in Macao) with a warm and deep salutation to the soul: '*Namaskar*'. My heart overflowed with joy and a deep inner knowing. 'Yes! This is it! I have truly come home!' Every cell in my body was jumping for joy and tears of relief welled up in my eyes. I was home!



Who could possibly have imagined that a simple *namaskar* and a warm compassionate smile would captivate my heart forever? Oh, and what joy! To know, yes, to really know. To step forward without trepidation and know nothing could be more meaningful, more precious. I felt stripped naked, like a newborn baby. My life was only just beginning: an exquisite journey back to my Beloved.

Didi gave me a book to read, *The Thoughts of PR Sarkar* (1985), a short collection of quotes from her Guru, Prabhat Rainjan Sarkar. I opened the first page and there he was, looking right at me from a photograph, a very familiar face with an amused half-smile and loving eyes. Yes, I had seen that face before. We weren't strangers. During my longing and searching for my master, I had focused on my third eye and demanded, 'OK, so show yourself!' I had concentrated hard and willed my master to appear. And so he had, but I could not believe my eyes and shrugged this vision off as my imagination. I was expecting someone with flowing robes and long hair. He didn't match my idea of what my master would look like. My ego too large and my mind not wholly ready to accept, I had brushed him away, just like that! He had also known it was not time yet.

But now this same face was smiling at me from the pages of the book. Now the time was right and I was more than ready to embrace him.

So my master had found me. I had searched and begged, rebelled and played and called – yet, nothing! Only when God wanted, no sooner. He came and took me onto his lap and gently chided me for being away so long. Smiled and embraced me sweetly and lovingly like no other could. Placed me in the flower garden of his heart

and allowed this wild flower to blossom. It was only God's Grace and nothing more, for I felt humbled to bare myself to him with all my imperfections. How could I possibly deserve this unbounded love and grace that was pouring down on me, washing over me, nourishing me, purifying me? Still, my most precious Love took me in and accepted me as any parent would their child.

Ten years down the road, I am now a Tantric nun. I have come to understand that the Tantric path is far from free from challenges, that the journey to God is strewn with rocks, boulders and enormous mountains to be overcome. In fact, I find that the intensity of the challenges increases, as does my capacity to overcome the obstacles. At times, as I am thrown into the most rocky and dangerous rapids, it feels almost impossible to hang on, but somehow I always find that the strength I need comes to me. And through the anguish and trauma of it all God is there, touching me with that ever-sweet compassionate love.

So now I understand what brought me to that little tip of land in Macau. On that enchanted piece of soil I was to receive my spiritual initiation, to be reunited with my master. Macau was a constant reminder to me that within all the haste of the world, true peace is an internal affair.

When I look at my Guru's photo before I sleep at night, I feel comforted by the knowledge that I will never be alone. Whatever strength I need God will have to provide it, and of course it always comes.

The only entity I can ever hope to please is God, who is my everything. I know God will put up with me no matter what: such is our divine marriage!

V

The Mirror at the Crossroads

Didi Ananda Devapriya

I had always been a shy, introverted and reflective child, but this intensified as I entered the self-consciousness of my early teens, when I was struggling to fit in and discover myself. In my earliest memories I recall lying in bed at night contemplating what existed before the universe and who I was before I was born. I felt somehow different from other children my age, and I felt more comfortable talking with adults than other kids.

When I was 15, I became interested in exploring and developing a personal relationship with God. I read a book on prayer and meditation given to me by my Jesuit uncle. I

had always been confused by the concept of prayer. Simply reciting formal prayers or a list of requests did not help me to feel or experience God's presence very deeply. Yet this book inspired me, because it suggested I should just talk to God as my closest friend, and listen to and trust the response I felt within.

So on my long walks to the bus stop I would just talk to God within about whatever was on my mind. I began to feel a presence, listening and guiding me lovingly.

That autumn, while I visiting my grandparents for Thanksgiving, I began to contemplate and realise the power of Love. I felt as if smitten with heartsickness over my first crush. I stayed up late into the night and wrote as an enchanting and powerful flow of insights about Love and God streamed through me. I felt an awakening of energy and excitement swirling in my body; I felt radiant with universal Love. I slept very little that night, absorbed in these thoughts.

These insights and this energy continued building in me during the following weeks. I was a swimmer, training at five o'clock each morning before school began. As I flowed through the water, I discovered an integrated harmony between my breathing and my body and the water, a oneness, a perfect grace that could flow endlessly and tirelessly.

I was also awakening to music and rhythm for the first time. I felt so energised by life that instead of sleeping I would lie awake deep into the night listening to music, endlessly fascinated, picking out different layers and textures of rhythm and melody. I found myself freely experimenting with my style of dress, with music, with art.



I felt I was discovering something new and powerful and beautiful inside. As the insights continued, I felt as if this energy that had awakened in me was spiralling higher and higher. I did not know where it was taking me. It was fascinating and beautiful, but I could no longer concentrate or focus properly on my schoolwork. I became entranced by the feeling that the universe was communicating insights to me through symbols and signs in everything around me.

Something special and unusual seemed to be unfolding, and I began to wonder what it meant. Could it be that this is what prophets or saints experienced when they felt God? Was I being chosen? Was it blasphemous to have such thoughts or to think of myself in this context? Could I be something divine? But how could this be possible? My Catholic upbringing had never taught me that God could be inside me. In fact, such a thought seemed potentially dangerous and heretical. Confusion, rooted in the irrational dogmas I had grown up with, began distorting my experience.

I began to think the world around me was a divine conspiracy designed to bring me to meet my Beloved. A palpable feeling of imminence grew. Simultaneously I was losing my grasp on ordinary reality and began slipping more deeply into an altered state. The insights and energy were still spiralling higher and higher. I felt God was physically present everywhere, permeating everything, communicating with me through every thing. It seemed that so much meaning was contained even in each letter of the alphabet that I could not contain it. I felt no human being could possibly attain this kind of knowledge and

remain alive. So I somehow concluded that I must be about to die, and I prepared myself.

I lay down on my bed and slowed my breathing. I tried to consciously suspend my breathing so that I could die and pass through the gates of this life to be united with my Beloved. Yet however much I tried, my breathing would not stop completely. No radical or sudden transformation of my body or surroundings took place. But this did not deter me. After some time I concluded I must have died, but I was mystified to discover that the afterworld looked just the same as my previous world. However now I was completely absorbed in my own subjective version of this world, as if in a dream.

About this time, my parents realised something strange was going on. They must have gotten a shock when they found my room a shambles, with me busy organising objects and bits of paper into elaborate patterns according to symbolic meanings. That night my parents took me to the hospital emergency room, and there the waking dream became a waking nightmare.

The doctors quickly determined I was not on any drug or the victim of a brain disease, so I was sent to a mental hospital and heavily dosed with psychiatric drugs. But the drugs only paralysed my body; they did not stop my mind, which was now spinning into nightmare. I was kept in an isolation room. I begged to listen to music because I longed to hear the orderly sounds of rhythms. But this was against the rules so I circled the room trying to remember songs to sing to myself. At night the convex mirror in the corner of the wall danced with abstract shapes of light and shadow. I



felt God communicating with me through those shapes, which was comforting.

I had no concept of time during that period. To this day only fragmented bits of memory survive out of sequence. I suspect I endured this conditions for at least a week. My only lifeline to reality was my parents' visits. All I wanted to do was look deep into my mother's grey-blue eyes, drinking them in like a cool soothing ocean. I could see her questions and her searching, yet she gazed bravely back at me, unflinchingly. She was my connection, my grounding link. She believed in me. She was so strong.

They kept increasing the doses of drugs until they finally physically overpowered and paralysed my body into a frighteningly frozen and deadened zombie state. My limbs stiffened from the toxicity and I could not move or walk properly. My mouth felt like it was stuffed with cotton wool. A dense, deadening fuzziness blocked out my capacity to think. It was like living in a waking hell.

When the drug-induced stupor lifted a little, I came to realise I was locked up without even the freedom to breathe the air outside or go to the bathroom alone. The whole world that only days ago had been glistening with magical vibrancy was now grey, lifeless and dead. The glow had disappeared. Now I was a prisoner of a world that was bleak, heavy and oppressive.

As the effects of the drugs began to subside, I struggled to clear my thoughts and get out of that place. I just wanted to get home and be surrounded by my books and music and things, and to see my friends. I felt this would ground me. I couldn't relate to the other people in the psychiatric unit; none of them had experienced anything like what I'd

just gone through. Many of them had survived horrific abuse, or attempted suicide, or been heavily addicted to drugs. They smoked constantly, and watched TV or played ping-pong. I don't remember much from my meetings with the psychiatrists. They found no explanation for my experience. After a few weeks I was released to go home.

My mother had arranged for the priest from our church to visit me. As I sat with him in the living room, so many questions haunted me but it was difficult to find the words to express my confusion. When I tried to describe my experience the words were flat, hollow and one-dimensional. I knew what I was saying sounded 'crazy'.

He seemed genuinely concerned, but I could tell he could not understand what I had felt – and that he had never felt anything similar. I had been so sure I was communicating with God, I had felt so close to God. With anguished hope I asked this priest if he thought I really had been close to God. He said no.

I felt crushed and bewildered. God had retreated into some incomprehensible, impersonal place, unreachable by ordinary people. The Divine felt so far away. I felt lost, alone and shipwrecked. I had hoped that a spiritual person would have understood my experience, which the doctors and psychiatrists had been unable to understand. But as this priest spoke of delusions and hallucinations, I felt my world falling away from me. I felt betrayed.

When the drugs wore off a few weeks later, the experience returned and my thoughts again began to spiral. I was terrified. If my experience of God really had been delusional, I feared I was being possessed by something powerful and evil. With drugs from the doctors, my par-



ents did their best to keep me at home. But again the drugs only slowed me down physically until they reached such overwhelmingly toxic levels that they could not be monitored at home without risk to my life.

One day I escaped from my parents to be alone for a few moments in my room. I sat down in half-lotus position with my hands resting on my knees, palms up. Within a few seconds my mind focused in on an effulgent white light that absorbed me into a state of pure peace away from the revolving maelstrom of my thoughts. But my parents burst in, frightened. They shook me and took me back into the nightmare of drugs. This second experience ended with a much briefer stay in the hospital, but with a long-term prescription for psychiatric drugs.

When I had realised my mother was taking me to the hospital again, I had felt so utterly betrayed because she had promised I would never have to go there again. I had screamed and screamed and had to be dragged inside. After that, I think I just gave up. Only a black hole remains in my memory from that point until several days later when my father, showing me pictures drawn by my little sister's classmates, coalesced out of a heavy fog.

The most devastating aspect of the experience, however, was being told repeatedly that what I felt to be spiritual experiences were in fact delusions, that I had 'chemical imbalances' in my brain. This implied I could not trust my own thinking. I felt a deep fear of being alone or of thinking deeply, or even of reading, which had always been something I loved. I felt as if the solid earth had been ripped from beneath me. My spiritual faith was shattered, in ruins, labelled irrational.

I felt a deep insecurity about my own sense of self, but I had to ignore this while I tried to put the pieces of my life back together, one step at a time. I became more extroverted and developed a set of good friends. Outwardly I became more relaxed and confident, a complete reversal of my previous disposition, but inside I still felt tension and self-doubt.

A few years later, during my first year in university, I went through a deep depression. My life seemed hollow and meaningless and I lacked the physical energy to move. Even walking to work became such an effort. At nights, a nameless restless anxiety seized me and I couldn't sleep. I visited my parents at home, and they took me to a psychiatrist. Before I had even finished my first few sentences describing my feelings, this psychiatrist was hurriedly writing a prescription for anti-depressant drugs. Smugly satisfied that he had made an easy and obvious diagnosis, he saw no need for further discussion, and promptly ended the visit.

However the medicine was new and not thoroughly tested for side-effects. Within a few days I began experiencing strange drug-induced symptoms. My heart palpitated wildly, and my field of vision shook when I walked or moved my head. Bizarre thoughts came into my mind, including a strange fascination with the idea of hurting myself. I began to contemplate suicide. But an objective part of me was watching all this anxiously, and fighting hard against these feelings that felt alien and dangerous. I desperately tried to contact the doctor, but he was impossible to reach and did not return my phone calls. I consulted another doctor who changed the prescription and within a



week I had stabilised. The new drug gave me an artificial boost of energy and I felt my spirits lighten. However the source of the problem, spiritual emptiness, had not been even remotely addressed.

I hated being dependent on the drugs and how they flattened out my personality, so I freed myself from them as quickly as possible. I knew intuitively that drugs were not the solution to my problems. I also suspected the doctors didn't really know or understand what they were doing.

Anyway, I was able to function well as a student on the surface, but internally I was still in turmoil. I was attracted to a fringe, artistic lifestyle, rejecting mainstream materialism. I developed a set of friends who were interested in questioning and exploring philosophy, consciousness, values, spirituality, everything. We were quite conscious of the destructive and manipulative nature of capitalist culture. The music we listened to often expressed rebelliousness, frustration, cynicism and alienation. I felt comfortable with this crowd.

When a few of my friends began to experiment with psychedelic drugs, I thought they were crazy. Why would anyone consciously choose to go into a psychotic state? But when they described having mystical experiences and a deeper, expanded sense of reality, I became intrigued. I wondered whether these psychedelic trips were similar to my own spontaneous experiences.

Reading books on Shamanism and Native American spirituality, I discovered that in ancient cultures around the world, the healers of the tribes received their wisdom from visions experienced in altered states of reality. Sometimes these states were induced with herbs or fasting and rituals.

More rarely, initiation was experienced spontaneously. In those cultures such experiences were respected as something powerful and sacred. Elders would guide the experience to discover its hidden message for the individual and for their society. In the books I read, it was noted that such experiences would be taken for madness in our modern culture.

There was a typical pattern to the initiation journeys. In the first stage, the initiate entered an exquisitely beautiful and blissful state, filled with energy, secret knowledge and inspiration. The next stage, however, was the journey through hell, in which the aspirant faced and battled his or her deepest shadow. This stage was fearful, intense and dangerous. Often the aspirant had the sense of being killed and even dismembered, but after passing through a resurrection and surviving the experience, they emerged with a deep wisdom and unshakeable courage, and with a special sacred symbol that would be their source of spiritual power. I was fascinated. Perhaps there had been some deeper significance to my experience. Maybe I wasn't just the unfortunate owner of a defective brain.

My curiosity began to stir. I wondered what would have happened had my journey not been aborted by psychiatric drugs. Where would my experience have led me? I wished that real Shamans, who could have guided me safely, still existed in our world.

I began a few cautious experiments in shamanism with a trusted friend. She too felt there was a deeper spiritual and symbolic world that was more real than our everyday world. I was thrilled as, during our experience, a mysterious doorway opened up into the very same realm that I



had spontaneously experienced when I was 15. I felt awakened and awed by the vast potentialities of the mind.

However, at that time I became enmeshed in some unhealthy friendships that undermined my already fragile self-esteem. Towards the end of the year, those same 'friends' suddenly cut me off and abandoned me when I was facing some difficult problems. I fell into a deep despair. I felt my life had reached rock bottom, and I was drowning. I wanted to break free of the hell that my life had become; I wanted to reconnect with the spiritual world, seeking inspiration that there was more to life than just this pain. I craved a deep catharsis.

Then, one weekend while attending an outdoor concert with a group of friends, I had a severe reaction to some medicine I had taken. I remember gazing into the blue sky, and then the clouds changed into a peculiar flattened pattern, as if solid – like the ripples of sand under water. Sounds began to echo and distort. I started to walk home. By the time I reached the dormitory building, I could feel my heart palpitating wildly in my chest. I began to panic, fearing that I was going to die. I couldn't breathe.

As I looked out a of a window on the stairwell, it seemed as if I simply walked through a doorway into the same realm I had occupied when I was 15, as easily as if I had just remembered something forgotten. I recognised it immediately. I felt calm now. The shift was so easy, I marvelled. I returned to my friends and we walked through the streets, but I was no longer seeing the external world. Beautiful luminous forms began taking shape and I felt myself merging into an omniscient ocean of God-consciousness.

However, as we walked back toward our building later, I began to experience apocalyptic visions of nuclear war, and my deepest fears and insecurities began to manifest.

Although I was very silent and internally focused, my friends guessed something unusual was going on. They took me back to their room, hoping to keep me there safely until the experience had passed. However, as I looked out their window I was suddenly overwhelmed by the feeling that I was supposed to be here to help and love people but that I had done nothing concrete. I had forgotten my Mission, and so many people were suffering. I felt I had to go and do something immediately. Seized by this idea, I ran from the room.

But on my way out of the building, I ran into one of the monitors, who quickly guessed that something was seriously wrong. She called the police. The police tried to wrestle me into their car, but I did not understand what they were doing and would not cooperate. An ambulance was called and I was taken to an emergency room.

In the hospital, a team of nurses and a doctor fought to tie me to a bed so they could pump my stomach according to the hospital protocol. I experienced it as a terrifying struggle, convinced that I had been taken there to be killed. Once I was tied to the bed, I was overwhelmed by an urge to just cease to exist. I longed for it with my whole being, and at the same time I felt this longing was the most blasphemous thing possible. I didn't want to just die, because I knew I would just have to come back again. I wanted to go beyond death and not exist any more. I focused my whole willpower and being on this desperate feeling. I pictured that at any moment I was about to be impaled through the



heart and dismembered. Several times I felt and saw it happening and saw myself bleeding, yet I was still here, still existing. It wasn't working. Even when my entire being rebelled against continuing to exist, I was powerless to stop it. Something was holding me here, like a child screaming in a violent raging tantrum being held against her will, safely on the protective lap of the Divine.

Then I felt I was not even a person anymore, but rather a place: I was 'Christian hell'. I felt ripped apart and exposed; I felt as if I was the very essence of shame, self-pity and degradation.

By God's unfathomable Grace, two of my friends who had seen me being taken in the ambulance had decided to follow to support me. They came close to me and took my hands. They looked into my eyes with so much love and warmth, telling me, 'You know, we know you're scared, but you're going to be okay. You're going to walk out of here with us tonight.'

And they meant it. They believed in me. In my world they were angels, messengers from God. They were sent to tell me that He did not want me to feel such shame, that I was inflicting this on myself. He wanted to welcome me to join the world again. As they talked, thoughts of doing just what they said, of leaving the hospital with them and going back to my life, flicked through my mind.

But then scenes of wrestling with the police in front of a crowd of staring people from my dormitory flashed into my mind, and again I was filled with fear and shame. I felt I had ruined everything, that there was no way I could go back and face what had happened. I felt as if I had crashed

a computer and I just wanted to turn it off and start over again.

In my mind, I saw myself as a reptilian serpent with silvery golden-mirrored eyes. These reflective eyes were shielding me from having to see the truth, allowing me to hide in self-deception because I was afraid to look and see myself.

Then I felt as if I was lifted from my body into a luminous, milky effulgence above my head. I felt a voice speak to me, and I knew it was God. I believe this was my first direct experience of Baba's guidance. Later, I would record in my journal that I had met my 'Guardian'.

The voice said, 'You know, they are right. You can just stay here feeling sorry for yourself for the rest of your life. It's never going to get any easier to get up and go back to your life than it is right now.'

In that moment, I felt as if I was standing at a crossroads with two possible futures stretching out before me.

In one, I saw myself sitting catatonic in a hospital room indefinitely; drugged, uncooperative, unwilling to assume any responsibility for being alive; in denial, simply waiting for a death that would not come for years, without the energy or initiative to even try suicide. I could see other people treating me like a helpless child, bathing me, feeding me, dressing me and drugging me.

The other possible future was hazier. I just saw myself deciding to get up and live again. The power to heal myself was within me. I knew that although this same possibility would always be waiting for me to choose it, if I didn't act now it would get more and more difficult, as I would sink deeper into defeatism, abandoning my life. Right now, it



was simply a matter of getting up and walking out, and a normal life would be just waiting for me to return to it, only momentarily disrupted.

But I asked, 'How is it possible? How can I go back, knowing all that I know now?' My mind was in a very expanded state of knowing. It was hard to imagine being able to fit back into a normal limited consciousness.

And a reassuring promise came, 'You will remember everything you know now as you need to know it.'

Then He said, 'Look in the mirror.'

Although I was certain I would see a horrible satanic serpent reflected in the mirror, I did not hesitate. Immediately I said to my friends, 'Get me a mirror.'

As I had been completely incoherent and catatonic for more than an hour, they were startled to hear me speak. They stumbled over each other as they ran to find a mirror. I took the mirror from them, and looked. I saw only myself staring back, wildly dishevelled and with a blank, lost look in my eyes. I touched my cheek; it was gritty with the salt of dried sweat from my battle.

Once I had made the decision to come back to my life, it only took about 10 minutes to get out of the hospital. At first, I felt like I was still re-entering my body and reconnecting with my voice. It was difficult to find words; simple questions confused me and my voice sounded far away and alien. But I told my friends I wanted to go home and to bring me the papers. Quickly I signed myself out and we left the hospital.

That night, I wrote this in my journal:

I feel like I've been through a battle. I have. Every muscle in my body aches from the struggle, but my mind is calm and triumphant. I feel so healed, and like I'm finally going to be happy again. I found my Guardian this time. I entered the hell I've created in my mind out of my fears, and I survived it. I wasn't sure I would.

Already the details of my visions were fading because they could not endure in normal consciousness, but that wasn't important. It was like having a dream and waking up feeling you have learned something. I immediately interpreted the experience in terms of the mythic archetypes of the Shamanic journey. I felt I had faced my deepest shadow, lived through hell, experienced dismemberment, and then spiritual healing had come and I had returned to life. I felt the journey I had begun when I was 15 had at last reached a conclusion.

Most importantly, I understood and had experienced, from the deepest level of my being, God's unconditional love and presence within me. I knew without a doubt that the voice had been the voice of the Divine. I realised that even though the mind has the power to create elaborate, confused realities and hells, it is limited. Ultimately I simply did not have the power to end my existence. A greater power held me. I realised it was not God that created Hell or Satan, it was our own fears, self-hatred and shame. Even when I had looked at myself in self-loathing and entertained feelings of unworthiness through the image that I had become Satan, still God was calling me, sending angels, and waiting for me to awaken from my nightmare.



I had fought the battle of lifetimes. These centuries-old dogmas had existed and limited me, perhaps through many lives. When God spoke to me, I had felt so clearly that if I did not overcome these obstacles now, in this lifetime, they would not disappear. There was no place to hide; I would be reborn time and time again into the same complexes until I faced this battle and emerged victorious. Victory was inevitable; only the timing was up to me. God was with me, I knew it, and nobody could ever take that presence away from me again. I felt healed in the core of my being, and I knew that everything else would fall into place now. I felt so grateful to be alive and back in reality. I felt safe and guided and confident that everything would work out. I felt as though I had been given a new chance at life. I had been so close to throwing everything away and utterly abandoning control of my life, but for some reason I had been saved.

There were consequences in my daily life, but somehow I sailed through them as if on a divinely protected ship. I had been filled with shame at the thought of returning to school. At first there may have indeed been curious gossip and speculation, but the topic faded quickly from people's minds and I was not rejected as I had feared.

My parents were, of course, shocked and frightened, worried that I had become unbalanced again. It was hard to convince them of the deep healing I had felt. I knew they would never understand my decision to discontinue all psychiatric drugs from that point onwards. It was a monumental turning point in my life. I knew that the worst was over, but I still had a deep hole to climb out of and a lot of work ahead of me to completely heal myself.

This time was also the beginning of a serious and intensive spiritual search. I felt a deep intuitive force was guiding me towards something special. I did not have a clear idea of what I wanted to do with my life once I graduated from college, but I knew it would be something very different from anything I had seen before. I began a summer job as a political activist, and this awakened in me a feeling that I could be a small part of a powerful force for concrete social change. I realised I wanted to put all my energy into making the world a better place.

While living abroad in France for a year, I discovered yoga. By simply becoming conscious of my breathing, I was able to release so much tension and anxiety, becoming more relaxed and centred. I really enjoyed the way the exercises made me feel. At first my mind and body were too restless for me to even imagine sitting still in meditation. Gradually my mind and body changed and I became more and more attracted to meditation.

After graduating from college, I spent a year working as a cook, and devoted all my free time to devouring library books about mystics like Rumi and Kabir. I was entranced by their passionate, vibrant relationships with God, and by stories about the special bond between guru and disciple. I developed an intense desire for a spiritual master to guide me safely and deeply into spiritual realisation. Intuitively I felt I needed to find a very deep meditation practice; I was not so attracted to eclectic New Age techniques that lacked the strong foundations and centuries of experience of more traditional disciplines.

I also spent a rewarding month volunteering on a permaculture project in Belgium, which instilled in me the



desire to work as a full-time volunteer. Following a strong internal urge, I felt I needed to both create a firm spiritual base for my life and to do active, concrete social-change work – either in the field of environmentalism or in alternative education. As I searched for volunteer opportunities I was torn between choosing to volunteer in a contemplative spiritual community or in a social change activist project with a group like Peace Corps or Greenpeace. Although I wanted to develop spiritually, I did not want to neglect the world. I deeply wanted to be part of the important changes I felt were desperately needed in the world.

I moved to Chicago, where I lived on the floor of various friend's apartments. My main objective was to find my spiritual Master, and I began my search. Within a very short period, I had found three spiritual paths. Each seemed to feel deeply familiar with a strong karmic connection for me. Now I was all the more confused about which one to choose.

Early one morning I was writing a long letter seeking advice from a spiritual Guru I had met. Suddenly I realised quite clearly that no person could answer this question for me. I put down my pen, closed my eyes, and said inside myself, 'Okay, I don't know what form you have for me, but God – whoever you are – please just show me the right path. And please, don't give me subtle hints. Please shine a big bright light on the path and make it really obvious for me so I won't get confused.'

That same day I met Ananda Marga.

In the evening, I noticed a simple photocopied poster as I was leaving the Art Institute where I was working. Its title, 'Self-realisation and selfless service to all', immedi-

ately caught my interest. An intense sense of anticipation thrilled me and I felt, 'This is it! This is what I have been searching for.' And it was.

I ran breathlessly to find the room where the lecture was being held. I burst into the room, expecting to find it filled with hundreds of people. To my surprise, there was only a small group of five or six gathered around a monk in orange playing the guitar.

As Dada Sarvabodhananda spoke that night, I felt every question that had been troubling me was answered so clearly and perfectly. As he described Ananda Marga and its vision for the world, I felt a tremendous excitement. Already someone had put together into one organisation all that I felt was needed for a truly sustainable society – alternative education, sustainable farming, holistic health and spirituality. I longed to know more about Dada's guru. Dada described Baba's incredible creative genius and how thousands of songs flowed from him spontaneously. I remember thinking, 'This is the guru I have been searching for – he is everything I have been longing for.' I wanted to go and meet Baba, to stay by His feet and learn. When I heard that Baba was no longer in a physical body, I felt a deep shocking stab of pain.

But as Dada talked about his travels and adventures in many countries working for Ananda Marga, I knew this is what I wanted to do with my life. I asked him if I could come and volunteer on one of the agricultural projects he had described. He encouraged me first to first meditation and to come to their next retreat, and I agreed. Then he taught us to dance and sing *kiirtan*. I sang with my heart filled with gratitude and joy. When we sat to meditate on



the *baba nam kevalam* mantra, I felt the truth of the mantra resonate in the core of my heart, and tears ran down my cheeks.

Discovering Ananda Marga was like coming home to my own warm, well-lit home after wandering around lost in the darkness. I had long sensed an invisible force guiding my life, and now I knew it was my Guru, Baba, pulling me close to Him. For a long time I had felt like a misfit, and had not understood how I would be able to integrate all of my varied interests and talents to do something useful and concrete for the world. But now I felt that I had been prepared, through each and every experience right from my childhood, to live my life in this way. For a long time, I had cherished dreams of being part of a revolution in consciousness on the planet, without any idea of how to realistically manifest such a lofty goal. Then I began reading Baba's clear, concise and practical philosophy expressed in Neohumanism and Prout, and I realised I had found a whole organisation of dedicated people working to actualise this vision.

Within each inspiration that Baba sends to us, I believe, is contained the seed for its fruition, if only we are willing to trust enough to actively reach towards our dreams, no matter how impossible they may seem. My own life has taught me that, with Divine Grace, amazing transformations are possible in one lifetime, and that nobody is really ever hopelessly lost. It is possible to give up trying and to resist life itself, but I feel certain that everyone has the power within to transform themselves beyond their imagination.

God is always awaiting our decision to wake up from our own self-created hells and look in the mirror. We are loved, no matter what, and will find the help when we need it to overcome any obstacle.



VI

From Heaven to Hell and Beyond

Ivana Milojević

On the flight from Barcelona to Zurich I couldn't touch my food. I was feeling both as light as those pretty rolling clouds out there and as heavy as the metal that was surrounding me. I saw a clear image of myself floating in the air with outstretched arms, touching the palms of the outstretched arms of another person also floating in the air. Who was this man I had just met and with whom I had fallen in love, with such strength and such passion? What had happened at that conference to this perfectly rational and down-to-earth girl? How could I possibly even dream of having a relationship with a person living on the other side of the planet? A Pakistani living in Hawaii? What a joke! Even my best friends would laugh at me: in Yugoslavia, Hawaii is not a real place; rather, it is a metaphorical

place. A place beyond all dreams, but also beyond anyone's reach.

However, thanks to the modern means of communication, this man and I managed to develop our relationship, meet again, and finally marry. During our courtship we travelled all around Europe and also to Athens, where I was initiated into the Tantric spiritual path of Ananda Marga. Everything seemed like a dream – the new found love, the new found meaning of, and for, life.

As I sat to do my meditation I would feel close to everything around me. I was able to keep psychically in touch with the person I loved and always feel him close to me. Sure, the world kept on reminding us of mundane and materialistic realities – visas, fares, planes, phone bills. I always worried about what was going to happen next: where we were going to meet, how we could finally be together. It took us a long time to find a place to marry as most countries had some requirements we could not fulfil, such as certain documents or special visa entry requirements. Finally, we managed to marry in Islamabad. We had a Muslim wedding and were married in my parents-in-law house by a *Mullah* (Islamic priest). Then my husband got a university position in Brisbane, Australia. To be able to be with him, I left my position at the University of Novi Sad in Serbia. My family and friends all stayed behind.

When I finally arrived in Australia, I was seven months pregnant. I was totally unprepared for the horror that awaited me. My newfound spirituality was decimated with one blow: the birth of my first child. I had approached the birth feeling very confident, thinking I would use my mantra and wouldn't feel much pain. Naïve, maybe, but I



was expecting proof of my newfound belief that it is the mind, and not the body, which matters.

But after the first seven hours of ever-increasing labour pains, I started to worry I was going to die. After another three hours of excruciating pain, the only thing I wanted to do was to die. Obviously, I did not die; at the end the birth went well. It was all natural, without any medical intervention, and the baby was fine.

After the birth, I was so overwhelmed by the experience that I felt some of my brain cells were missing. I could hardly remember what people were telling me, and constantly felt in a fog. Lack of sleep, countless hours of breastfeeding, cleaning, tidying and washing made me tired and depressed. My husband was working full-time, and on top of that he would spend additional time meditating and doing yoga. I couldn't meditate because I was not sure if I believed in all that 'stuff' anymore. And every time I tried, I would fall asleep.

In order to cope, I went back to my previous belief system. I had been raised in an atheist family in an atheist society in the 1970s and 1980s when Eastern-European socialism was doing pretty well. My childhood was happy and stable. Through my feminist beliefs, which had I adopted at the age of 13, I found a more meaningful and broader life purpose than building socialism. I tried to live out feminism, both in terms of my actions, writings and involvement with women's groups and in terms of building a 'successful' personal life.

In Australia, I wanted to reclaim that image of myself through a successful and meaningful career at an Australian university. But no matter how hard I tried there were

always barriers. I couldn't enrol to complete my post-graduate degree because we were on a temporary visitors visa, and the cost of educational fees for international students was prohibitive. I could not get a job in the commercial sector because all my previous experience was at universities.

My knowledge of feminist and socialist theory allowed me to perceive that my personal 'failure' was in many ways the result of structural discrimination towards migrants. But even though I understood that my position was a result of the forces of patriarchy, capitalism and localism, the pain I was feeling was very real and very personal. I felt rejected. I felt alone.

I spent days and months at home alone with my son. My husband and new friends were all busy in their working worlds. There were very few people around me to whom I felt close. My Australian friends didn't understand me: no one thought of me as an unemployed person, they all thought of me as a 'mother'. My family in Yugoslavia didn't understand my position: surely in Western countries there is freedom of choice and the potential for the educated and capable to rise in society. In my home town, the rumour spread that I had married an Orthodox Muslim who kept me locked up at home!

It might seem odd, but at that time I was actually desperate to move to Pakistan. I hoped my husband's temporary contract would not be extended and that we would be forced to move there. People warned me about Pakistan and the poor position of women there; they told me I would find myself in chains. I told them I had never



felt more in chains and less free than I felt in this supposedly free country of Australia.

I was chained being at home, alone, taking care of the baby; chained because of my migrant status; chained because of patriarchy; chained because there was no one to give me a break; chained because there was no one I could talk to; chained because on one income and without government subsidies we could not afford childcare, and chained because I felt horribly uncomfortable in the artificially created 'play group' environments where lonely mothers like me are supposed to meet.

I also wanted to go to Pakistan to regenerate my spirituality. I love the sound of the Mullahs calling to prayer five times a day. I love the slow time there. I love the connection with people. I love being kissed by every neighbour and friend who comes to visit my in-laws' house. I love fighting with my mother-in-law. Although these fights are draining it is all about real people and real emotions. I knew also that she loved me at some level, even though there were things we couldn't agree on.

By contrast, in Australia everyone was nice to me. The bus drivers and people working in banks and post offices never yelled at me, like they do in Yugoslavia. The country is clean, our material standard of living relatively high. But I felt that no one really cared what happened to me or my child. I felt that if I died it wouldn't really matter. I felt like I was living in a virtual reality.

After two and half years of living in Brisbane, my continuous dissatisfaction and unhappiness finally manifested itself in severe anxiety, panic attacks and depression. I had just given birth to my second baby. She was a beautiful

baby girl, the birth was relatively easy and I was in 'seventh heaven'. This time my mantra had really, really helped. Although I was still connected to my body, I had also been able to transcend what was happening to some extent and had stayed pretty calm throughout the whole process. My sister was visiting and helping me at home, the baby was a good sleeper and good eater, and everything was going smoothly.

Then, a month after his sister was born my son started to cough. He coughed and coughed, month after month. The doctors said he would stop coughing by himself. Finally, after he didn't, they told me he had asthma. I couldn't handle this final blow. This diagnosis helped to feed my total sense of desperation. Only later did I realise the doctors weren't aware about how different cultures define and deal with 'asthma'. For me, asthma was a life-long, chronic and life-threatening disease. In Australia, every fourth child has 'asthma' – which for most kids is nothing more than an allergic reaction to weather, food or dust.

The birth of my baby girl had in some ways restored my belief in a world beyond this material one, then my son's illness destroyed it again. And again, not many people understood me. My husband felt I was overreacting. My Australian friends told me my son's sickness was not a big deal, that many kids and adults in Australia have asthma. My family in Yugoslavia was sure my son had become ill because he was not eating meat. They kept suggesting we were doing something (everything!) wrong.

As for myself, I was in between worlds. I would go to buy bread and could not make a decision: the white loaf or the brown loaf? The one I grew up with or the one all my



vegetarian friends were eating? White sugar, brown sugar or no sugar at all? Butter or margarine? Polyunsaturated, monounsaturated or olive oil? To cook or not to cook? As I write this now I can laugh at myself, but at that time it seemed that every little decision could mean the difference between life and death for my child.

I would try to sit and meditate but my mind would go from one catastrophic thought to another. As I was thinking those thoughts in the alpha wave, they became even stronger. I suspected the way I was doing my 'meditation' was causing me greater harm than good. Later I also became aware that, because of my fundamentalist attitude and my desire for perfection, I was always scolding myself – for not doing enough meditation, for not doing 'proper' meditation.

Didis or Dadas I spoke to suggested more *kiirtan* and more meditation. I could not bear doing more of my 'meditation' and doing *kiirtan* seemed a bit silly to me. In the very materialistic and atheist culture that I grew up in, even the mainstream religions were considered 'silly'. Alternative spiritual paths, such as the Hare Krishnas, were considered 'ridiculous' and widely mocked. How then could I do this chanting without seeing myself as a ridiculous and silly person? A person too weak to accept the realities of 'scientific laws', who wanted to believe in life beyond life, a world beyond this world, justice beyond law, morality beyond customs?

The longer I went on debating with myself, the more in conflict I felt. I would argue myself round and round in circles. But I also had many insights. My intellect told me that the only real truth was scientific truth, but my feelings

were telling me otherwise. I wondered: Why would I believe more in what I think is true than what I feel is true?

And how could I explain the appearance of my Guru in a vision when, during intensely unbearable stomach pains, I had laid down in the *shavasana* position (position of total relaxation) and focused on my mantra? At that time, I saw Baba come and slap my face. After that 'touch' the intense pain instantly disappeared.

And how could I explain the visions in which each of my children's names had appeared: for Saim, a year before he was born and, for Mariyam, the moment she was conceived?

During this first round of panic attacks I decided that no matter what was apparently 'true', I was going to have to choose the truth that actually helped me. I slowly began to realise that I have to deal with my self on all levels. The spiritual level alone is not enough. I cannot deny the realities of everyday life – of screaming children and the possibility of having to pack my suitcases and move to another country with only a month's notice. I also cannot deny my psychology, my personal characteristics, or the way I was brought up. But how to embrace them all and bring the many parts of myself into a state of comfort and harmony with each other? Well, I have yet to figure out the answer to this last question!

My life is finally starting to settle. After four and a half years of living in Australia, we have applied for and received permanent residency.

Just recently, I spent nine months working full-time and I experienced another round of panic attacks and severe anxiety, but without so much depression this time. I am



wondering why I am still getting these attacks when it seems I am finally living out my mother's script, which I grew up believing to be the 'right' one. She was a socialist superwoman: a mother working full-time, a political activist and a career woman climbing to high positions of power, including the ministerial level of politics. At the end, when her world disappeared in the smoke of burning villages in the war of a once peaceful and multicultural Yugoslavia, my mother collapsed as well.

I was probably lucky I experienced my collapse at a much younger age; my mother was in her late fifties when her world fell apart. At a younger age it was perhaps easier for me to let go of my values when the world around me no longer supported them.

And I've also come to realise something that takes many people a lifetime to learn: that having more of this and less of that is not necessarily going to make everything alright. Finding a perfect partner won't necessarily take us straight to heaven, as the Cinderella in us would have us believe. Having a perfect house, getting that job, building a career, a family or a community, having parents around or being away from them, living 'abroad' or living at 'home': all these factors and realities could be one way or the other without us being happy or content.

At the same time, I believe that just doing enough *sadhana* (meditation) and enough *kiirtan* is not enough to help us emerge as complete human beings. We are body as well as mind, spirit and personality, and we have to find a way to integrate all of these. We get petty and resentful even while believing we are all part of the one, loving and caring spiritual source. We believe in equality of all inanimate and

animate life, but those 'idiots across the road are really stupid'. We believe in equality of genders, but we support patriarchy in one way or another. We believe in equality of nations, but we still manage to comfortably live in Western societies while people 'out there' are dying of hunger.

The combination of spirituality and social activism in Ananda Marga in some ways helps me to integrate these two worlds. It enables me to remain idealistic without falling into the rhetoric of past and overused social movements. It enables me to work on my fear of death. The yogic practice helps my anxious personality. In an individualistic and atomised society, it helps me feel part of community.

As always, I still have many questions, but it seems that the right path is emerging. This right path is, of course, the right path for me, and not a generalised right answer to all the suffering and all the struggle humanity has been going through since the dawn of time. It is the path towards my inner self – the spirit with both heaven and hell inside, where both heaven and hell are within my reach and under my guidance.



VII

Nothing that Comes to You is Negative

Rukminii Athans

In the 1970s life was simpler. I was an only child and living with my mother. She worked during the day while I attended primary school in Melbourne, Australia. We lived an ordinary and simple life. My spiritual journey started there.

My parents were born into Greek Orthodox families. They were married young, had me a year later, divorced young, and remained friends. My mother, although not a practicing member of the Greek Orthodox church, respected other people's religious beliefs. She also had a curiosity about the mystical side of spirituality – that which challenges and goes beyond the bounds of conventional religion.

I always knew there was a higher entity. However, as a child, I could never understand why priests and people on television would say Jesus was the only son of God and that God only belonged to people of a particular faith. I also couldn't understand why the mere talk of meditation or of becoming vegetarian sent shock waves through some of our relatives. Surely we were not possessed by the devil, as some thought.

My mother and I were best friends and we would talk about everything – music, animals, people, life, death, reincarnation, and the possibility of life on other planets. It was all very exciting. She shared with me many stories of her spiritual experiences. One of the first of these occurred when she was a young girl still living in Egypt. She had been seriously ill and was lying alone in her room. She had a vision of a luminous being coming towards her. She said its presence was beautiful. The being comforted and reassured her that she would recover, and she did. Throughout her life she had many experiences like this one, and I was beginning to understand there was more to life and death than we could ever imagine. I used to wonder about the purpose of my life. This was a question I would silently ask myself many times throughout the years.

In the late 1970s my mother learned meditation and she started to have unusual experiences again. She had visions of a being of light, floating in her room. When she first told me, my immediate reaction was, 'My God, we have ghosts in the house!' (I had just been reading a book on 'the unknown' and strange phenomena.)

She smiled. Her calm acceptance of these events was reassuring and helped me realise this was all a part of life's



rare and special gifts. Through my mother, I met my meditation teacher.

I was eleven. I was sitting on a carpeted step in the hallway of a house in Brunswick, Melbourne. The door was closed and I was waiting to see my meditation teacher. We were going to meet for the very first time. I was a little nervous. I was trying to imagine what she would look like. I thought she might look rather like a stereotypical female librarian with glasses.

The door opened and there standing before me was a gentle smiling woman, dressed in saffron-coloured robes and wearing glasses. I could feel there was something pretty special about what was to come. I entered the room and we introduced ourselves. Her name was Didi Ananda Sampurna. She was a nun. We sat together and Didi guided me through *diiksa*, the ancient initiation process into the meditative practices of the Tantric path. There was such a special feeling in the room, a feeling of deep reverence. I can only express it as the presence of God.

Life had a new purpose now. There was more to existence than just working, shopping, eating and sleeping. We were to actively help others in society as well as meditate for personal development.

My mother became involved in a soup kitchen with Didi and would leave home with big pots of food to feed homeless people as well as clothes to distribute to people in need. I felt a bit uneasy about two women going out at night but there was an air of simplicity about it all; they had no fear, just a desire to serve. I grew to admire their humility, courage and sacrifice. My role as a young person

was to be kind to people, to help people wherever possible, and to do my meditation regularly.

Sticking to the discipline of meditating twice a day while I was still growing up was challenging. My mind was full of thoughts and ideas – what I was planning to do, when I was going to play with friends, when I could squeeze in a basketball game. Sometimes I would even wait until Sunday to do my meditation. This continued until, one night, I had a dream.

Baba, my spiritual teacher and guide, was seated in a chair. Children were standing beside him. He was smiling, greeting people with his palms together in the gesture of the *namaskar* greeting. Suddenly, Baba's mood changed and his face became serious. He looked into my eyes and with pointed finger, he said, 'Why haven't you done your *sad-hana* (meditation)?'

I was jolted right out of my sleep. This message from Baba felt so real. I tossed and turned but I couldn't go back to sleep no matter how hard I tried until, of course, I did my meditation.

After a short time I forgot all about the dream. A month or two later I was at the *ashram* (meditation centre) for a *kiirtan* and meditation program. I was singing and dancing *kiirtan*; in the middle of the room was a table decorated with many flowers and photographs of Baba. Then a second jolt came. There, in one of the photographs, was the exact scene that had been in my dream – Baba surrounded by children and greeting people. The very same scene! Only this time Baba was smiling.

On the Tantric path, deep internal struggle goes hand in hand with the deep love that initiation brings into your life.



For me, just as my spiritual life began early, so too did the confrontation with pain and suffering.

When I was 13, my mother became seriously ill. She was 31 years old. She was to spend the next two years in and out of hospital. Her heart was failing and there was nothing anyone could do.

I moved into my mother's room. I spent the next couple of years, every waking and sleeping moment, keeping a close eye on her every movement, including her breath. I would wake many times during each night and silently observe her breathing pattern, watching for any irregularity, the rise and fall of her chest, the flickering of her eyelids, any sign of palpitations. The oxygen tank was nearby, the pain killers, the wheelchair, the bucket for times of nausea, the tissues, the water and the telephone. I knew what to do and how to help. I carefully listened to her sentence structure when she spoke to see if she used even one word out of context, which would be a sign to call the ambulance immediately – her brain might not be getting enough oxygen.

This beautiful, strong and loving person was deteriorating before my eyes. My mother was now being asked, by the laws of nature, to surrender and trust her life into the care of other people. The laws of nature were asking me to surrender as well. I was not so willing to do so. We had swapped roles. She was now the newborn child and I was now the mother.

On three separate occasions, when she was rushed to hospital, I was asked by the doctors to start calling relatives because 'this was the time'. She was experiencing a lot of pain. I would plead to Baba for help and beg him not to

take her. Each of the three times, I was given a strong feeling of reassurance that she was not going to die this time. The doctors would come in and check how she was going and would say that now all they could do was make her feel comfortable. This was their way of saying there was no hope and that death was imminent.

Nothing that comes to you is negative. I mean nothing. All the trials and tribulations and the biggest losses you ever experience are gifts to you. You will not grow if you sit in a beautiful garden and somebody brings you gorgeous food on a golden platter. But you will grow if you are sick, if you are in pain, if you experience losses, and if you do not put your head in the sand but take the pain and learn to accept it, not as a curse or a punishment, but as a GIFT TO YOU with a very, very specific purpose.

(Elizabeth Kubler-Ross, 1973)

During these months, I felt an unbreakable communication and connection between myself, Baba and my mother. I knew from the very core of my being that she was not going to die, and I was relaxed and calm. She proved the doctors wrong. She not only recovered, but she was able to go home, baffling the doctors. During the third visit to hospital, my mother had visions of beings in orange floating in her room and beckoning her to come. I told her to tell them NO! They left.

My mother's illness continued. It was August 25; I was 15 years old. As I lay beside my mother my intuition told



me she would die the next day. I took out my journal and began writing a letter to Baba, asking for help and pleading for her life, but this time the answer was not what I wanted to hear. She was going to leave this world tomorrow.

On August 26th at six o'clock in the morning, I called the ambulance for the last time. Throughout that day and into the evening, she was in constant pain. My internal pleas didn't help change the course of events this time. I called our relatives. Mum called out to Baba. (They thought she was calling her deceased father, but I knew to whom she was calling). At 7.30 pm I was given the news of her departure. Life was never going to be the same again.

Throughout the course of the next 16 years, life has presented me with many ups and downs, ins and outs. What I have come to know as truth, no matter what corner of the world you are in or how easy or difficult the situation, is this one truth:

You are never alone or helpless. The force
that guides the stars, guides you too.

(Prabhat Rainjan Sarkar, 1985: p.50)



VIII

The Green Glass Ring

Kaoverii Weber

When I was eight I had a green glass ring. It wasn't anything special; I think I got it at a custom jewellery store in the mall. Still, to me it was an exquisite thing.

I grew up in a large Catholic family where Sunday mass was not optional. My sisters and I wore short, itchy dresses and mom brushed our hair back into tight ponytails. For my eight-year-old self, wanting to run and play, it was an hour of hot constriction: constriction in my clothes, the pew, and the drone of easily recited, meaningless-to-an-eight-year-old prayers.

But I had my ring and secretly it provided me with escape. We would kneel in our pews to say the acts of contrition and, pretending to lower my head in prayer, I



spied into my ring. In there the church was transformed. The stained-glass windows, inverted and glowing in emerald light, awakened into living stories. The chandeliers on the ceiling became a host of celestial bodies that danced as I squinted and turned my hand. Wafts of incense smoke mingled with the statues of Jesus and Mary until I was half-sure their mouths were moving, whispering to me. I knew this was truly where God was, inside a hidden world, a place of mystery and magic.

By the time I was 19, Catholicism's appeal was rapidly waning within me and soon I left it behind completely in a flurry of feminist angst. Remaining was a large gap in my spirit and a large question mark as to who I was and how spirituality would manifest in me. I moved to San Francisco and took a job as a reporter for a local paper. My work gave me the opportunity to meet various kinds of people. I dabbled in goddess worship and guided meditation, took Hatha yoga classes, and went to a Zen centre. But that inner world of my childhood continued to elude me. I touched that world of my green glass ring only rarely, in glimpses and whispers.

In 1991 I moved to Japan to teach English and to save money to do some backpacking in Asia. About a year later, I met Didi Ananda Kalika (*see Chapter XXII*), a nun of Ananda Marga who would become my meditation teacher.

Originally from Australia, Didi is a very low-key person and I was attracted by her simplicity and steadiness. At first I was taken aback by her orange nun's uniform. When she took me to the meditation centre in Tokyo I was a little suspicious, especially about the photos of the Indian man in funny-looking glasses whom I assumed was their Guru.

But Didi and most of the other people I met there all had a certain quality about them. It wasn't necessarily a calmness, it was something deeper; something that felt pure and honest to me. When we all sat down to meditate I was amazed by how long the session lasted – a half hour of silence. I had been to many 'meditations' during my days in San Francisco and also in Japan, but none of the other groups sat still, seemingly absorbed in something deep – though I had no idea what – as long as this one did.

Despite my reservations, I kept in touch with Didi and spent several Sundays helping her with service projects before one of the Ananda Marga monks asked me if I was meditating. I said I guess I was – I sat for meditation every Sunday with the Margiis at their group meditation. He asked me if Didi had actually taught me how to meditate. I told him she hadn't and that I was wondering when she would. Then he said with a smile, 'Why don't you just ask?'

The next week I asked. Didi took me into a little room at the meditation centre and we sat down on the floor. She asked me what I did when I meditated.

'I sit there and close my eyes and try to clear my mind,' I said, closing my eyes. 'And then I start to see this wall. I see the shape of the stones and the cracks in it. Sometimes I can see over it and sometimes I can see people or the sunrise on the other side.'

'And then?' she asked.

'Well, I sort of contemplate it,' I said, uncertainly.

Didi paused, as a small smile crept over her face. Then she said, 'Well today I'm going to teach you a different method.'



After receiving my first lesson that afternoon, meditation became a tangible process. I actually had something to do while I sat there. I meditated twice every day for 10 minutes or so at first. But although I was following the lesson, it felt like nothing was happening.

‘Nothing’s happening,’ I complained to Didi on the phone.

‘Something’s happening,’ she told me calmly. ‘Just keep doing it.’

Somehow I found the motivation to meditate every day. I think I understood that the way Didi was, the way the Margiis and the Dadas were, had something to do with meditating. And I wanted to become like that. It occurred to me one day that the wall I had seen in my meditations before my lesson with Didi had crumbled out of my mind.

Didi inspired me in a quiet way. It fascinated me that she could sit in full lotus for such long periods and that she meditated for several hours every day. She had so many qualities that I thought were completely absent from my personality. She told me meditation had made her lose a lot of her fears. At that time my fears were buried down deep and I was hardly aware of them; still, I was intrigued by what she said. And I would remember it years later when, as I continued to meditate, I felt layers of my personality peeling back like an onion to reveal layers of suppressed anxiety and fear. I was surprised to witness myself facing and overcoming these obstacles with a greater fortitude than I realised I possessed.

After a few months of meditation, I noticed that I had little desire for animal food, so it was easy to stick to the vegetarian diet that Didi recommended. A little while after

that, I noticed I was also pretty indifferent about drinking alcohol. I had always enjoyed partying with friends, but it had slowly become less interesting to me. Didi had told me these things would fall away when I was ready, as long as I continued to meditate. Slowly I noticed that I was sitting longer than I had before and that my legs and knees weren't hurting nearly as much.

One of the Dadas gave me some of the Guru's books. First I read *The Way of Tantra* (1989). I found it a little strange, but still something in it resonated deep within me. Didi had told me Ananda Marga was a social service group as well as a spiritual organisation. I was attracted to these two ideas existing in the one organisation; it struck me as commonsensical but also unique.

My body and mind were feeling better from the meditation, and I felt happy about participating in service projects. Most Sundays I went to the Tokyo centre to prepare miso soup and onigiri (tasty Japanese rice balls). Then I went with a group of Margiis to Shinjuku station in Tokyo to give out the food and sometimes also clothes to the homeless men and women who lived in cardboard boxes in the subway corridors. At first I found it mortifying to be around dirty, sometimes drunk, and often mentally unstable people. But I saw the way Didi and the others gracefully interacted and I knew it had something to do with the fact that they meditated regularly. It struck me that perhaps their teacher, Baba, was someone very special.

About two years after I had learned to meditate, I quit my job in Tokyo and went to India with the man whom, I thought at the time, I was going to marry. We spent a little time at Ananda Marga centres in Bihar and Calcutta and



then went off on our own to do some travelling. Over the next few weeks our relationship accelerated on a downward spiral and finally crashed and burned in the middle of the Rajasthani desert.

In pain and shock, I travelled around the country for three months on my own. Although I continued to meditate, I questioned my faith in Ananda Marga. What had seemed like a true and clear path had become fuzzy and tainted with heartache. I cropped my hair close to my scalp. I read *Women Who Run With the Wolves* (Clarissa Pinkola Estes, 1993) and cried. I could barely meditate but I could sing *kiirtan*, the *baba nam kevalam* chant I had learned from the Margiis that means 'love is all there is'. It certainly did not feel like love was all there was, but somehow the mantra helped me.

During that time on my own, I visited several *ashrams* of other Indian gurus. I met some interesting people. There were many Westerners who had shown up to study yoga postures or to sit at the feet of their gurus. And while it was a relief to spend a little time away from the chaos of Indian cities, again and again I was disappointed with the experience and thought the next *ashram* would have to be better. The people would be more down-to-earth, the teachings more rational and interesting.

After a few months of this guru-hopping I ended up back at the Ananda Marga centre, smack in the middle of a noisy Calcutta suburb. It was not an idyllic setting, yet arriving there felt like a long, cool drink after a blistering day. I felt that same connection I had encountered from the beginning in Tokyo – the sense of community and caring I had felt from the Margiis every time I had been with them.

I began to realise that my identity was changing. I was actually feeling like a Margii myself and my respect for Baba and his teachings was growing. But I had no strong desire to stay in Calcutta. I wanted to make my way to Mongolia to spend time with Didi Ananda Kalika, who had been posted there from Tokyo, and to be consoled about my break-up.

Another nun told me she was going to Mongolia too in a few weeks, and that I should wait so that we could go together. So I hung around with two young, brand new nuns. I shared a room with them, cooked with them, meditated with them, sang and laughed with them, went to the market with them, and mostly talked about Baba and Ananda Marga while I waited.

The younger Didi woke me up and dragged me to Baba's room with her every morning at five o'clock for meditation. The room was painted a quiet pale green and the carpet was soft under my legs. In the silence of those early morning hours I felt a certain gentleness and sweetness in that room, as if something very loving cradled me as I sat there.

One morning I woke just before Didi with a start, a very vivid dream on the tip of my consciousness. Baba was outside at night with many of his devotees. As the Margiis looked on, he sprayed water from a hose onto a sinister-looking building which sat on the top of a hill in a meadow. After he finished cleaning the building, he put down the hose and turned to me.

'I will eradicate all negative elements in society,' he said with a steady certainty.



Then, with a flourish he threw his hands up in the air and the stars began descending like large, exquisite crystals. The Margiis ecstatically jumped up and cried out in joy trying to catch them.

That morning my meditation was deeper than usual, and I understood that buds of devotion were stirring inside me.

I finally left India for Mongolia, a journey that took me through Southeast Asia and China. After a two-day train ride I arrived in Ulaan Bataar to a welcoming committee of Didi and several of the homeless children for whom she cared. During my stay, Didi and I spent little time talking about me and lots of time pulling lice out of the childrens' hair. She had about six girls living with her and 10 boys in and out of her apartment all day long, eating meals, getting washed, having their wounds dressed, and swallowing capfuls of homeopathic remedies. Didi's project, Lotus Children's Centre, would grow over the coming years to become one of the largest homes for infants in Mongolia and one of the most successful Ananda Marga projects for children in the world.

Through this service, my personal pain slowly began to heal. Didi and I meditated together and took long walks without much talking between us. In a rugged environment, dealing daily with the trauma and suffering of the children, Didi steadily glowed with sweetness and compassion. Her steadiness made the heaviness of my life become very light. Her devotion and determination quelled the pain of the children and, through them, my own pain dissipated.

After six weeks, I left Didi and returned to the United States, to my parents' house in Pennsylvania. My travelling was over and I wanted to settle and put my life together in a meaningful way. I looked up a Margii named Ravi Dutta who was living in New Jersey, several miles up the Delaware River. Conveniently he had a little apartment for rent and I moved in. My life was shifting and my meditation deepening – it was much longer and more pleasant than it had ever been. I often felt a warm, sweet sensation in the centre of my chest that spread throughout my body.

Ravi was surrounded by good people interested in meditation and social change. Years earlier he had found a little spot of flat rocks on a bend in the river where we would all meditate during the warmer months. It was near that running water that I first noticed that the glimpses and whispers of that world within my green glass ring had slowly transformed into gazes and song.

One evening, while meditating alone on the rocks, I noticed that my spine was moving very slightly back and forth. I thought I must be doing this myself so I stopped it. But when I relaxed the rocking started again, and from the top of my head I felt a blissful wave pass through me that connected with the bottom of my spine. Tears ran from my eyes as I saw Baba's face clearly. It was not the first time I had seen him clearly in my mind, but it was strong enough to bring the buds of devotion into a slow, sweet bloom. I finished meditating and sat for a long time looking at the water while a song surfaced:

*With the surge of the river
Your face emerged in the dusk*



*And you whispered your name
Then the breeze off the water
Kissed the trees on the hill
And spread your whisper like a flame.
It's because of you
The whole world shivers in love
And it's to you
I raise my hands and sing your mantra:
Baba Nam Kevalam*

I got up and walked up the bank to the path that led home. The long corridor, canopied by bowing trees, was shimmering with the lights of thousands of fireflies. I walked through them, feeling as if I was surrounded by celestial beings. The world of magic and mystery I had so long been searching for had actually found me.



Part Two

Facing Our Challenges



IX

Life is Beautiful

In memory of Didi Ananda Supriiti
an unassuming saint and beloved Didi

Didi Ananda Ujjvala

I was in a car with others travelling in hilly countryside. When the terrain levelled off, we got down. Everyone started walking in different directions. I knew my direction. At first my path criss-crossed with others; then I became more and more alone. The way became difficult. I had to climb, but I knew it was my way. Then a Being appeared and I knew I should follow It through the mountains. There was a ladder and I began to climb up. When I reached the top I knew I could give my hand to the Being and It would pull me to another level of existence.

She liked that dream and talked about it for a long time.

She was never afraid of having cancer. She said that whenever Baba wanted to take her she would be ready. Being sick, for her, was a spiritual journey. Many times she would tell me that. She loved life so much. I asked her,

‘What’s so good about it?’ She said, ‘Just look, it’s beautiful.’ She was so happy to be alive.

After the first shock of the news from the biopsy, done when she was in India in 1995, the path was clear for her. She said, ‘If I go, I will go fighting. Life is worth fighting for.’ Life, to her, was a celebration.

Cancer was a self-journey. She was confident she did not want an operation; she was determined to heal herself through natural means. In the beginning, she wanted to stay in India for the spiritual atmosphere and Baba’s room. She insisted, even though I pushed her to go where there would be better medical facilities or food. She believed the cure had more to do with spiritual vibrations than any physical factor. In time, she returned home to her native Philippines and the home she shared with her adopted daughters.

After that, it was five years of ups and down. The journey was one of healing the body as well as of looking inside. She travelled into so many fields, and read so many books, and talked to so many people about different types of therapies. She would try those she thought were suitable for herself, all for a while, with a passion. All those she chose had different positive and sometimes alarming effects on her. She followed Baba’s prescriptions in Yogic Treatments very strictly, which is almost impossible to do. It’s hardly humanly possible to find the time to follow all the things that Baba has written, but she did.

All the while, she never accepted that being sick should be a hampering condition, a limitation. She saw her illness as something to help spiritual growth, not something to stop her from doing work. Even if her physical body was



not functioning to full capacity, the mind was still free to be engaged as she saw fit.

She didn't see death as a possibility. For something to happen, one has to think about it, and for most people with cancer, death is the main issue. Didi lived as if death didn't exist. Not that she wasn't aware of death, but for her it had no meaning. She always saw the bright side of everything and worked for Him, even while dying, as Baba said He wants us to do.

Her strong belief was that as long as Baba wanted her to stay, she would stay, and that while she stayed it was her duty to do work. Part of the work was to make her body fit to continue working.

When you think that your whole life is in front of you, you delay many things. But when you know that life may be short, there comes a feeling of urgency, that things need to be done.

Her main priority was, of course, the children. She tried to imbibe in them firstly the values of spirituality, and also of human conduct. She was patient and compassionate. She learnt not to listen to other nuns who advised her not to be too close to the children. For Rashmii, who came to our home at the age of six months, Didi was the only mother she ever knew. For all of them – Bashanti, Asha¹, Sumitra – it was the same. These four girls are normal human beings because, for more than 16 years, Didi gave them the full heart of a mother's love. These girls had a normal child-

¹ Asha's story appears in Chapter 12.

hood, even though they bore scars from their previous experiences. Even though the children lived together with nuns and trainee nuns, Didi provided for them the structure of a loving family as much as she could. People would say she was too attached to them and she would say, 'Of course I am. Not all attachment is bad. The children belong to Baba.' She was hoping that at least one or more would become a Didi, but if the girls chose to marry and have a family life, she never felt dissatisfied about it. She just wanted them to be happy and to have Baba inside them.

Then there were the various community projects, the schools, the administrative and organisational tasks, and the care of other cancer sufferers from around the Philippines who would call for inspiration and hope. Can you imagine: even though she was often confined to her bed in the living room, even though she had to have people to feed her, bathe her and help her to eliminate wastes, she worked like a high-powered business executive! Staff meetings, board meetings, regional diocese meetings were held around her bed. There was an unending stream of teachers, school directors, construction managers, farm managers, Ananda Marga executives, trainee nuns and monks, trainer nuns and monks, simple Margiis, the children and their friends, boyfriends, potential husbands; all came to her for discussion, direction, advice, counselling, scolding. All of this she did in between the acupuncturists, the herbalists and healers, the physiotherapist, the masseurs and those who used magnetic and electrical impulse healing mechanisms.

And anyone would think this was the most natural thing in the world for her, lying there, at times unable to



move from the shoulders down, with people constantly attending to her suffering body, smiling and talking and joking and living and loving life to its fullest. There was never any sense that this was a person struggling with the pain of cancer and the risk of death.

For those with cancer who called for advice and comfort, especially when they were in the first shocked stages of knowing they had cancer, it was a blessing to talk to someone who also had the disease yet who remained eternally optimistic. She would talk to them for hours. Often we had to hold the phone to her ear and wipe the sweat off her brow with a cloth while she gave everything she had to help them. She would inspire all. 'Cancer is not the end of the world. Trust God within. It's an opportunity to grow, not an obstacle, not a dead end.'

In the only picture that I keep of her, she is wearing our 'volunteers' uniform and holding the camp commander's baton. She had the bravery, and iron-willed discipline, and determination to conquer, of a top-notch military commander. Before joining Ananda Marga, she had been a mountain climbing guide. She had a great love for sports and outdoor activities and physical fitness. She was the only nun of our order that I have seen who had the mentality of a military supervisor. The year she was in charge of the service volunteers' training camp, it was run like a military affair. The area had just been affected by volcanic ash after a recent eruption. Not much was growing. It was like a desert, like the moon. The camp was held at a school that had been evacuated and abandoned. During the training, as well as serving the local people we had to engage in many hardships, endurance testing, and survival skill

exercises; she made it tough, like a real war-time or crisis experience, not just a 'camp'. There I saw her as a completely different person. It was a chance for her to express another aspect of herself – not the soft, compassionate (even sometimes, submissive) aspect, not the high-power director aspect, but the adventurer-warrior aspect.

Part of our Tantric meditation techniques involve being in certain prescribed positions and surroundings for special, quite strenuous, meditation practices. Up to her last days, she was unwavering in her devotee's sincerity and warrior's resolve to follow these practices. Even when she could not move herself, or when she had lost the sensation in her hands, she would ask me to move her, or place the *mala* in position for her. Then she would struggle, sometimes for hours, to merge her mind with God.

There were three or four times during the last years that were the most difficult for her. When there was a setback, I could see her struggling to get the power to try again from inside. After a hospital stay in 1998 it took her three to four months to start walking again. But she always found the strength to say, 'Never give up, never'. She pulled herself out of any setback. Even towards the end when she had uncontrollable spasms that shot waves of pain into her neck, like a torture, she was looking for a way of healing it, not a way of ending it.

A few people who came and stayed in the house would ask, 'Why does she want so much to stay alive when she cannot move and people have to take care of all her physical needs?' I also asked her many times, 'Why don't you give up?' She would just laugh, saying, 'Life is just beautiful.'



I finish with a poem taken from Didi Ananda Supriiti's own diary after she found out that she had cancer.

*Before I go into fears, I want to express something
that has been within me for a long time*

*It needs expression
so much has overflowed
this stream of unexpressed divinity*

*How to describe in words?
Love, passion divine, inspiration, stream of light,
ocean wave forever cresting ready to break onto the shore
but never breaking as if frozen in time*

*A glimpse of something opening within
is it love?
so often tangled with passion
just something that expresses from within
an inner awakening
a combination of love towards one towards all
and desire
desire to express
to share with Him with all*

*(I want to say I love you
it's not something I usually say
it's my way to leave it unsaid
but for most, for many, for all
it must be expressed
clearly from time to time
for if the distance and time are far or long*

*the need to express becomes greater
or small changes within and around here and there
create gaps, misunderstandings, insecurities)*

*At times I'm at the wheel
I can feel it coming
I want to go into it
lose myself in it
above me
all around me:
But wait!
I'm at the wheel
What's the time?
I'm on my way to the school, the bank, to the store, wherever*

*Or at a collective gathering
inevitable when kiirtan is there
long or short
then meditation
which is always far too short
How to express this surging energy
it rises
builds, builds
Go into it
explore it
express it – the unexpressed
Where was it?
Just a touch, and life goes on
That feeling comes to me unexpected
without prior warning
caught unaware.*

X

Beyond Miracles

Jennifer Jayanti Fitzgerald

Out beyond ideas of wrongdoing and rightdoing, there is a field.

I'll meet you there.

Rumi (in *The Enlightened Heart*, 1993: p. 59)

'Ninety per cent of breast lumps are benign.' Even now, after all I've been through, I have no idea whether this statement is true, but I do know that I clung to it like a lifeline from the moment I found that small lump in my left breast. I don't even know where I first heard it, but from wherever it came, but I held it close, repeating it over and over in my mind, like a mantra, to keep the fear that was swelling deep within me from emerging.

That statement stayed with me the next day as I visited my local doctor and the following day at the breast clinic where I had gone for tests. It was like a pacifier you might give to a child, a soporific lullaby to keep my emotions under control. But as the day at the breast clinic wore on and I underwent more and more tests (mammograms, physical examinations and finally, a fine needle biopsy) that statement – ‘90 per cent of breast lumps are benign’ – somehow seemed less comforting. I looked around at the other women in the waiting room. There were about 10 of us there. Going by these statistics, it meant that probably one of us would be diagnosed with breast cancer that day. I was the one.

With that diagnosis, I stepped (or rather, was pushed) across a threshold that has permanently altered my life, my values and my spirituality. I have been forced to reconceptualise myself, to recognise my existential value above my utilitarian value. I have been forced to embrace my value as a human-‘being’ rather than as a human-‘doing’. In a world that values so highly what we do and what we achieve, this redefinition of personal self is no easy adjustment.

Not wanting to lend credence to the potential seriousness of what I was facing, I had gone alone to the breast clinic. So, on leaving the clinic, I kept myself together (just) until I got to the car, then I totally crumpled. The world fell on top of me. I have never felt so desolate, helpless and alone.

Driving home in the car, I screamed my rage at the Divine: ‘Why me? Why me?’ Like a faint echo returning from some distant place, came the reply, ‘Why not?’



I screamed again, 'I don't want to go through this!' Yet I realised that even as I screamed those words, the threshold I so feared crossing was already well behind me. Try as I did to hold onto the veneers of control and certainty that had been the backdrop to my life only three days ago, even only forty minutes ago, I knew that the plug had already been pulled and I was undergoing a massive bleeding of the ego, as all sense of control and certainty poured out of me.

When I arrived home, everything felt different. Things that had seemed permanent and secure – my home, my books, the furnishings, even my cat – suddenly felt temporary. With just one stroke of the Cosmic brush, I had been shockingly confronted by my own transience. And as I realised how transient I was, I realised too how impermanent were all the things that I had so carefully chosen and gathered around me. I felt myself moving, with a rapid intensity, into a new world – a world of vulnerability.

Twenty-one years ago I was initiated into the practice of Tantric meditation. I was 20 years old. At that time, I felt that my past was wiped clear and I emerged from my initiation to see the world with new eyes. A feeling of exhilaration and excitement accompanied my initiation into the world of Divine. Suddenly that spirit which I had felt within me all my life as an unnamed subterranean flow had been acknowledged and allowed to come to the surface. I felt an immense sense of liberation. I could feel this thing called 'spirit' flow through me in my meditation, in my waking moments, even during my hours of sleep. But now I also had a name for it, and I had a philosophical framework that affirmed it. I felt complete and I felt free.

There have been perhaps only two other experiences that have changed me so dramatically, that have felt like true initiations after which I have opened my eyes and seen the world differently. Childbirth was one of those experiences, an initiation into the world of unconditional love. Being diagnosed with breast cancer was the other. Susun Weed (1996: p. 192) describes the diagnosis of breast cancer as an initiatory passage:

There is no return for a woman who has passed through the initiation of breast cancer. Like menarche, like childbirth, like menopause, once a woman is initiated by breast cancer, she is forever changed, forever set apart, forever different from the way she was before.

For me, the diagnosis of breast cancer has been another rite of passage in my Tantric initiation. It has been a process of deepening my spiritual understanding, of my spiritual identity being made real. A process of being forced to realign all my belief systems with my lived experience. It has been a process of scraping out the old values that were born of belief systems that had not been tried and tested against the reality of life experience and replacing them with others that speak to the intensity of the life experiences I have had to face. I liken this process to having a philosophical debate going on inside my own body as my body, by its quiet, persistent, silent actions of civil disobedience, challenges every value structure I have consciously or unconsciously assimilated. It has forced me to challenge not only my own values, but also those social values that devalue illness and disability. I have been forced to do this



at a deeply personal level, not an intellectual level, but to integrate at the level of cellular philosophy the ebbs and flows that make up this thing called 'life' that we all live. It has forced me to a place of acceptance of myself and my illness that goes beyond judgment, rationality, causation, or explanation. It is like looking at the stars in the night sky. There is no room for judgment or explanation – they simply are. This is where I have been asked to go, to a place where what is, simply is. No more.

As the first shock waves of diagnosis receded I was faced with decisions – lots of decisions. How was I going to deal with this growing mass of clumping cells inside my body? I couldn't just ignore it. The medical professionals were offering me options – they weren't offering me hope, but they were offering me options. They spoke to me of probabilities, of percentages, of objectivities. But I found these of little comfort. I had already defied the first statistic – 'ninety per cent of breast lumps are benign'. Mine was not; so I could find no comfort in the 50 per cent five-year survival rates they offered me. None of these facts or figures spoke to my subjective reality, to my fear, and to my desperate need for hope.

At that point, I turned my back on everything conventional medicine was offering me. I elected not to have surgery, chemotherapy, or radiation treatment. I felt these treatments were born of a psychology of fear and control – a desire to root out, destroy and burn all evidence of the cancer in my body. I rejected this treatment regime as an expression of the myth of control that is so deeply entrenched in the Western psyche. As yet, I did not know how deeply I would be forced to confront this same mind-

set within my own mind and within the 'alternative' value systems I had embraced.

For many years before I was diagnosed I had worked as an advocate for people with disability. My work focused on bio-ethical issues and their impact on the lives of people with disability. I wrote, spoke, and thought deeply about things like vulnerability, the myth of control, existential value versus utilitarian value. I had had a lot of time to work out my position on these issues, to deconstruct the flawed social values that alienated those people made vulnerable by their own bodies. So I knew what I believed, but until I had to live these issues out in my own body, I really didn't know what I felt. Nor did I realise how many of those value structures, which I could easily challenge at an intellectual level, still lived within me at a cellular level.

When I rejected what conventional medicine had to offer me, I embarked upon a journey which took me everywhere other than where I expected to go. While I rejected conventional medicine because I felt its approach was deeply reflective of the belief that the body could be controlled, I did not realise how much this myth, though well disguised, also permeated 'alternative' treatments and therapies. The essence was the same, though the form it took was very, very different. It has taken me a long time to recognise that same basic human fear manifesting through apparently different approaches to illness and wellness.

With my diagnosis came an intense self-reflection. I went over and over my life trying to explain why I had developed cancer. I left no stone unturned. I looked at my diet, my thought patterns, the stresses and griefs in my life, my attitudes, my work situation, where I lived, my rela-



tionships. I was prepared to rework all of them, to remake myself. At some level I really believed that I was flawed and that this was why I had become sick, so to become well I had to remake myself. I felt that something I had done had made me sick and that I needed to stop doing it. So I stopped doing nearly everything I had been doing. I think I really believed, at some deep level, that if I became totally passive about my engagement with life, if I stopped doing whatever it was that I was doing ‘wrong’, somehow I would become well again. I virtually obliterated my self and my life in pursuit of cure. ‘Cure’ became my *raison d’être*.

I realise now that deeply rooted in my response was a sense that I was only valid or real when I was healthy. I realise now how deeply ingrained this paradigm of health is. This paradigm permits momentary periods of ill-health which ultimately surrender to a return to full health (equated with full validity) – a bout of influenza, a broken leg that heals with time. But what was happening to my body just didn’t fit into this paradigm. So I sought to control what was happening – not with chemotherapy or radiation or surgery, but with meditation, diet, visualisations, herbs, vitamins, massage and acupuncture, with practically anything anyone suggested to me.

It is not that these things are bad in themselves. On the contrary, at different times all of these things have been, and continue to be, very important to my well-being. But I have become aware that the myth of control manifests just as strongly in ‘alternative’ value systems as it does in conventional ones. At the root of this thinking is the wish to protect oneself from the possibility of having to face one’s

own mortality. So we seek to make everything explicable and therefore controllable. If we can explain why someone else has become ill, we believe that we can somehow prevent ourselves from becoming ill – or so the theory goes.

It took me a long time to see what was happening because so much of this thought patterning had become unconsciously woven into my own psyche. And in my vulnerability, I felt totally unable to contest it. It was as though my body had betrayed me – by becoming ill, my body had revealed my ‘damaged psyche’. I was sick, therefore I was flawed. It took me a long time to realise, however, that embedded in all of this was a kind of New Age moral blame, a new burden for the ill. It wasn’t just that I was sick. It was that I was sick because I was not expressive enough, not calm enough, not creative enough, not angry enough, or too angry, too passive, too suppressed, too me. I realise that I saw my illness as a label stuck on the outside of my body – ‘psychologically mal-adapted’.

It is not that I wish to deny the veracity of mind-body medicine. It is an integral part of yoga and my own Tantric practices. I believe that bio-psychology (as discussed by Baba in *Yoga Psychology*, 1991) has so much to offer in understanding illness and health. But at a deep level in the popular mind some New Age notions of health and wellness have become intertwined with early religious views of illness as a blight imposed by God. Few people now would consciously view disease as an instrument of divine wrath, but there are many who do see it as an expression of flawed personality. And flawed personality has somehow become equated with moral turpitude. And when moral blame



comes into the equation, it is hard to look clearly at the connection between the mind and the body.

In this way, the illness becomes a way of explaining the whole person, of reducing the complexities of a complete person into one psychological explanation. It becomes a way of explaining illness, but also of distancing us from the possibility of experiencing it: 'She has breast cancer because she has emotional problems. I don't have those emotional problems therefore I won't get breast cancer.'

It is a way of placing rationality and reason between ourselves and the thing we fear most: our own loss of control. Susan Sontag (1979: 55,57) describes it in this way:

Psychologising seems to provide control over the experiences and events (like grave illnesses) over which people have in fact little or no control . . . Psychological theories of illness are a powerful means of placing blame on the ill. Patients who are instructed that they have, unwittingly, caused their disease are also being made to feel that they have deserved it.

It took me a very long time to start identifying this as a phenomenon in others. And as I began to recognise it in others, I also began to recognise it in myself. At first, when someone would tactfully suggest that there were areas of my emotional adjustment I should look at, I would feel slightly shame-faced, thank them for their honesty, and again begin the inward search. Sometimes I would feel slightly irritated, but I would sublimate this feeling as proof of my flawed psyche and my inherent defence mechanism that sought to deny the real cause of my illness.

But as these suggestions to ‘correct’ myself came more and more often, I started to see through them. I began to see that those who didn’t have serious illnesses were just as ‘screwed up’ as me, and that there was more to this thing called ‘illness’ than psychology. A real turning point came when I was staying in Europe at an alternative cancer therapy centre. In the space of a few days, every possible explanation for my having cancer was thrown at me by well-meaning people who didn’t have cancer. The reasons just seemed to pour out at me: apparently, I was sick because I did meditation, because I didn’t eat onions and garlic, because I did eat tomatoes, because I worked too hard, and because I had unresolved grief. Suddenly everything about me was on trial just because I had cancer. I began to feel there was nothing right about me.

The final straw came when a woman asked to join me at lunch. We had never met before and we started a polite conversation. She asked what type of cancer I had and when I said I had breast cancer, she said, ‘Oh, you must have issues with your mother.’

For me this was a turning point. It seemed so absurd that someone who knew nothing of my personal, social, cultural or spiritual background could make such a pronouncement about me within three minutes of our meeting. I allowed my anger to surface and, in doing so, somehow released myself from the bondage of ‘flawed psychology’. Up to this point I had been through immense physical and psychic pain in coming to terms with this illness, and I started to realise that this counted for something. I started to see that pain was not just an embarrassment, that it was



a tool for finding personal depth and spiritual understanding.

As I began to see how other people sought to distance themselves from illness by controlling it through explanation, I also came to understand how I had been doing the same thing. As I began to feel the cumulative destructive effect on my own well-being and sense of integrity of other people's confused and often judgmental perceptions of illness, I also began to recognise similar values within myself. These values have been impediments to being able to fully embrace my spiritual integrity beyond my bodily integrity. It has been, and continues to be, a hard process.

I realise now that when I embarked on my journey with cancer, I was actually intent on living out a script which I had already written in my mind: I would turn my back on conventional medicine, I would dive deep into the world of meditation, yoga, diet and alternative health, I would have deep insights, and eventually I would come out of it well again. I would resume my life where I left off, just a little wiser. The bottom line was: I would live to tell the story.

I have read so many stories like this. Stories of people diagnosed with cancer who just started meditating, or just started drinking wheat grass juice, started doing visualisations or started looking at their 'issues', and six months later all signs of their cancer were gone and they were well again. I so much wanted to be able to write a story of my own just like theirs. I wanted a neatly packaged product that fitted all my parameters of expectation and hope.

The only problem was, the ending just wouldn't come. I did all the right things. I dove deep into my meditation, drank gallons of juices, followed rigid diets, took supple-

ments, did visualizations... the only thing lacking was the neat and tidy ending. That one loose end continues to elude me. In short, I wanted a miracle.

When the miracle didn't come, I started asking why. And the answers that issued forth from the depths of my being revealed things about me and my spirituality I thought I had sorted out years ago. From these murky depths of my subconscious emerged a deeply rooted belief that if I was good, God would save me. The Divine would make me better. But I wasn't getting better and so I wondered, 'Maybe my Divine Lover doesn't love me anymore.'

It is difficult to convey how deeply embedded a value like this is and how difficult it is to confront it and move beyond it. A recognition emerged that at some level, even after 21 years of commitment to my spiritual path, my commitment to my spirituality was still conditional. In one sense, I guess I saw my spirituality as some kind of insurance policy: If I do all the right things – meditate regularly, practice my *asanas* (yoga postures), follow my diet, read spiritual literature – I will be safe. Somewhere deep down, I believed that bad things don't happen to good people. Susan Wendell (1996: p. 107) expresses this essential human dilemma beautifully:

Most people are deeply reluctant to believe that bad things happen to people who do not deserve them, or seek them, or risk them, or fail to take care of themselves. To believe this as a general proposition is to acknowledge the fragility of one's own life; to realise it in relation to someone one knows is to become acutely aware of one's own vulnerability.



By having to confront my illness, and the absence of miracles in my journey with cancer, I have been forced to face up to some essential issues about life and death. I have been forced to rewrite the false story that I had written in my own mind and to write my own script – a script which doesn't incorporate a miracle, or even a happy ending. This has become my biggest challenge – to accept the completeness of my spirit, irrespective of the state of my physical body, and to make positive meaning out of pain.

I realised that, even after all these years, I was still hooked on a materially based notion of spirituality, an interpretation of my spiritual path that assumed that my spirituality would bring some kind of material reward. This is a naive spirituality, a shallow spirituality that fails to embrace all the inconsistencies and injustices that make up the world. Yet it is a belief system that can often serve us for a long time, until we are forced by life's circumstances to wrestle with the essence of the human condition. And try as you may to reinterpret and reconstruct, the simple fact is that pain is an essential part of the human condition, and for a spiritual path to be meaningful, it must make meaning out of that pain. Meditation is not about creating a safe social environment, it's about creating the internal strength to deal with naturally occurring chaos.

One of my greatest struggles with this illness has been reconciling the pain I experience every day in a social value system that really doesn't know how to make meaning from pain. The real mysteries of life have been sidelined by being sanitised. Events like birth and death, illness and grief, the points in our life when we come closest to mystery and spirit, have been so sanitised and beauracratished

that the moments of wonder and enlightenment that come from coming face to face with these raw energies are lost. Because these moments are challenging to materially based social value structures (especially in a capitalist society), those who live close to them, perhaps by virtue of being ill or close to death, are marginalised and discredited. In Susan Sontag's (1979: p. 8) words:

As death is now an offensively meaningless event, so that disease widely considered a synonym for death is experienced as something to hide.

Tantra is a raw spirituality – one that defies all shams and veneers and which continually strips one bare. On the Tantric path, one is asked to wrestle with the meaning of life and death, to understand the forces of darkness and light, and to seek the Divine in every experience. For the *Tantrika*, life experiences seem to be vehicles for developing spiritual understanding at a deep level. In my experience, the mill of life pursues you until you really do internalise your spiritual understandings. Early on in my illness, I had a dream which I can see now was a clue to the depths to which I would be asked to go to in wrestling with my understanding of pain and of death.

It was about six months after my diagnosis, and I had gone to sleep in tears, feeling overwhelmed, over-burdened and very much alone. In the dream, I was at a place where many people had gathered for a spiritual retreat. They were people I know well, people with whom I have shared my spiritual path for many years. In the dream, somebody was trying to kill me. I knew my life was in danger, but when I went to my friends for help they couldn't see it. They were



so busy with their own lives that they could not recognise my danger.

So I went to the entrance of the place where my Guru's body lay. Going there was like crossing to 'the other side', yet I felt compelled to go there because I could get no help in any of the safe places. The entrance looked like a coffin on the ground with a wire grate over the top, leading to a tomb-like space below. The wire grate was padlocked shut. I asked the woman who guarded the entrance to let me in. As she padlocked the gate again behind me, I reminded her to tell other people I was down there. I feared I was going to a dangerous place and that I would not be able to get out. But it was as if she didn't hear me. I was already out of sight, out of mind – in 'the other world'.

Inside, it was like a tomb, very dark and frightening, lit only by a few candles. Some places were very dark and carried a evil vibration. I could see where Baba's body lay – it was lighter there. I was scared because I could feel a very strong death energy. But I could also feel a very strong energy of clarity and light (the energy I associate with Baba). I knew I would only survive if I held my mind very steady and focused single-mindedly on the forces of light to the exclusion of the darkness. As my mind strengthened in its focus, my experience of that light and loving energy intensified too. Then I saw that life was returning to Baba's body. I started singing *kiirtan* to him, and he was smiling broadly at me.

Quietly and simply, He said to me, 'Sing louder, sing louder.'

He smiled his most beautiful smile and all my fear of this place of death fell away. I was just surrounded by him and his light and beauty and love.

I awoke feeling strangely disquieted, as though I was being challenged but also being pushed through a door into a new level of understanding. I felt I was being asked to really face death, and that the only way to do this was to focus strongly on the light.

I feel that the essence of Tantra is the dance with death. By coming face to face with the underbelly of human experience, we get the chance to really find an immense strength within our selves. From this place, we get the chance to really understand unconditional love.

By being scraped down to my essence, I have come to truly appreciate the beauty of both my humanity and my divinity. At an earlier time, I saw these two parts of myself in opposition to each other. I was angry at my humanity because I thought it was a force that sought to assert itself over my divinity. But now I've come to appreciate the strange interconnectedness between these apparent opposites. It is my humanity that has brought me to experience this pain. And without it, I wouldn't have come to really wrestle with 'The Big Questions'. Yet my divinity allows me moments of transcendence – to momentarily see and understand, through the pain, the transience of the 'permanence' we so avidly believe in.

In the intensity of pain, one is forced to stand back, occasionally, and look for a bigger thread to the meaningless suffering we experience. In moments of clarity, that *liila* (Cosmic play) reveals itself as the Divine law that is the backdrop to the drama we all live out. In those moments of



understanding, there is no place for wrongdoing and right-doing, as the smallness of our experience fades into the depth and breadth of the Divine tapestry of which we are all just a tiny part.



XI

An Island of Gold

Maniisha Yamaoka

(Translated by Didi Ananda Laghima)

One day, the force of the universe caused something to happen for which I could never have prepared myself. Could there ever be a bigger shock for me and my children? Yes, I guess there could be. But what happened did happen, and I have to accept it. I am stronger now.

It was March of 1996. Ganesh, my husband of seven years and the father of my three young daughters, was visiting us in Japan. Our cross-cultural marriage meant we divided our time between my country of birth, Japan, and his home country in Africa. The children and their education kept me in Japan, and his work kept him in Africa, so



he would visit us whenever he could in Japan and we would travel to Africa to be with him.

We had travelled to Tokyo to take the children to Disneyland. One of the children was having a birthday, and we wanted to give all of them a treat. After Tokyo, I was to fly to Kaohsiung in Taiwan to attend a meditation retreat. Ganesh felt a pressing need to return to his work in Africa. I asked him not to go back to Africa this time. He was only planning to go for a very short time, and would return to Japan before we moved to Africa as a family in one month's time. I could not understand what was so important that was calling him back for this short trip. But he was insistent that he had to go, and I could do nothing but accept it. I would travel with the children to the meditation retreat in Kaohsiung while he returned to Africa.

We had one day together in Tokyo before we went our separate ways. That day something strange happened between us all. Ganesh and I began to argue over the smallest thing. The problem was so insignificant, yet it produced such a strong reaction in all of us. Suddenly, I was crying hard. Ganesh was crying too. Then all the children started crying – Tosa, who was seven; Kamala, who was five, and Piyusa, who was only one year old. We were all crying. Then Tosa took my hand and placed Ganesh's hand over mine to bring us together. We hugged as a family, all of us, hugging and crying.

The next day Ganesh saw us off at the airport. When we arrived in Kaohsiung I tried to call him in Tokyo, but he had left already.

After the retreat, we flew to Taipei en route to Japan. I took the children shopping and, while I was walking down

the street, I glanced down at my wedding ring – three solid bands of gold intertwined into one ring. The ring had split in two. It was solid gold, but it had just split. I showed it to Didi, a nun of Ananda Marga, who was with us. I asked her what she thought it might mean. She made light of it, but I knew she was thinking it had some greater significance.

I travelled with Didi and the children back to Japan. That night, at home, I got a phone call from Africa. Ganesh had been in a serious car accident. The voice on the other end of the phone told me he was in hospital in a very serious condition and I should come at once. I was in total shock.

I felt completely overwhelmed. How would I manage to travel to Africa alone with three young children and my mind in such distress?

I remembered my broken wedding ring and I knew, at that moment, that Ganesh had gone already. I understood that the voice on the phone was trying to break the news to me gently, but I knew. Ganesh had gone, leaving the three daughters he dearly loved.

I was out of my mind with grief. I cried for three days without being able to eat. All kinds of emotions came with the tears: sadness, anger, insecurity, fear. Sadness that I couldn't see or touch or talk to Ganesh any more. Anger that he could leave me alone. Insecurity about how I would survive with my three daughters. And fear about how to tell the children.

I could not tell my children everything. I was trying to reconcile myself to what had happened, but I could not yet face their pain as well. I told them that Papa had been in an



accident and that he was in hospital. I could not tell them that he had gone already.

Everyone was telling me I should travel to Africa for his funeral – my mother, his family. But I could not bring myself to go. I knew Ganesh was gone already.

I also knew, though everyone said it was an accident, that his death had been no accident. I understood African politics and I knew that Ganesh was vulnerable in his position as aide to the Prime Minister. I knew it was no accident, but I could not even bring myself to fight for justice about his death. I knew nothing would bring Ganesh back to me now.

I understand now that Ganesh's body could no longer contain the intensity of the person that he was. He was 100 per cent a lover of God. He was 100 per cent a businessman. And he was 100 per cent a politician. This was the intensity with which my husband lived life. There was just too much to fit into that single physical frame.

For three days I was in total despair, but then my mind started to recover incredibly quickly. I became overwhelmed by an almost indescribable feeling of gratitude, and I cried.

*My dearest soul mate,
Thank you, Ganesh.
I am so happy that I met you.
You gave me three daughters and guided me to Baba.
You came to this earth for that purpose
And waited until I could stand on my feet without your physical
presence.
And now that I am ready,*

*You have left to be with your most Beloved.
You must have been anxious to go there,
But you cheated death twice already
– overcoming major heart surgery twice,
And left me three joyful daughters.*

I started to feel stronger and calmer, but still my mind was asking: How will I survive without my husband's support? How will I feed and clothe my children?

Then, one week after Ganesh died, I received a wonderful message in a dream. In this dream, I was walking along a quiet beach with several Didis and Dadas. I saw a shining, spinning object flying toward us. It came closer and closer. We could see now that it was an island; an island made entirely of gold. Finally, it landed right in front of us. One Dada looked at it and wondered how much gold it might contain. Another Dada tried various calculations, but in vain. Everyone wondered what to do with this huge mass of gold that had landed right in front of us. Then we saw a small house on the beach. Together we carried the island of gold into the house. The island was incredibly heavy. The moment we managed to put it inside the house, I woke up. Immediately I understood the meaning of the dream.

I knew that Baba, my Guru, and Ganesh, my husband, were telling me, 'You don't need to worry about money.' I felt so relieved and thankful. I sat up in bed and began meditating immediately. Since then, whatever money I have needed to support myself and my children has come to me.



As I began to feel stronger inside myself, I knew it was time to tell the children. There was a special room in our house that we kept for meditation. I gathered my children there along with my mother, my best friend and Didi, and I told them their Papa had died. Tosa was silent and went inside with her pain. Kamala cried and cried. Piyusa was still very young and could not express her feelings in a conscious way.

Day by day, I started to feel very strong – stronger than ever before. I did not worry about anything any more. I walked in the direction my soul set me. And so, on March 26 in 1997, one year after Ganesh had left his body, I was travelling to Australia with my three young daughters.

It is hard to explain what pulled me here. I felt I could not stay in Japan any longer; I didn't feel my daughters would get what they needed there for their total development. I could have gone to Africa where everything I needed on a material level was waiting for me – the beautiful house which Ganesh and I had just had built for our family to be together, an expensive car, financial support – yet I felt pulled, for no explicable reason, to Australia where I knew no one and had no place to live.

I had heard of two Neohumanist schools in Australia. I went to look at these schools and decide where I should make my home. I travelled with my children and my photographs of Ganesh and Baba. In Maleny, I stayed with a family who lived on the community land where one of those schools was situated. As they drove us about, showing us the area, we listened to *kiirtan*. It was the same tape every day. When I had travelled with Ganesh in his car in Africa, he had played the very same tape all the time, only

this tape. It was his favourite tape and I associated it very strongly with Ganesh. When I heard it playing in the car in Maleny, I felt Ganesh was calling me here to stay. Immediately I knew this was the place where I should settle.

Although everything I needed physically was waiting for me in Africa, I feel that here, in Australia, I have everything I need Cosmically. Somehow all our needs have been met by some unseen Cosmic hand, and I know this will continue.

I feel that Ganesh is free now and, in his freedom, I feel him close to us, even closer than when he was in his physical body.

Life in a foreign country without a husband and with three children has been hard and stressful at times but I have managed easily. Where does this strength come from? Of course it is not mine, but I feel I am receiving tremendous energy from the Universe by doing *kiirtan*. The energy I feel when I do *kiirtan* turns my negativity, stress, acidity, into a positive energy. When I receive new positive energy my heart becomes full of happiness, my face starts to smile, and my mind becomes light and shining. I don't feel tired even after doing *kiirtan* for three hours. Now I know that my life cannot continue without my *kiirtan*, meditation and fasting.

I look forward to *akhanda kiirtan* (*kiirtan* moving in a circle for three, six or twelve hours) once a month. And when I go to group meditation each week, the tiredness that has accumulated during the week disappears. It is very important for me to live with joy and smiles that are shared with my children and to feel the happiness of life.



I pay respect to the teaching of my Guru, Shrii Shrii Anandamurti, which gives meaning to everything. I am grateful for everything life brings. I have learned that there are no coincidences in life. Always there is a reason or meaning behind every event. There is a deep meaning in why I lost my husband and why I am here in Australia with my children. If not now, then one day I will understand it fully. My life is full of joy and happiness. May everyone live with joy and happiness!



XII

My Last Moment with My Mother²

Asha Brown

It was March 23, a Wednesday, at eight o'clock in the morning. I stood looking out the window. 'I should get going, get moving. I've got to go to work; there's a pile of things to do.' But something felt strange. There was an eerie feeling in the atmosphere. Everything seemed to be calm, quiet, different.

As I headed home that same day, I felt so lonely, sad. I was eager to reach home. Usually I dreaded coming home because it meant having to pass by her as she lay in the living room, meant having to take her blessing (it is a Fili-

² Asha's mother was Didi Ananda Supriiti, whose story is also told in Chapter IX by Didi Ananda Ujjvala.



pino custom to take the blessing of our elders as we enter or leave a place), and that meant having to talk to her. I couldn't stand to look at her for a long time; my heart would race and pound, as if something was squeezing it inside me, and uncontrollable tears would race down my cheeks.

But when I reached home that day it was different. She looked completely at peace, so at ease. Unexpectedly I saw her smile. This smile told me everything would be fine.

That night, while she was sleeping, I sat beside her bed and held her hand. I could feel the warm flow of her strong energy. As I gazed at her, tears of love began to roll down my cheeks.

She slept the sleep of the contented. She looked so peaceful. I guess it was faith. She always had her faith – a simple thing, yet too hard for most people, including me, to practice. How I envied her, my mum, for those special qualities she had that I didn't have. She could truly love, accept and forgive. Despite her condition, she still chose to be happy.

Often during her sickness I felt a dilemma: if God truly exists, why won't He cure her? Why does He let her suffer like this? Why not just free her?

As I looked at her then, my vision blurred with tears, I knew the answer. 'Render everything to God, whole without doubt, but with faith and hope. Surrender, and He'll do the rest.'

For five years she battled cancer with faith, with the hope that someday she'd be relieved. In those years I never ever heard her moan or complain about the way she was suffering. Through the early stages, she offered us, her

children, faith and assurance – a faith that she'd be healed, and an assurance that everything would return to normal.

But my question was always 'when'?

When would she walk with us again? When would we go out shopping together, just like before? When would she help Rashmii straighten her things up again? When would she help Bashanti with her assignments? When would she be there to catch me when I said nasty words, hidden behind my smiles? I let the painful memories come of how I had realised 'when' had changed to 'if'. And at that moment, looking at her with my cheeks wet and my shirt soaked with tears, I knew 'if' had changed to 'never'.

She may not have been a perfect mother, but she was always sensitive to our needs. She always guided us in a way that opened our hearts and minds. She showed us that no matter how great or small a thing was, everything is possible. Her determination, her dedication, drew our attention, won our respect, deepened our affection. No matter what pain she was feeling, she always had that 'everything-will-be-fine' look on her face. Even when she was on her back, on her bed, her mind was always soaring up high, full of light, full of hope, full of life.

With the melody in her voice, she bore her pains quietly. She laughed with us, cried when she had to, and she constantly encouraged us to express our thoughts in an interesting way. In the last years, even as she was suffering inside, you could feel and see the lively spirit radiating from within her. Her lesson to us was simple and clear: take a stand, face and fight whatever may come. Like a rose, burdened by so many thorns, she was able to reach past the thorns and find the real rose within her.



I never ever heard her express regret about anything. She always looked at the bright side of life amidst the thorns of being alive. And she loved helping other people to realise and overcome their thorns, to fight and to conquer so they might blossom, not once, but many times over. She taught me that the true meaning of existence is to suffer and fight. In her I witnessed how she conquered her disease and was able to free herself from the bondage of suffering that God had chosen to give her.

That night, as I kissed her goodnight, I clung to her warm strength, feeling, savouring the moment of having her in my arms, in my life.

Early the next morning, at five minutes past four o'clock, we were awakened by the sound of someone's tears. She, my mother, my friend, my adviser, had passed away. Although we had expected it for some time and tried to prepare ourselves, her death was still a big shock.

Full of my memories of her, I looked at her with her eyes closed forever. I sat down quietly, carefully, at her bedside, uttering my last farewell, my prayer. At last she was free, free from all her burdens, free from all obligations, free from suffering.

In the waiting silence, I still could feel her invisible force of faith, the same faith she had taught us to have, which no one could destroy.

I know that without her we will have rough, hard days ahead. I also have faith that she'll always look upon us, that she will always be with us in our minds, in our hearts. She will always be our mother.

So, wherever she is, I bid her farewell, a happy journey back to His lap now that she rests in peace.

XIII

My Five Miracles

Jody Wright

When a baby is born to you, you know that he or she has somehow been chosen by God to be yours. Though four of our children came to us through adoption, each has come with that same sense of destiny. It has made me feel that each of them has been lent to me with God's special blessing. Let me tell you their stories.

Olisa

For me, 1979 and the first months of 1980 were very depressing. I had been trying to get pregnant for over a year, and nothing was happening. The whole world seemed populated by pregnant women, and every 24 days my period came again.



I had a gnawing feeling that there was a child out there for me. Pursuing adoption was my one light. During a pre-adoption meeting, my husband Prakash and I learned about searching independently for a child to adopt and explored the idea of having a multiracial family.

We spent six months going through fertility testing and the equally laborious task of proving to an adoption agency that we would make good parents. We started spreading the word that we wanted to adopt.

A friend wrote about us to a pregnant friend of hers. This woman, from the Philippines, was now living in the United States, as we were. But months passed, and no word came. By spring I had sunk into a deeper depression, spending weekends in tears. I felt that my child was out there and I couldn't get to her.

One day I dried my tears and said to myself, 'If she really is out there, I better get ready for her.' I listed all the things I would need to do to prepare for a new baby. There were 16 things on my list, and I told myself that if I did one of them every weekend, she would come to me when I was done. I counted out 16 weeks to the end of July, then added a few just to be sure. I refinished a chest and began to collect hand-me-downs, diapers, information about adoptive nursing, and whatever else I thought we'd need.

One day in July, just as I was recovering from a uterine infection caused by the infertility work, I got a call from a friend's pregnant friend. She wanted us to consider adopting her baby! The next weekend we drove five hours to visit this woman, whose African-Filipino baby was due in two weeks. Somehow I knew it would be born the next Sunday on the full moon. In Sunday she called, in labour,

and invited us to come. We put our already-packed suitcases into the car, and the accelerator pedal did not work! It was just like all the stories we had heard people tell of labouring women unable to get to the hospital. Luckily for us, we got hold of another car and were on our way in a matter of hours.

Olisa was born into the arms of an African midwife exactly 16 weeks from the weekend I had made my list. Giving up her baby was tremendously difficult for Olisa's mother. Early in her pregnancy she had asked God what she should do with her baby, and the letter about us had arrived in her mailbox. Now, passing Olisa among loving arms, we spent four days helping one another through the painful emotions brought forth by this transition. I was able to sit for long hours with her in my lap and look into her beautiful face and breast-feed a child that was going to be mine.

I loved getting home with this new baby and showing her off to all my friends and family. It was a moment I had dreamed of for years!

Mahajoy

When Olisa was two years old, I had a feeling there was another baby, somewhere, for us. Again we started telling our friends of our desire to find a child. Olisa's mother contacted us in the beginning of September and asked if she could mention us to a friend in the Philippines. One Sunday some time later I felt intensely that I should get ready for a new baby, so I got out all of Olisa's baby clothes and washed and repaired them. The next day I got a call from Mahajoy's mum in the Philippines inviting me to come. As with Olisa's mom, economics, race, social expec-



tations and politics played strong roles in forcing Mahajoy's mother to consider adoption. She also suffered from a great deal of emotional turmoil. A mother giving up her baby often feels that the new mother has everything she doesn't: a caring partner, a home, money to support a child, and most of all, her baby.

For more than seven months I lived in the Philippines with my two-year-old and an infant whose mother could not make up her mind whether we were the right family for her daughter. Meanwhile, I was breast-feeding Mahajoy but not able to give myself totally to her for fear I would lose her.

Between caring for two children, keeping everything sterile in a third-world country, doing all our laundry by hand, and cooking without refrigeration, I lost 20 pounds and got a serious case of post-natal depression.

I knew inside that Mahajoy was supposed to be with me. I recognised that gnawing feeling from the previous adoption, but there was nothing to do but wait. After much pain on everyone's part the adoption was complete, and I finally brought nine-month-old Mahajoy home.

Liina

Now that we had adopted two children, I felt ready to face the risk of surgery. I knew that as I tried again to get pregnant I would have two beautiful children to help me keep perspective through the difficulties. We decided to go ahead.

At first we were told that there was about a one-in-five-chance of getting pregnant with fallopian-tube surgery. After a preliminary look, the surgeon thought the chances

were even smaller. We decided to go for it anyway, augmenting the procedure in every way we could think of to increase the odds. I spent several months eating nutritious foods and taking care of my health. I researched homeopathics to help me heal and reduce the internal scarring. As I waited on the operating table, I imagined that my spiritual teacher was the one who was doing the surgery. Then I spent five and half hours having my fallopian tubes opened and fibrous scar tissue removed.

Within seven weeks I was pregnant! The surgeon was astounded. He told my midwife that he had thought there was a one-in-a-thousand chance of success, then he took the file home to see what he had done right. It was a very fulfilling pregnancy, and the natural birth of our beautiful daughter Liina was everything I had hoped for.

Emily

When Liina was two, we began having unprotected intercourse again. Four years later, I still hadn't fallen pregnant, so when we found out about a potential adoption we decided to pursue it. We completed a very quick home study (by now it was clear we were good parents), and were all ready for a special-needs baby that had been born three months premature. But it wasn't to be because the mom wasn't ready for the adoption.

We met with our social worker on a Monday afternoon to begin looking for another baby. She told us that just that morning she'd been given the file of a biracial baby who was due that month. She also said we were the only family she currently had on her files for a biracial child, and sent us home to think about it. We knew what we wanted be-



fore we got to our car. That afternoon, we presented the idea to our kids.

Everyone gave an excited 'OKAY!' Everyone but Liina. 'Why not?' I asked. 'We really want another baby.' 'I just don't want to.' I chose the psychological approach. 'What would make you change your mind?' 'Gum.' 'Gum?' I asked incredulously. 'Yes. Ten pieces of gum.' 'If I gave you ten pieces of gum, you'd feel okay about us getting another baby?' 'Yes.' 'It's a deal!' We got her ten pieces of gum and called the agency to tell them yes.

Friday came. We hadn't heard anything. My spirits dropped, and I wondered if it had been all a mirage. I didn't know whether to unpack the boxes and start preparing for a baby or not. I called our social worker, who said, 'I'll call you back in a few hours. Don't worry, it's looking good.' We only had to wait an hour. 'Your baby was born Wednesday night. You can pick her up at ten o'clock on Monday morning.'

Sundarii

This article was originally written as 'My Four Miracles'. Five years after Emily's adoption, I was riding in a car with a friend who had just returned from visiting Haiti. Remembering an intuitive feeling from some months earlier, I asked him if, by chance, there was a child in Haiti who needed a home. He started in surprise and said, 'Yes, there is! I have been worrying about what will happen to Sundarii when her home sister gets adopted!' The children's home she lived in had fallen apart.

He showed me pictures of her and I began exploring what it might mean to adopt an older child who had had

many adverse experiences. It was a very hard decision, and it has been very challenging, but we have added a fifth child to our family.

Sundarii was twelve years old when the whole family went to Haiti and brought her home. I don't think that all these situations were coincidences, nor do I believe that we 'made' each adoption happen. Each of these was a miracle, and each was God's will. Thank you, God, for giving us these wonderful children to raise for you.



XIV

A Tantric Birth

Anjali Natarajan

Who would imagine that while going to catch the very first glimpse of your new baby that the ultrasound technician would find another foetus inside, growing in its own little sack? Although twins run in my family and I had a suspicion that I might be carrying a set, the reality of it came as a shock to me. How would I possibly manage? Yet I gradually resolved my fear and came to take it as a blessing. I began to enjoy the fact that I was going to have two babies to care for.

Reading all that I could find that my spiritual teacher, Baba, had written regarding pregnancy and birth, I began to eat whole foods, exercise, sing more spiritual songs and read spiritual discourses daily, keeping the welfare of my two sons in mind. In my meditation, I would visualize that

both babies were with me, that our spirits were one with the Divine, and that we shared a special link together which went beyond time. In order to tell them apart, we temporarily named the babies 'Shiva' and 'Shyam'. Our beloved *acharya*, Dada Nityasatyanandaji, would give them spiritual names on the day of their birth, as per the system of Ananda Marga.

My husband, Nataraj, and I had attended a Bradley birth course, where we learned how to recognise the various stages of birth and many valuable techniques for dealing with pain.

Around four and a half months into my pregnancy, I seemed to become acutely aware of children with different birth defects wherever I went – on the beach, in the grocery store, on the television. Was the Divine preparing my mind for the news to come? I was devastated and heartbroken to discover a few weeks later that one of my beloved twins, Shiva, had a severe birth defect with several anomalies which meant he would probably not survive. How could it be that the child inside me was not the healthy child I had envisaged?

With the help of my dear friend and spiritual counsellor, Didi Giitainjali, I was able to shift my paradigm and things started to fall into perspective: This little soul was a gift from the Divine and my duty was to serve him selflessly while his spirit was with me. The anchoring and familiar voice of my mother was an additional soothing balm to my mental distress. She herself had nearly died that year and was recovering from major surgery. Her words echoed Didi's as she supported my decision to care for the baby, should he survive.



I spent the following week with Didi singing and dancing kiirtan and sitting for meditation. That weekend my husband and I went to a six-hour meditation program (*sadhana shivir*) at the Ananda Dhiira eco-spiritual centre in the Sierra foothills. Didi's presence and support was a soothing balm to the confusion and fear that filled my mind at this time. At night, I sang the babies to sleep with *Prabhat Samgiita*, the beautiful spiritual songs composed by my spiritual teacher. After singing and dancing kiirtan, I sat for meditation and concentrated all of my effort on little Shiva's welfare. This helped me to love both babies even more and to surrender to the Divine's plan for Shiva.

On the dawn of the day on which we were to honour my guru's birthday, we arose in the ashram at five o'clock to dance kiirtan and do collective meditation. Having spent the day there, we continued our celebration throughout the evening. Throughout that day I felt the presence of my guru as an immense spiritual vibration encircling us all, illuminating such sweetness and purity within. That feeling continued to flow with me into the following weekend as we attended another program, a three-hour kiirtan followed by meditation.

Somewhere in between, baby Shiva departed from his body. The midwife had heard his heartbeat only a few days before, and just four days later, the ultrasound confirmed that his soul had left his body. I was told that Shiva's decomposing body was unlikely to pose a threat to my other baby or myself, but that I would continue to be monitored by a perinatal specialist to make sure. I would have to wait for the delivery before both babies could emerge.

Our community pulled together and created a beautiful ceremony to help my husband and me release our emotions concerning Shiva's death. After *kiirtan* and meditation, we passed a candle around the room, representing the light of the child. Each person shared some heartfelt words of sympathy. This ritual helped to expedite my grieving. Soon, I was able to relax, and focus on my living child and the birth to come.

A few weeks before my due date, I began to doubt my ability to give birth. Crying out mentally to Baba, I expressed my deep fear of not being able to endure the labour to come. He appeared to me in a vision and smiled sweetly, telling me not to worry and that he would be with me; he was reassuring me that everything would be okay.

The day before I went into labour, my good friend Mohiini and I took a short walk to the shopping centre a block away. Upon our return, I was extremely exhausted and out of breath. She put her hand on my belly. 'You're tightening,' she said. 'I think you're going to go into labour soon.' I brushed her comment off as an old wives' tale – one of many that I had heard since becoming pregnant.

That evening, Mohiini received a call from her mother that her father had been hospitalised. She felt torn; her intuition was calling her to stay with me. She decided to drive home so she could see her father the next day. She told Nataraj to telephone her if I went into labour.

Around half past two in the early morning, I began to experience a strange sensation in my body, as if cosmic, electrical currents were running throughout my lower back. After going to the toilet to pass stools three times within thirty minutes, I realised something unusual was



beginning. Excitedly, I shook Nataraj awake to tell him that I was in labour. He didn't believe me, since we had ten more days to go, and told me to get some rest.

At three o'clock, the waves began to intensify. It felt like my back would split open. I did not know it at the time, but the baby was face forward and I was experiencing 'back labour', an excruciatingly painful affair. We called our doula (birth assistant), Maureen, who was attending another birth. She advised me to 'get some sleep' as this was my first delivery and she thought my labour would last a long time. It was comforting to hear her voice so I tried to take her advice.

The contractions were coming about every seven to ten minutes apart. I would moan really low, using sound to vibrate the region where the pain was centralized. Quietly singing *kiirtan*, I rocked back and forth on the edge of the bed as Nataraj slept soundly, snoring away. I found myself drifting into another time zone; as a primitive woman, in another world, completely alone and unafraid, performing a magnificent task. Darkness surrounded me as I continued to rock and surrender to a blissful, higher state of consciousness.

At half past four, I had a great desire to do *paincajanya* (early morning meditation that begins with some special songs and chanting). I somehow knew that there wouldn't be much time for meditation after the baby was born. I wanted to feel close to the Divine, so I sat down in half-lotus posture to sing *Prabhat Samgiita* and *kiirtan*, and enjoyed a long meditation. During that peaceful time, all activity ceased. Afterwards I was able to sleep for short periods in between more subtle contractions.

At around seven o'clock, I awoke in extreme discomfort, feeling as though my back would finally give way and burst open. The baby's feet were kicking inside as the squeezing motion moved him lower down. I pushed Nataraj to call Maureen again. She was still at the other birth and told Nataraj to call her back-up, Michele. Within the hour, the contractions had advanced to only a few minutes apart. There was no doubt in my mind that it was time to go to the hospital. I began repeating my *i'sta mantra* (a personal mantra given at the time of spiritual initiation) silently to myself, and murmuring deeply through each swell.

At around eight o'clock, we finally left for the hospital. It took all of my effort to get down the stairs and into the car. As I lay down in the back seat of the car, I continued to sing, or perhaps more correctly, 'groan' *kiirtan*, imagining the sound entering my lower back region. The twenty-minute ride seemed to take an eternity as the intensely arduous contractions closed in on me. My waters broke while I was in the car.

When we arrived at the hospital, Nataraj went inside to register. He was told he had driven to the wrong entrance. As he got back into the car, he forgot to shut the car door. Without realizing it, he began driving to the other side of the hospital with his door wide open. I cried out to him, 'Shut the door! Shut the door!' But amidst all the excitement, he didn't hear a word. He was clearly excited about the baby coming!

Our room was not yet ready so a nurse set me up on a gurney in the hall. When the nurse checked me, I was already dilated to six centimetres.



A few minutes later, I heard a very pleasant, seraphic voice. 'Anjali? I'm Michele, your doula.' I was moaning softly through a contraction. She came closer to me and gently placed my hand in hers.

'Is this how you've been labouring?' she whispered softly. 'You're doing a great job!'

'Really?' I thought. 'Who is this lovely woman with such a kind, soothing voice?'

I had been sent a divine sister to assist me.

As the next contraction emerged, she began to guide me. 'Just ride the wave, ride above it – that's it.' I closed my eyes and visualized the pain as a blue and white wave, and saw myself as a celestial being in a white flowing dress with long black hair, riding over the top of it. From that moment on, I felt at peace, confident in her care.

At last our room was ready. Maria, my midwife, arrived shortly thereafter and greeted me cheerfully.

'Hi Anjali, how are you doing?' she asked.

Michele told her that I was dilated to six centimetres.

'Do you want to get into the shower? That might help things along.'

The wise birthing mothers were there. Their loving voices, calm demeanour and years of experience embraced me. As I sank into their nurturing arms, I felt as though I belonged to this tribe – a community of caring women.

They drew a warm shower for me and sat me down on a stool with my back to the jet. The warm water immediately relieved some of the intense pain. I was just beginning to relax when the urge overcame me to use the bathroom – a

sign of transition. They checked my cervix. Within the hour I had dilated to 10 centimetres.

Seemingly out of nowhere, a most familiar, warm and smiling face peered at me from above my feet. Mohiini, my good friend and spiritual sister, had made it just in time!

‘How did you know?’ I uttered, completely astonished to see her there.

‘Nataraj called me and told me that you were in labour.’

She had rushed through the morning traffic to be there by my side. I was overjoyed to see her and knew then that everything was as it should be.

The time had come to push. I remembered Baba’s instructions for birthing and began to close my eyes. Focusing on a particular energy point, I started repeating my *guru mantra*. My whole being became absorbed into the universe. I was no longer made of matter but of pure, cosmic energy.

‘Now Anjali, I want you to look at me,’ Maria instructed. ‘When I tell you to, I want you to take a deep breath, hold it, and push. Push your pelvis upward like you’re pushing a car up a hill.’ I closed my eyes, and journeyed inside, listening carefully to Maria and Michele’s voices.

‘*Guru mantra*,’ I repeated in my mind. ‘Everything around me is Supreme Consciousness, nothing more.’

‘Breathe deep and let it out. Take another breath and hold it in your chest. Push out through your pelvis.’

A hospital labour nurse appeared at the side of the bed. As she poked the Doppler ultrasound device deep into my belly, I cried, ‘Get that thing off of me!’



She began clamouring in my ear, 'Get mad, get mad! Get mad at that baby!'

'Get mad at my baby?' I thought to myself: 'Get this woman out of my ear!' Her vibration seemed completely paradoxical to my internal, spiritual experience. Or rather it was just an addition, an expression of the Divine's humorous play.

Guru mantra... Deep within my mind, I beheld Baba's brilliant physical presence as it permeated the room. I did not dare to open my eyes as I was drenched in a powerful flow of universal love. Following my body's cues, I felt tremendous relief as I pushed.

'Now, Anjali, listen to me.' Maria's words brought me back. 'You will feel a burning sensation when the head comes through. Don't be afraid, just push through. This is what is going to bring your baby out.'

My guru, my greatest friend, was with me. How could I be afraid? He, to whom I had surrendered my life – the sweet father who consistently showered me with Universal Love – I understood then that He was not about to abandon me.

After two more pushes, I felt an extraordinary cosmic surge as our radiant son streamed out of my body and into Maria's hands. Nataraj and I were in complete bliss as we both began to shout in unison, 'Baba, Baba, Baba, Baba!'

They placed the fruits of my labour onto my chest, all slippery and wet. Then they cleaned him up and gave him, wrapped and warm, to me once more. I put him to my breast and immediately he began to suckle. Nataraj and I stared in awe at his tiny limbs as we sang a spiritual birthday song to our newborn son. Then I remembered to sing

kiirtan in his ear, soft and low, *baba nam kevalam*, (only the Name of the Divine).³

Nataraj called Dada Nityasatyanandaji from the hospital for our baby's spiritual name. Using intuition sciences and astrology, Dada chose the name 'Jagannath', meaning 'the Lord of the Universe'.

Lost in a spiritual trance with Jagannath in my arms, I was unaware of all that was going on around me: nurses and doctors coming and going, the presence of my mother basking in the revelry accompanying the birth of her first grandson. Never had I imagined that I could feel such rapture. A continuous flow of *kiirtan* poured forth from my heart into Jagannath's little ears.

A few hours passed and the room, with all of its sounds and hustle, gradually and mystically emptied out, leaving me completely alone with my newborn babe. Slowly, Jagannath opened his eyes and looked deep into mine. All was quiet and time stood still as I gazed back, into the dark eyes of my precious son.

'I will love and care for you with all of my heart and all of my mind forever,' I said without speaking. He seemed wise beyond his time, to understand the secrets of the universe, as if he were the tiniest replica of the Divine

³ Shiva's tiny, shrunken body came out with the placenta. In my birth plan, I had requested Maria to keep it from my sight, as I did not want to be distracted from enjoying the birth of my son. In a few days, I would feel the duality of sweet bliss and deep sorrow, as I retrieved the ashes of Shiva at the funeral home, with my tiny newborn in my arms.



himself. In that moment I realised I had a great spiritual journey ahead of me, one that would bring profound bliss and would weave the deepest wisdom into my life from that moment on.

Tell our girls that during the time of giving birth they should repeat their particular guru mantra in their particular i'sta chakra... If they do so, there will be minimum haemorrhaging and the birth will be safe.

Until the age of six months, the mother should give only her milk, and at the time of nursing, she should sing Baba Nam Kevalam (the kiirtan mantra) in a low voice so that only she and the baby can hear it. If she does so, the baby will have a spiritual start, and at the time of singing kiirtan, her milk will become divine nectar.

(Prabhat Rainjan Sarkar, 1995: p. 263)



XV

Didi Ananda Sukriti's Dreams

Didi Ananda Sukriti

A short time before she died of malaria in 2000 while travelling to India from the Congo, Didi Ananda Sukriti shared the following dreams and reflections. They illustrate the intensity of what she was experiencing during this period.

I was going through a series of extreme difficulties that had disturbed my peace of mind. I didn't realize, however, that I was feeling so low until I had the following dreams.

In one of my dreams I was walking along a road with a child who was carrying a box of soap powder. Suddenly the road became like a cliff that was about as tall as a ten-storey building, and there were long stairs leading down. The child was walking along the edge. Suddenly she fell;



however she managed to catch onto a stair with her hand. She decided to put the box aside so she could use both hands to climb back onto the road. She did this, and was able to climb to safety.

When I awoke, I realised I was the child. The soap powder symbolised the 'cleaning up' I was doing in West Africa, the Ananda Marga organisational sector that had unsupervised for some years due to scarcity of workers. This 'clean up' work had almost got me out of balance.

That morning my mind was filled with tumultuous thoughts about my recent experiences. I had left a safe place to come to Congo. Here I felt I was undergoing a psychic torture. I was isolated, without the company of other spiritual people or *acharyas*. There was no one to talk to but the four walls in my room and the mango tree in the garden where I had been doing my evening meditation. But now, because of the dream, I found I had a better perspective on the problems which at first had seemed like a whirlpool of mess with no beginning, middle or end. Now, it all seemed very clear to me.

The next day I had another dream, a dream I consider to be the best of all the Baba dreams I have ever had. I saw Baba sitting in the garden. He seemed to have long thin hands with long thin fingers. He was swinging his arms in different directions. I seemed to be the only person there. I concentrated my mind only on him. Then suddenly he did his *varabhaya mudra* (a gesture from the Guru to dispel fear), long and slow. He even turned towards me so I could see His hands better. I don't know how long He stayed in that *mudra*, but long enough.

Afterwards he stood up and picked up a leaf-like glass container with some water in it. He asked me what it was. I said it was water from Los Banos (the place in the Philippines where I became a Margii and the site of many blissful retreats during those wonderful old days in the '70s.) Then he said, 'Why didn't you tell me?' As I had no answer, he left the water with me and continued walking around the garden.

Suddenly he asked me, 'How are your finances?'. I said, 'All right, Baba'. I wanted to make Him happy. He was the one taking care of my finances, and I wanted to let Him know that I did not live miserably.

When I woke I felt blessed to have received this *varabhaya mudra* from Baba. It seemed a big ball of negative *microvita* (living energies) had been taken from me. I hadn't realised I had been in such a low state of mind until Baba came to me in this dream. In the following days, my state of mind started to lift. I felt more and more positive, light, calm and free. (It is very demanding being a senior citizen of Ananda Marga, because you are expected to be understanding and forgiving and the 'shock absorber' for other people's suppressed energies.)

I was so amazed to feel so free in my mind and so light-hearted. I felt just like I had after *avadhutika diiksa* (initiation as a senior nun, which involves a meditation on conquering fear) and *dharma samiksa* (personal review by Baba, at which time he absorbed some of my negative karma that would cause me suffering). The feeling was similar, but seemingly stronger than I had felt before, even after seeing Baba in person at spiritual gatherings in the past.



And then one day, in my morning meditation, it dawned on me that in the dream Baba had given me *dharma samiksa* along with his *varabhaya mudra*. And the dream had been on the exact same date as when I had received these blessings from Baba in person 19 years ago in 1981 in India! It was a Cosmic coincidence. Baba had put me back on his lap, perhaps because of the big tough job awaiting me here in Congo or in Africa as a whole. That's why he had to 'purify' me first and pump me with positive energy.

I find it really tough to do his work here in Africa. When he asked me in the dream about my finances, it had sounded the same as when he had asked me, during my first *dharma samiksa*, about how many students I had in my school in Iceland. I had said I had twelve students, and he had replied, 'Twelve students are no students at all!'. He had said I should have at least fifty. Years later, when we'd completed the construction of our own school building, we did have fifty children in the school in Iceland. So I felt it would be the same with my finances in Africa.

Now I do not want to lose such a beautiful feeling of lightness and freedom. I'm trying to do more *kiirtan* by joining the children's *dharma chakra* (group meditation), and I am doing long *sadhana* (meditations), especially in the evening facing that mango tree.



XVI

Hearing the Truth

Margaret Rathwell

Stephen was staying with us for the weekend; it was the weekend of my birthday. Dada, an Ananda Marga monk, was also visiting us that weekend. Dada talked and joked with Stephen, who was nearly five, and they enjoyed each other's company. My husband and I were planning to adopt Stephen; after eleven years of marriage, our own children had not come. We had been getting to know Stephen since Christmas. He was lively and curious and sometimes wild. He had been the victim of neglect, violence and sexual abuse and was undergoing therapy.

Dada spent the whole day with us; he ate and relaxed and played with Stephen. He did not say much. At the end of the day, when Stephen had gone to bed, he talked to my husband and me together. He spoke calmly and simply



without partiality and he spoke the truth. What he said was painful. He was helping me face the hardest decision I had ever had to make in my life, but I knew that what he said was the truth. There are few occasions in our lives when we face the clear truth of our situations, but if that moment comes you cannot ignore it; your whole being reacts to it and it changes you.

Dada said my relationship with my husband lacked strength: there was no emotional base that would enable us to support Stephen. Deep in my heart I had known this for a long time. Yet up until then the guilt I felt at the prospect of leaving and the fear of leaving what I knew – my husband, house, shared friendships and work – and starting again on my own had been too great to overcome.

When I heard Dada's words I felt a great sense of relief. The agony of a decision I had been trying to make for years was gone. Now I knew I could no longer continue to live in our lovely old English cottage and carry on the life to which I had become accustomed. My husband gave me a birthday gift as though nothing had changed, but I had finally made the decision to leave. I could not ignore the truth any longer, even though it was painful.

That day I could not see any bright future. All I could see was the pain of telling my husband that I was leaving, and of telling Stephen we could no longer be a possible new mummy and daddy for him, offering him the new home and new life he was eager to have. We tried to explain it was because of us and not because of him. It was another disappointment for him and, sadly, he was accustomed to these.

I had slowly been making changes in my life over the last eight years since my initiation onto the spiritual path of Ananda Marga. That had been in February 1979 in Hong Kong. I had been working for an American international bank as a computer programmer in London, and had gone to Hong Kong to work on a project for a few months.

A short time after returning to England my husband moved to a new job as a lecturer with a centre attached to the University of Leeds in Yorkshire. I did not want to seek another job as a computer programmer in Leeds and decided to do a Masters of Science in computing (my first degree had been in geography).

After I finished my study, in an attempt to gain some freedom for myself I went to Scotland to lecture in computing at a college. However I returned to Yorkshire after a year and got a grant to do a PhD in computer science for three years. I realise now that by taking on the new study I was buying myself thinking time.

After a long period of indecision, I visited my Guru in India. Baba was encouraging for Neohumanist kindergartens to be set up around the world.⁴ I discovered I needed to do more emotionally satisfying work such as this. Now I had a focus and a goal. I came away from India with the

⁴ Ananda Marga kindergartens, using the Neohumanist education system of holistic child-centred education based on a love and respect for all living beings, now operate in many countries. Didi Ananda Rama's book (2000) expounds on this philosophy.



clear intention of finalising my PhD so I could start to work with small children.

The day after that painful day when Dada had caused me to think clearly about my marriage, Dada had also spoken to me alone. He talked about what he felt were my husband's problems and how he could change. Apart from becoming vegetarian my husband had never shared the goals of my path; he had become jealous and continually tried to discourage me. For me, Dada talked of the future. He believed I should marry again and have children of my own. My husband, who was from Canada and 11 years older than me, had been told it was unlikely he could have children.

Thoughts of remarriage and children were not uppermost in my mind, especially now I had other things to worry about. Still, this vision of a possible future went on to grow quietly inside me. Perhaps it lent me some hope as I faced the painful challenges of the following days, weeks and months. Dada had told me of a man he knew who shared my spiritual path and who lived abroad. He said he felt I would get along well with him and that he had a good sense of humour! (Later on I heard through a friend that this man had been divorced and was now engaged to be married to someone else. So I let all this slip from my mind.)

Now I was alone to pursue my spiritual path without opposition. However many of my life's anchor points had suddenly disappeared. Somehow I struggled through the hurdles of telling family and friends of my decision to leave my husband, finding a flat of my own, feeling guilty, resisting my husband's pleas to return, taking on extra work as a

supply teacher in secondary schools so I could pay the bills and maintain my little pre-school group and... illness and a hospital recovery after a trip to India to see my Guru.

I had been ill for some time with undetected pneumonia. My unsympathetic local doctor suggested I was not really ill but rather I was just experiencing a reaction to leaving my husband, and that maybe I should go back to him. Fortunately my dear friend Madhurii came to visit and insisted we get a second opinion, after which I was admitted to hospital. Later on my menstruation stopped and I lost a lot of my hair as a result of this illness.

Now a new challenge confronted me: Didi Ananda Prajina asked me to go to Iceland to work in the Ananda Marga kindergarten there as a volunteer worker. At 32 years of age I was to leave my country and all that was familiar – language, education and culture. In the cold, dull November days of the year of my decision, I left England and all my difficult memories.

By now I was worn out, mentally and physically. What better place to ‘find oneself’ again than amidst the lunar landscape, volcanoes, mountains, sea and ice, and strong mystic tradition of Iceland. This was the perfect opportunity to put many things behind me.

In Iceland, I struggled for two years teaching children in a language I did not understand, cleaning the school, clashing with the women I lived with, and feeling very much alone.

Then my former husband wrote that he wanted to marry a work colleague who had grown-up children, so we needed to go through divorce proceedings. This came as a shock, even though it had been me who had left. But by



this time I was doing regular yoga and meditation, I was in contact with Didi and other women who shared my spiritual path, and I was attending retreats and generally expanding my spiritual understanding. During this time I underwent an inner change that strengthened me tremendously. Slowly I discovered who I was, what I could do, and what I wanted and needed.

After a time of introspection I was ready to return to the world. In 1989, after another trip to India to see Baba, the desire to remarry and have children began to surface. I had no particular person in mind, but rather I felt a kind of readiness.

Some years before, Baba had introduced the idea of 'revolutionary marriage', encouraging people from different countries and preferably different continents and cultures to marry, thereby helping to bring about cultural blending and a single human society – a planetary civilisation. Such marriages are often arranged in Ananda Marga.

This may seem to go against the Western idea of freedom of choice and romantic love, of 'falling in love'. It would seem frightening if you're thinking you could end up married to just anyone. However if you believe there is a destiny for each of us, then you can know there is a much deeper logic guiding the whole process. A friend in Iceland helped me prepare my mind for such a marriage. She explained that our lover is somewhere in the world waiting for us. Maybe we have known each other in previous lifetimes. But we do have to be ready to meet them. The key is to make ourselves more loving to everybody we meet so that when our path crosses with our lover's path we can

recognise each other. This path requires complete acceptance; you are putting yourself in the hands of the Guru.

So I asked Didi Ananda Prajina, the ‘mother’ of so many Tantric women, if she would help me find a revolutionary marriage. She asked me which nationalities I thought should she consider. I remember saying, although I’m not sure why, ‘Oh, maybe someone from the warm countries like Italy, Spain or South America.’ Months later, while I was still in Iceland, I received a message that Didi had found a man in Italy and that we could meet at the summer retreat in Germany. I had a name to play with in my mind but no other information; we didn’t contact each other. The summer retreat arrived, but he didn’t! I assumed he was no longer interested but I went to Italy anyway to work in the Ananda Marga kindergarten in Verona. Didi told me there was another man there who wanted to marry. (I was open to this, but we were from very different social and educational backgrounds and it was not meant to be.)

At *dharma chakra* (group meditation) on my first evening in Verona, I remember seeing the face of a man across the room and suddenly feeling attracted: I hoped he was the man I had come to Italy to meet. Later I discovered that this was Tapan Kumar, the man I was supposed to have met at the retreat in Germany. However the few brief interactions we had over the next few months left me feeling I did not particularly like his personality, and I remember feeling glad that it seemed this wasn’t meant to be.

Soon after I arrived in Italy, I was directed to go to India. I was reluctant to leave the beautiful ancient city of Verona, rich in Roman remains and cradled by mountains and lakes, and was eager to return to Italy, to this country that



promised so much happiness. In India I was resistant to being there right up until the end of my visit when I had a change of heart and was able to see Baby with love. Unknowingly, I said my final goodbye to him. It was the last time I saw him. He died the following year.

After struggling again to work with children in a new language and to understand a new culture, I started to get to know Tapan Kumar through work (we both have computing backgrounds). We became friends, and I 'fell in love'. Well, it just had to be, didn't it! Not only had Didi Ananda Prajina suggested him to me, but I also found out later that he was the man Dada had mentioned to me in that year of my decision! Tapan's engagement had not worked out. And he does have a good sense of humour! This confirmed my inner sense that I am being cared for on my spiritual path, as I follow my destiny in life.

The greatest lessons for me now are lessons of acceptance, surrender and unconditional love, of learning to give up the self in order to achieve unity. In the first few months of my new relationship there were misunderstandings, personality differences and cultural differences to overcome. I passed through a hard time struggling with impatience as I waited for Tapan to decide whether he actually wanted to marry again.

However, as Didi Ananda Prajina wisely advised me (revealing the conflicts between Oriental and Western thinking), 'Surely if you truly love him you would follow him just to be with him, without it mattering if he married you.' Looking at love in spiritual terms, I have gained a new understanding of marriage and relationships.

Our spiritual marriage was held under a walnut tree in the garden of the kindergarten where I was working. I seem to have passed so many important times by that tree: my work as a Neohumanist teacher, organisational meetings, *akhanda kiirtan* on the night Baba died, and more recently, the baby-naming ceremonies of our two sons.

I have had to learn that when a problem comes, acceptance is necessary before a solution can be found. Right at the beginning of my marriage a problem came which I could not solve. Something important for me was missing and I could not see any way out. The Western mind typically sets conditions and makes ultimatums in relationships. However the Italian way, with its strong family tradition – in some ways falling somewhere between the Indian and Western approaches – helped me to understand that there is another way. This is to accept the situation; not to back out of it, but to make the best of it. As soon as I accepted the circumstances of the problem, the solution came by itself.

The path of Tantra has taught me the value of struggle, and how struggle is necessary to make us stronger and our love deeper. The Guru's love and caring provides a tremendous sense of security, yet there is always the feeling of 'living on the edge' which *Tantrikas* describe. There is no permanent happiness in our material lives: we always have to struggle with problems as they present themselves from time to time.

After living for so many years without being able to express myself, I now see how important it is to express our deepest desires and dreams and to share them with others. This sharing is part of the process of realising our dreams. I



have also learned the importance of sharing problems with a friend. When friends speak of their experiences, I feel more connected to them and feel that real communication has taken place. Sometimes just sharing a problem seems to lift the load; the problem seems less important, or may go away altogether. When there are choices to make in life, I try to choose the path for growth – the path which, though it may not always be the easiest one, feels real. For me, a good criteria is to ask if this is the path that will bring me closer to the Divine and so make my life deeper and more significant.

Often I find it difficult to maintain balance in my life, particularly with conflicting family, work and personal needs. Long periods of time seem to be spent in mental overload. I can start to feel desperate when there are many things needing to be done at once, such as marking correspondence course essays, helping the children with their homework, putting the dinner on to cook, emptying the washing machine, feeding the cats and answering the telephone, and all right at the time when I want to start my meditation! All our spiritual practices are necessary to keep us balanced, yet usually some of these fall apart in times of stress. Despite the enormous workload my Guru took upon himself – working in every available moment, even dictating spiritual philosophy or songs while taking bath – he kept a balance in his life by taking time out morning and evening to walk and be near to nature. This is a beautiful model which I would like to be able to follow more closely.

Looking back over these years of my life, I can see how my spiritual development has unfolded. The struggles came in order for me to grow, and everything had its pur-

pose and came at the right time. My revolutionary marriage, I am sure, came about for my growth. The words of the spiritual marriage ceremony, in which each partner promises to care for the material needs as well as the mental and spiritual progress of the other, confirm this. I also feel that by combining my husband's and my strengths, we are able to give more to the world together than either of us could do alone.

And our two boys, with their cultural blending and birth into a spiritual family, will also contribute to society in their turn. Having children is a great joy which I once thought would never be mine.

After many years of indecision, my life's progress accelerated most when I let go of all my material securities and dove deeply into my spiritual path. I had to learn to surrender my ego, to accept problems and, above all, to take risks.



XVII

Sweet Dawn: Birthing into Wholeness

Kamala Alister

*Feminine Sanctuary
A dry world begs for the rain
of honest tears and honest laughter
Woman gives comfort, shares comfort,
feels and acts for the greening of life*

*Roots invisible and deep
feed in the waters of silence
Companionship with the Beloved
is the only thing that lasts.*

It was sometime in the dark hours past midnight. In the living room I was surrounded by candlelight and soft music and warmed by a wood fire and the loving attention of my husband, my midwife, and two close friends.

Despite this, I was moaning loudly enough to be heard in the far away hills. I thrashed around, clinging to my husband's hands with desperate intensity, trying to somehow squeeze some comfort into the extreme pain I felt with each contraction. I was giving birth, but at that moment, I was aware of nothing but pain and fear. My midwife whispered to me, 'Choose love, not fear.' Somewhere deep inside my mind, those few words helped me relax and surrender a bit more.

Labour was the most intense experience of my life. Although everything proceeded properly, I really felt in agony for eight straight hours. Despite being at home with people I love and trust, in front of a warm fire with beautiful *kiirtan* playing, I felt I was in the darkest hell all by myself.

'These reassuring, well-meaning helpers have no idea,' I thought.

My midwife is a deeply spiritual woman, a Tibetan Buddhist, which is also a Tantric path. During one of hardest moments, she said to me, 'Remember, there's so much help available to you in the universe.' Although I was not able to make a big shift, in a small way I remembered that birthing the baby was not up to me alone, that God also had a part to play. I began to pray out loud between contractions, asking Baba, asking the baby, to help. Later, instead of screaming, 'NOOOOO!' during pushes (which went on for two hours) I shifted, with great mental effort, to 'YESSSSS!' The women who were helping me told me afterwards that my mental shift changed the energy in the room, although I was not aware of it at the time.



In retrospect, that horrible night of birth was a tremendous initiation. The intensity was appropriate because between the early evening of one night and the dawning of the next day when the baby came out, pink and wide-eyed into the red-tinged water of the birthing pool, my life changed completely. I had become a mother, and everything was changed – forever!

I understood why native cultures often have terrifying and challenging initiation processes for men when they become adults, but not for women. Birth itself is the greatest initiation. For nine months you prepare. Your body and mind go through huge changes. You have no control over the time of birth. As the date approaches, you must be ready at any time of night or day, and often you must wait and wait, with total surrender. You have no way to know if the birth will be easy or hard, if the baby will be well or not, or what its personality will be. You can only wait and surrender. As the birth progresses, you don't know if you have two more hours or 24 more hours of the labour process to endure.

A few days after the birth I wrote: 'I feel so strongly that on that intense night I walked through a true door of initiation and transformation. I left behind an old self and an old life and walked through a huge pain, and a huge opening. Now I am putting myself back together, physically and emotionally, with gushes of tears, rushes of sweetness, wavering fear of the future, mixed with an intense grasp on the present which the baby enforces with his complete presence in the moment. I still feel I am in a sacred and opened-up space. My body is still changing and repairing. At night I have intense dreams. I have felt deep peace and

floods of love and bonding, along with some unexplained grief and crashes.'

For two weeks afterwards, I didn't leave the land of the community where we live, surrounded by rainforest-covered hills. Through the blessings of wonderful neighbours, dinner and nutritious vegetable juice and nut milk were delivered each evening. I was able to respect and guard the sacred energy that I felt following the tremendous opening between the worlds of seen and unseen on the night of the birth.

While the baby and remaining physical pain in my body kept me rooted in the physical reality, I was aware of being in a sacred spiritual/emotional space, tinged with gold dust. I found I couldn't look at newspapers or TV, or even open the refrigerator, because it brought my mind down palpably and I lost touch with my new reality.

Instead, I sat topless on the front verandah, feeding the baby in the morning sunlight, looking out over the trees and flowers that were just coming into bloom in the springtime. I kept the baby close in a front pouch while we took short walks, or held him close while I talked with visitors. I feel grateful for the opportunity I had to fully experience a deep initiation of womanhood.

The Abundance of Grace

My baby, Manikya, began wanting to feed on the first day. But there was no milk in my breasts yet, just a few drops of highly nutritious colostrum. For three days he sucked often and long, and still received almost nothing. On the morning of the fourth day, he latched onto a huge round breast that had filled with milk during the night, and choked and



sputtered with the sudden downpour of sweet, rich breast milk.

Breastfeeding is an ancient experience and unchanged in modern society. I feel it is a metaphor for the workings of the universe: the abundance of Grace. Like a baby, we must often rely on God without result. Still, instinctively, if we keep depending on our inner guidance, keep following the path of intuitional practice and reliance on God, then we get flooded in Grace.

Breastfeeding feels good to me and to Manikya. When my breasts are full, I look forward to his next drink to relieve the pressure. Does God also feel pleasure and comfort when we depend on abundant Grace? I think so!

Sweetness

Sweet Manikya

*In the dawn of a special morning
We experienced the miracle of birth
And each day you teach me the secrets
That only a mother and baby can share
The sweet touch of your gentle mouth
the steady gaze of your dark eyes
looking into mine with trust and curiosity*

*The sparkle of your first smiles
Spreads light into the universe.*

The Secret Love Affair

Now, nearly two years later, sometimes motherhood seems too mundane to write about. With an active two-year-old there isn't much time for reflection amid the scattered toys

on the living room floor, rounds of laundry and snacks, playgroups and playgrounds. When I do sit down I can expect to be pounced upon and my shirt pulled up because my thirsty or cuddle-hungry baby is ready for a nurse.

But the other night, when Manikya was asleep, I had a quiet moment to sort some of his baby photos. I found myself gazing at each precious one and realised... I am desperately in love!

What else could it be but a love affair? Our days begin before the sun rises when he wakes up and cuddles in for a long, sleepy nurse. Half asleep, I can't help but snuggle my face in against his silken, blonde head. As he becomes more active, I stroke his soft back and legs and play with his little, fat feet. Finally he pulls his little head out of his milk-induced *samadhi* and gives me a huge smile. Usually we end up in a tickle session before he rolls out of his bed, runs away and returns a minute later to drop a book on my sleepy head.

Our days end in a similar love-in. He rushes into our big bed (a double and single mattress taking up almost the whole bedroom floor) and rolls around laughing until I come in, scoop him up and pull back the covers. We cuddle up for a night nurse, and he gazes at me with his big eyes as I sing him songs, talk about the day and about God, and endlessly stroke him. After our busy day, he usually ends up nursing ME to sleep; we often end curled up in a heap, lost in soft dreams. Of course, by this time of the day I am exhausted after a busy day of chasing after a running toddler, putting up with rebellious tantrums, fulfilling endless urgent baby demands, and singing Baa Baa Black Sheep twenty-three times.



But motherhood for me is a life full of small sacrifices, richly rewarded with a heart filled with love. On the spiritual path, I have learned that it is good to sacrifice. I have slowly acquired gratitude for opportunities I find to serve others and to forget myself. Nothing is better for learning these lessons than motherhood! And it challenges me again to practice what I have learned about emotional healing when I try to find a balance between this endless sacrifice and the importance of sometimes putting myself first so I can have quiet times for meditation, creativity and exercise.

Baba said that devotional sentiment is the highest treasure of humanity. The devotional relationship I share with Manikya is implanting in him the deepest meaning of love. While it is hard work to be a full-time mum, I also believe I am doing more than caring for my baby's physical needs. I am planting a seed of devotion. Perhaps this little boy won't find it so difficult to feel God's infinite love and protection, or to form loving relationships built on sacrifice and commitment, or, as he gets older, to put children first.

As I reluctantly put aside my creative work because a toddler is tugging on my sleeve and demanding that I run outside with him and ride tricycles noisily up and down the verandah, I'm glad I have the support and understanding to put this busy life into perspective and to remember the passionate love affair that we are living. Serving Baba, serving Baby, serving Love.



XVIII

A Flower has Grown from the Tear that God Shed on the Desert of this World

Didi Ananda Devamala

As a young girl I always wanted to be free from all kind of convention and social imposition. I was in love with the spirit of the renunciate monks of the Franciscan order of my native country, Italy. To be simple like the birds in the sky, surrendering completely to God for their survival, was so attractive to me, just as the cinema and disco were to the youth of my age. I wanted to be useful and to serve too.

When I was 20 years old I met my living master. True to my Franciscan spirit, without a penny in my pocket I started to wander in the world and inside myself. I discovered new places and I opened my mind to new horizons. I met many smiles and many tears. At every obstacle my



yearning for the Supreme became stronger and stronger. I met goodness and beauty. It became my job and my very mission in life to dig up the gold of the human heart from the dust of poverty, depravity and suffering. At the feet of my master, who nourished me with the principles of a Neohumanist ideology, the aspiration of my early youth took a more definite form.

'This world is my home, all men and women are my fathers and mothers, all are my brothers and sisters, and the animals and plants are my younger brothers and sisters.'

This I would say to those who questioned me about my way of life.

For the last 10 years I have been in Thailand at the Thai-Burmese border. Most people here live in very poor conditions and many cases are desperate. I came intending to help heal the earth, which had suffered from illegal logging and the construction of a huge dam. But gradually my garden started to be enriched with human children.

'Didi, can't you help this child? She is very pitiful. She does not have a father. The family is starving.'

With this sentence, Joy, our first child, came to our house.

'The step-father wants to sell them!'

'Their mother had died and now their auntie is going door to door in my village trying to give the two girls away!'

'Her mother died of fever. She was only three days old. The father became crazy!'

'My husband has left me. My milk has dried up. I do not have milk for my baby!'

These were the sentences I heard, and I gradually became accustomed to hearing them. In many cases I did not have the heart to refuse to help. My house became more and more filled with children. For my children I had a special dream. I saw them in my vision full of light, a light that gives warmth and a promise of a brighter future.

That was how Baan Unrak (House of Happiness) started.

Our children's home in Sangklaburi is situated in a very beautiful area near one of the few remaining rainforests of Thailand. However, the beauty of the mountains and forests can't conceal the natural and human tragedy of the area. Our home is a painful reflection of the suffering of the people in this area: children are orphaned by the main killer, malaria. Other children are abandoned by their destitute mothers or sold, either in the hope that they might find a better future or to help out their impoverished families. Other children are the product of the war in Burma.

Yet the children are beautiful, like their forests and mountains. Baan Unrak tries to create a congenial environment for these children so that they will be able to unfold their inner potentiality and to preserve their culture and ethnic beauty.

In July last year, a mother with a very small baby of seven months came to our orphanage.

'Please take my baby! I can't take care of her anymore,' she appealed to us.

Soon we found out this woman was not the baby's natural mother. She was a poor village woman who fell in love with the baby's cute face and had decided to take care of her. She was poor, so she needed our assistance to maintain



the baby. Usually we help in such cases by giving milk or food. This time, however, the mother was not asking for milk.

'Why do you want to give the baby to us? You know we are ready to help you with milk and if necessary with some rice for you and your family.'

'I must work, and my elder children refuse to take care of her.'

'What about her real mother? Where is she?'

'The mother ran away, and her father has already died. I do not know anything more about her.'

'What about her relatives? Does she have any relatives?'

'I paid 1500 baht (about US\$40) for her. I do not know about her relatives.'

I took the baby in my arm. She was so cute. But her legs seemed to be very weak. I wondered if she would ever walk. As the woman left, she called lovingly to the baby. The baby turned to look and for the first time I saw the baby's beautiful smile. With her eyes filled with tears, the woman pressed a package of medicine that belonged to the baby into my hand and she ran away. Holding the new baby in my arms, I wondered at this exchange of love and its deeper significance.

We gave her the name of Kusuma, which means flower in Sanskrit. She was such a cherished flower. Everybody immediately loved her deeply.

'Didi, this is my baby,' said Bobo, a seven-year-old boy.

'No, this is my baby,' said Jnejne, a nine-year-old girl.

The children were competing with each other to hold Kusuma in their arms. She brought so much happiness into our home. Everybody played and laughed with her.

Her smile was indeed sweet and it seemed to communicate so much love. But Kusuma was in so much pain. Her left ear was badly infected and behind the ear there was a very deep wound that never seemed to heal.

Early one morning our home assistant, Wee, took the little baby to the mission hospital 20 kilometres away to see what was wrong with her. In the evening Wee returned, her usually smiling face very serious.

‘The hospital knows this baby very well,’ she told us.

‘All the nurses are concerned about her. They like this baby. Her father died in the hospital of AIDS. Her mother gave birth to Kusuma in the hospital. At the birth, the mother tested positive for HIV.’

‘Are you sure, Wee? Why didn’t the new mother tell us?’

‘The new mother did not know about this when she got the baby. The new family made a hole in the ear because they wanted to put in an earring but the hole never healed and started to get infected. They went to the hospital only one week ago. In the hospital they found out about the baby’s HIV status.’

‘God. After she went to the hospital and got the news, she came directly here and did not say a thing about this.’

‘This baby had five different mothers before coming to Baan Unrak. One of these mothers went to the hospital one month ago to check the baby’s blood. At that time she was



already HIV positive. The nurse thinks maybe the baby was sold to the next family at this time.'

Now our little Kusuma was laying on the floor near my knee, making soft noises. A circle of sad children squatted around me, whispering to each other. They were all anxiously waiting to hear what I would say. I looked at the helper I had employed to care for Kusuma. She turned her face away. She could not look at the baby.

Some children said softly, 'Didi, we can't keep her. She has AIDS.'

This was the first time the children had come into personal contact with this sickness and they were afraid. I always said to the children that I will take care of those whom nobody wants, those who are completely helpless. Now who was more helpless? Kusuma had been abandoned five times. Did I have to abandon her again? This would be completely against all my principles. Once I take a child, no matter what problems I have, I will never abandon her or him.

The children knew this, but they were afraid. I could not disregard their fear and my fear too.

Before I took in a new child I always used to consult the children, because we already had so many and to take another child meant that everybody had to make extra sacrifices. Now they were afraid and, maybe, in danger too. They waited expectantly for my decision.

'You don't need to worry anymore. I will take care of her myself,' I told them.

'But Didi, she has AIDS!' sixteen-year-old Soma said, 'Other children will become sick too.'

‘No! Not if we are careful. The baby will stay with me in my room, and until the baby is better nobody can come inside. Tarakanath and Janaki must go and sleep in the other room with the teacher,’ I told them.

Later, Soma came to my room. ‘Didi, how long will she live?’ Soma asked softly.

‘I do not know. I think not too long. I am only afraid of the pain that she has to go through before she will die. It is sad to take care of her only to watch her die.’

‘It is such a pity, isn’t it. She is so lovely.’

‘Kusuma will not be thrown away again, but I will have to look for more professional help since I do not know much about AIDS.’

Soma kissed the baby on the forehead and quietly promised, ‘I will help you, Didi’.

In the beginning it was very difficult. I had to refuse Soma’s help. Kusuma had many little wounds on her hands and I did not want to put Soma in danger. Kusuma was sick. Her stomach was very bad and she could not sleep. She also had a high fever and was crying constantly. I had to hold her all the time and did not get any sleep. Now not only was I running a home for 50 children, I also had to do all the washing and caring for this baby.

These were among the most terrible days of my life. I was alone, hopelessly fighting against a very powerful enemy.

Luckily Kusuma had a charm of her own. It did not take long before everybody in the house felt attracted to her again. Even when she was in the most pain, she never forgot to smile and look lovingly at everybody.



'Be careful, it might hurt the baby,' Janaki cautioned me while I was bathing Kusuma and gently rubbing her body with a bar of soap.

In a very short while, Kusuma became the centre of attention for all the children. She was indeed a little princess with so many little attendants while taking a bath, eating or playing. They started to love her, and day by day the children's fear dissipated.

'Why! This AIDS is not such a terrible ghost. How could it be? Kusuma is so lovely,' said Madhavi.

After a month nobody was thinking about sending her away anymore. Kusuma became our own; we did not want to give her to anybody. In our struggle to save her life, we met doctors and nurses. When they saw the baby, they too fell in love with her, just as the children had.

'You may be lucky. Check her again after six months. She might be one of the few babies that lose the HIV virus and suddenly become well.'

I was told that some babies born HIV positive will mysteriously become HIV negative within one or two years. Scientists simply don't know how this happens, nor can they explain why.

The doctors' words were like magic that filled my heart with joy and hope. When I had first taken Kusuma into my care, I had thought it would be only to watch her die slowly. Now I was determined to do anything to keep her alive.

In our home every evening before dinner, we gather together for quiet time and reflection, inspirational stories and to express ourselves. That evening I talked to the children about our baby.

‘Today at the hospital we found out there is a possibility Kusuma could survive. We must put together our good intentions. Our new hope will help her to fight her sickness.’

I knew from my experience as a yoga and meditation teacher and as a home-mother that hope is the key element for starting the healing process.

‘Do you know that little babies live close to the hearts and minds of the people who take care of them? They live with their hopes and their aspirations. Your little baby sister Kusuma lives with your heart and with your mind. Now we know that she can become well. Her heart will be full of hope and the process of healing will start.’

The children had already started to consider Kusuma as a blessing that had knocked at our door; she had brought so much liveliness and happiness. This collective positive energy yielded results almost immediately. The ear that had refused to heal now healed in only three days. From that day, the general condition of our little baby started to improve. Finally she became very strong.

‘Didi! Kusuma does not have AIDS any more!’ said Mala, eleven years old.

‘How can you say that?’ I asked

‘She does not have it. She is so happy!’

After a month had passed the children were so sure Kusuma was well that they asked me to take her for another blood test. They were sure she had won her battle for life.

So off we went to the hospital. The doctor advised us to wait and come back after six months. We stood firm and requested the test, so the doctor tested her himself. He was



concentrating intently on the blood sample while conversing with the nurse in the local Karen language. He was not too far from my Karen assistant and me.

I was tense and worried. Suddenly my assistant whispered in my ear, 'The doctor and the nurse are saying that maybe she does not have it anymore.' I hoped with all my heart that what my children had told me few days ago might have become true.

Casually the doctor came over to me and handed me the result paper. With a serious and professional manner, he said, 'HIV negative'. These very simple words created an explosion of pure happiness in my brain. I could see that underneath the doctor's seriousness he was pleased too.

Back home, the children swarmed around me as I entered the front gate. One after the other asked me questions. I also kept a very serious face and told them that Kusuma was not HIV positive anymore.

The children chorused, 'Really Didi, is she well already?'

'Yes, she is well!!'

The children received the news wildly. For a moment our front yard was transformed into a party hall. Some of the children who had stopped themselves from touching the baby were the most wild with happiness. We ordered ice-cream. The children passed Kusuma from one to the next. The yard echoed with the happy sounds of children chatting; the words 'Kusuma, Kusuma' were constantly heard. Kusuma, like a little queen, smiled sweetly down at them. It was such an unforgettably beautiful day.

However, our happiness did not last long. One day without obvious reason our Kusuma became depressed.

She started to become weak again. I felt uneasy. Even though it was against all logic, I was afraid she had been infected again with the HIV virus.

I took her to be checked again, this time in a different hospital. The doctor called me in his room and when he told me the result my heart sank: 'She is HIV positive.'

However the news did not discourage me. I already knew that it had been very easy to gain victory over such a great enemy. The most difficult part would be to communicate the news to the children, but I was determined and gathered all my courage. That evening at our usual meeting, I said:

'Kusuma has been sick lately and now she has the HIV virus again. Again we must be careful but we must never stop loving her. Love is her medicine. She is a little flower that grows on love. Like all children she has a healing power. She has done so much for our hearts. She has filled our lives with so much happiness and joy. She has taught us not to be afraid. Now more than ever we must believe she will become well. What is most important is that she will become well because of us.'

The children had no doubts that if Kusuma had been cured once, she could be cured a second time.

I tried all the natural medicines I had used before, but this time it was not the same. I had to change medicine constantly. I had to be creative with her diet because she could not eat anything.

It wasn't the same with the children either. This time they were not afraid; they were in love. Some children would hide and cry when Kusuma cried out in pain.



She started to develop wounds on her body, wounds that seemed to never heal. I tried everything I could think of to help her, but I restricted the treatment to natural remedies only. It wasn't easy. We feared that she could die at any time. Added to this she was in so much pain, especially when her wounds were being dressed. I could not take care of her alone. She would scream and twist her body. Sometimes two people were needed to help me and hold her while I administered the medication.

'Didi, I want to sleep with you and Kusuma!' This was Tarakanath, a seven-year-old boy who had also come to us as an emaciated seven-month-old baby.

'No! Tarakanath, you can't. Recently you had an accident and you have too many wounds and Kusuma has wounds too. You can't be near each other.'

'Mother, I want to be near my sister.'

'Not at the moment, Tarakanath.'

'Mother, will my sister become well?'

'Yes, she will.'

'Are you afraid, mother?'

'No, I am not.'

The time came for me to attend the annual meeting of our organisation. For the first time in many years it was to be held in Bangkok, and I had to go there. Kusuma was very sick and I could not leave her during this critical period.

I called my direct supervisor and said, 'Our youngest child, Kusuma, is very sick. I can't leave her in this condition. Please give me permission to bring her to the meeting with me.'

I wanted to attend the meeting for other reasons. Many great yogis working in our mission would be present to discuss social issues and the role of spirituality in facilitating social change. The environment would be spiritually charged. This would have a positive effect on the little baby and could bring about some change in the higher level of her mind. I was sure of this.

‘How can you bring the baby? These meetings are very intensive. You will not have time to take care of her!’

‘I can’t leave the baby, but I want to come to the meeting. I need to meet all my brothers and sisters. I need to be recharged spiritually. I am so exhausted!’

‘Definitely you should come, but you can’t bring the baby. Try to find someone else to take care of her.’

‘It is impossible, nobody can take care of her now. She is extremely sick. I am her mother now. No mother would leave her baby in this condition.’

‘The baby will become sicker on this long journey. She should not be moved around,’ my supervisor replied.

‘No, she will not become more sick. She too needs to be in a spiritual environment as much as I do.’

It was not easy to convince my superiors, but finally they agreed.

Preparations were made for the seven-hour journey to Bangkok.

‘Didi, you don’t need to worry, we will go with you and help all the time while you are in the meetings,’ said four of the big girls at the home. They were determined to go with me. No matter the hardships, I knew it would be worth it and I was happy.



After much difficulty, we arrived at the meeting place in Bangkok. As I got out of the car holding my sick baby, I came face to face with the Dada who was overall-in-charge for my area. He had been the hardest person to convince, not wanting me to bring the baby. He had seemed so hard in his e-mail and telephone calls. Now he was standing in front of me in his saffron robe and flowing white beard, with folded hands.

'Didi, you came!'

His eyes fell on the baby and his heart filled with compassion. 'Is this your baby?' he asked with damp eyes.

Then I went into the hall where all my sisters working in different countries were gathered together. As I entered, my supervisor came up to me with extended arms and embraced me. In a moment she had robbed me of my baby while all my other sisters surrounded me with enthusiastic greetings and questions. The baby didn't seem to mind being the centre of attention for strangers; on the contrary, she seemed to enjoy it very much. She seemed to recognise people, and everybody showed so much sympathy and love for her.

Besides the organisational meetings, several times were set aside each day for collective meditations. I always tried to bring Kusuma to these. The vibration was very beautiful, creating a feeling of peace and quietness. The baby was very quiet during those meditation hours, and I felt that she really enjoyed the vibration.

'She seems so peaceful and yet she has so much pain,' someone said.

'She is a great soul,' commented another.

Outside the meditation hall Kusuma was charming and smiling at everyone, and everybody liked to hold her. But she was really sick and her fever sometimes went up to 106°F. Everybody wished for the best for her.

‘Don’t worry, Didi, children have a great capacity to tolerate fever,’ said Kamala, a spiritual singer from Australia, as I looked worriedly at the thermometer.

‘My baby had a fever that high too, for many days. Of course it was not this dreadful sickness. Fever is their way of freeing their system of illness.’

After the meetings, I returned to Baan Unrak. Kusuma was still sick with a very high fever. Then suddenly all the wounds dried up. It was the end of December and it was very cold. Sangklaburi rarely has such cold days.

‘Two people died of cold yesterday,’ said Soma. ‘They were very poor and did not have any warm clothes.’

We did not have enough blankets for the children. We bought all the blankets in the village, and still there weren’t enough. We did not have enough sweaters and winter clothes. It became very difficult to protect our little babies, especially Kusuma. Every time we changed her clothes, no matter how quickly we did it, her fever would shoot up immediately. The fever stayed for another ten days.

After many days I looked at Kusuma and my heart sank. I thought, ‘Now she is going to die.’ She was so weak. I gave her a drug to reduce the fever and then I tried the last thing I could possibly do. I held her to my heart and silently talked to my master.

‘I can’t do anything more for her. Now please, you take charge of her.’ I surrendered everything to him. ‘If you want to give her back to us, we will gladly take her, but if



you want her to merge into the Infinite Self, we will remember her dearly.'

I watched and waited. There was a slight change in the weather, or so it seemed to me. It was not so cold anymore.

By evening, the little baby's fever was gone. Over the next few days the weather started to become more normal. The baby was free from fever for three days. Kusuma looked strong although she was still weak from the sickness. It looked like a miracle.

I took Kusuma to the hospital for a blood test. My heart was in tumult as I waited at the hospital, knowing this was our last chance. Kusuma was one year old now; this was the time when she could gain victory over the virus.

'You are lucky. The baby is HIV negative!' said the smiling nurse.

We were finally victorious.

In order to be completely sure, I requested a test for the virus itself because the usual test is for antibodies for the virus. I also went to another hospital for an antibody test, and this test was also negative.

After one month I went back to the hospital for the results of the test on the virus. The doctor came himself, smiling and waving the paper in my face.

'Your baby does not have the HIV virus. This is final! Here is the last result. She is free. The HIV virus is not in her body at all!'

Now, six months after these last tests, Kusuma is becoming really strong. She is moving on her own two legs like every little baby of her own age. She is full of life and joy. I give thanks to all those who have loved her, with special

thanks to all the children of Baan Unrak who, with their love and care, were active agents in the materialization of this miracle. And finally there is my spiritual master, Baba, who behind all the struggle was a source of love and strength.



XIX

My Experiences in Congo

Didi Ananda Bhaktidhara

During the war in Congo I was in the position to mobilise the Margiis of Brazzaville to help each other, while reminding them that we are all universal children of Baba.

Unexpectedly, I received a message from the sectorial secretary of Ananda Marga that I should go to Pointe Noire to pick up my passport, which he had just brought from Nairobi. He told me not to return to Brazzaville as it was not safe. After he left, I met a woman, Ishvari, who was going back to Brazzaville to join her husband. I felt intensely that I must be with the Margiis in their time of need. We went together.

In the train, the newly recruited militia were terrorizing the passengers. A militia man wanted to grab Ishvari's bag.

I fought him for the bag and the men became angry with me.

They said I was not a nun, that I was a spy working for Sassau and the rebels. They knew Sassau had brought many foreign mercenaries with his rebel army. They wanted me to get down from the train to be investigated. I refused. Ishvari held my hand and spoke with trembling fear, 'Didi, don't get off the train. Whatever happens, we must stay together.' I told her to repeat her mantra and to think only of Baba.

One militia man said that if I didn't get down, he would search my person to see if I was carrying any weapons. They wanted to undress me. Fear filled my mind but I struggled to think of Baba. Another militia man jumped on top of the seat and lay down on the luggage. He was very drunk. He said he was hot to see me.

Then a policeman whom I had met earlier came forward to talk to the militia man. I had told this policeman that I knew his captain, Kiese (a Margii called Muniish, who had become a legend by that time). The policeman and the militia man talked in their local dialect. Then they both looked at me savagely, swearing, 'Today you are saved.' They went together to another compartment of the train. I heard their brutal language as they grabbed a woman, pulled her to the floor and raped her in front of all the passengers. No one interfered because they had threatened to pull the pin on a grenade. For these militia, their machine guns and grenades were just toys.

When we reached Brazzaville, I tried to contact the government authorities to arrange to do relief work. At one



building that I had visited just ten minutes earlier, a bomb exploded, killing many people.

I met Muniish; he was very upset that I had come back to Brazzaville and, worse, that I was walking alone in the market place. He said it was too dangerous. He insisted that I should leave immediately to go back to Pointe Noire. I told him, 'Muniish, you should leave too. Your life is more precious for Baba's mission than to be killed for these political leaders.' There were tears in his eyes as he told me that Lissouba's government was losing the battle.

I found out most of the Margiis had left Brazzaville. Only those who were directly involved in the fighting remained. So I decided to follow his advice. Muniish told a remaining Margii brother, Danaviir, to escort me back to the train station.

Bullets and missiles were raining everywhere. I ran to catch the train before it left for Pointe Noire. But a militia man stopped me. He took me to their headquarters for investigation. Their chief wasn't there, so they could not decide whether I was a 'spy'. They took me in a heavily armed car to the President's compound.

Danaviir was very frightened. I told him to go to inform the Mayor that I had been arrested. I had explained a lot about Ananda Marga to the Mayor during the previous year while we were cleaning the streets of Brazzaville. By now, he had become the Prime Minister. He called the militia headquarters and talked to the chief of the militia. He said I was a missionary and that I must be released.

Meanwhile, just as the car I was travelling in arrived at the President's compound, Muniish came out and saw me. He was very surprised. I told him they suspected me of

being a spy because I had a map of Brazzaville in my bag. Muniish talked to the militia and told them to release me. He ordered them to provide me with security back to the train station.

When I arrived, the train had left. The next morning I sent Danaviir to the militia to get the 'pass certificate' I would need to travel. When the militia man saw Danaviir he was very nervous. He told him he had been looking for Didi for the entire night because the Prime Minister kept calling him and threatening that he would be in serious trouble if he did not find her. He told Danaviir to take me to the train immediately.

When I reached the station another bomb exploded and the authorities cancelled the train. It was announced that the train would not be coming to Brazzaville, and that the passengers would have to go to the next town to catch the train. Immediately there was a panic to find cars to go to the next town. People were running and fighting to climb into empty cars.

I saw the car of the son of the Mayor, but it was gone before I could reach it. Frustrated, I thought of Baba. All of a sudden, an empty car was standing in front of me. I climbed in. Soon a huge crowd of people came fighting each other to sit on top of me. On the way there it rained heavily. We all got soaked. I saw a young girl crying in pain as she was crushed by all the bodies in the car. Everyone was shouting and fighting with each other. At that moment, I felt so much pain for the suffering people of Congo. I started to cry.

When we reached the station in the next town the last train was waiting, but Lissouba's militia, who were losing



the war, were trying to get away from Brazzaville. By force they took the train for themselves. They literally threw all the passengers out of the train. A militia man pushed me off the train and I fell into a hole full of water. It was still raining heavily. I was completely soaked.

As Danaviir and another Margii brother and I walked away from the train in total frustration, we heard a voice calling, 'Didi, Didi, Didi.' I turned and saw a huge man with a black T-shirt telling me, 'Didi, you come here.' He was in the last coach of the train. I said that the train was only for the military. He said, 'Don't believe them. You come here.'

Thinking of my previous experience with militia, I hesitated to do what he said. Then I thought of Baba and asked whether I should trust this man. The man smiled, and something inside me felt confident that I could trust him. I moved close to the train. The militia had closed the doors. The man told me to put my foot on the train's wheel. I did so and he pulled me up through the window. As I put one foot inside, the train started to move. I shouted to the two Margii brothers to hurry and climb up.

When all three of us were safely inside we turned to thank the man. He had disappeared. We searched everywhere, searched the entire train, but the man was not to be found. Danaviir returned from his search saying, 'Didi, that man was truly a mystery man'.

I was the only woman on the train. Most of the militia were heavily drugged or drunk. The Margii brothers and I were drenched from the rain, and I told them we should move away from the window. A militia man who was sitting near the door spoke to me, 'Sister, you stay here, I

will take care of your security. You won't need to worry about anything as long as I'm with you.' This man was short and slim in his thirties. He had a fierce-looking scar from his forehead down to his nose and from his lips to his chin. He looked so frightening that even the other militia men were afraid to speak to him.

Other groups of militia men were questioning me about why I was on the train. This man with the scar shouted at them to shut up because he was responsible for me and the two brothers. Again another group came to tell me that I should pay money because this was a military train. And again this man told them, 'Class (short for classmates or comrades), I'm responsible for this good lady and these two men, so you should not harass them.' When he called me 'good lady', he pushed me hard on the shoulder and I fell off balance, which started Danaviir laughing.

Many times the militia inspectors came to harass us for identification or money and so on. Each time this man would answer for us.

I became interested in finding out more about him. I asked him many things. I asked him for his name. He said it started with the letter 'A'. 'Okay,' he said, 'you can call me Albert.' He smiled and I noticed he had one tooth missing. I asked him where he was going and he replied 'Pointe Noire'. 'What will you do there?' I inquired. He said, 'I want to see my little girl. I have a little daughter just like you.' As he said these words, I actually felt a wave of fatherly affection coming from him.

I asked him so many questions to engage him in conversation. But he never asked me anything. He just remained calm and quiet. Four or five times I asked him where he



would stay in Pointe Noire and whether he would give me his address. He always said that when we reached the station in Pointe Noire, he would write it down for me.

In the evening, I felt very tired and cold. The man arranged our bags and told me to sleep. He assured me that he would take care of us while we slept. He started singing a song that caused other militia men to join in. Then he sang alone, and everyone listened and laughed as he sang his song. The meaning of the song was:

The war, the war, it's not good, it's not good.

Your wife will become a corpse,

You also will become a corpse.

Everybody will become a corpse.

The war, the war, it's not good, it's not good.

When we reached Pointe Noire, I asked him to write down his address for me but he told me, 'Don't worry. I will be the one to visit you. I know where you live.' I asked him when he would come. He said, 'Tuesday, at four o'clock'.

Tuesday arrived. In excitement I went to the *jagriti* (Ananda Marga centre) to meet him. I sat in the reception room with Baba's photo in front of me. But the time passed and my visitor didn't arrive. I waited until five o'clock, and then until six o'clock. I thought to myself that I had been so sure he would come because he had promised me in such an affectionate manner. I was starting to feel sad that he had broken his promise.

As I was gazing at Baba's photo, I began to look closely at Baba's smile. He was smiling at me. I suddenly realised that Albert's smile had been so similar to Baba's smile. The

photo of Baba had been taken just after Baba had lost a tooth. I did *dhyana* (meditation on Baba) immediately. I felt such a special vibration emanating from Baba's sweet smile and affectionate gaze. Tears fell from my eyes. A sense of gratitude overwhelmed my whole being. I could feel Baba's affection for me and I was aware of the fatherly care Baba had been taking of me all the time.

Baba is, indeed, my eternal guide. He is my love, my everything, and the source of my life. In him I have taken refuge.

At that moment I took a new vow to serve him, to please him more by serving him sincerely through his mission and serving this suffering humanity.



XX

Sweet Gympie

Didi Ananda Mainjusa

On the 30th March 1991 I came to Australia. I was posted to Gympie, to the Global Basic Training Centre for women volunteers working in Ananda Marga. I had worked for ten years in different parts of my native India, but this was my first time outside India. I was not accustomed to different cultures or foods, so this posting was a big challenge for me.

My training centre was in the countryside, half an hour's drive from the beautiful small town of Gympie. For four and a half months I lived at the training centre with Didi Ananda Vijaya and some trainees, and I was happy finishing my training sessions with them. But then Baba began my tests, one by one.

After those first months I was alone. I had come from India where everything is very busy. Now I was living in a remote part of Australia. There was no electricity at the Training Centre and at night it was very dark.

I was too scared to go out and I was scared inside the house too. Sometimes I thought I should read a book or do some indoor work but I didn't because I was so afraid. I was scared that a snake might come inside the house, or a robber might break the window or door, or there might be a big storm that would damage my house. Every afternoon at 5.00 pm I locked my windows and doors. I would go to bed and fall asleep.

Nearly a month passed and it was time for me to do *ka-palika* (graveyard) meditation. When I went outside it was very dark. I had a torch but the light was weak. Also I was worried that if I turned my torch on, someone might see me and interrupt my meditation. The next *kapalika* was better though.

I did not know what to do. I felt full of conflict. But the positive part of my mind reminded me of when I went to Baba for my personal contact. Baba had asked me, 'How are you, my little girl?' I had replied, 'Very good Baba'. Then he asked me, 'When I send you very far, will you be scared?' I had said, 'No Baba, you are always with me'.

Baba had laughed and said to Didi Ananda Karuna, 'You see, she is very intelligent.'

Baba had said he would send me very far, but while I was at Gympie I came to realise that didn't mean far from Him. Gympie seemed a lonely place, but I knew that Baba was always with me. I understood that I did not need to be afraid of anything. If anything happened Baba would save



me. In fact, nothing dangerous happened to me while I was at Gympie, and my courage grew steadily. But the tests of my Beloved did continue.

In those days I could only buy brown rice in Gympie, no white rice, so I could not eat properly and felt hungry all the time. I started to feel uncomfortable.

I had a car but I did not know how to drive, so the car was useless to me.

Sometimes I thought I heard a big crowd of people coming towards my house and I felt cheered at the prospect of company. But when I looked towards the verandah I could not see any people, only big waves of wind playing in the trees. I was very sad. There were no people coming.

My neighbour, Eric, sometimes took me to town for shopping, and sometimes I rang him for talks. This was almost my only contact with people. There were no other neighbours. I did not know any people in town. There was the language problem too. Many times people could not understand what I was saying. I was starting to feel quite distressed.

One day Didi Ananda Sampurna rang, asking me how I was. I could not stop myself crying. She told me some stories of courage and said she thought one volunteer worker should be with me. A few days later she sent me a woman volunteer worker. When she came I felt a bit better but we weren't comfortable with each other. A few weeks later she left to do a course to comply with government regulations for unemployment benefits. So she went off for her training course, and she took my phone key with her!

Then I was really alone. I could not drive. I had no companion with whom to share my feelings. My difficulties

with English prevented me from talking to people. I could not eat properly and felt hungry all the time. I had no phone key. If anything happened, I could not phone my neighbour.

I walked to Eric's house and told him I had no phone key. He was upset too and let me use his phone to ring my volunteer worker. I asked her to send the key by post. I rang her a few times but she never sent the key to me. Now it was all getting too much for me.

It was a long time since I had seen Baba. I wanted Baba to appear physically in front of me and bless me. But this was not possible. I did not know how to settle my distress. I thought deep in my mind that if Baba came to me in a dream and blessed me, I would be free from all these feelings of turmoil. But Baba did not come in a dream. I was sure that without Baba's blessing I could not recover from my state of distress. What could I do?

I thought I needed to do a long meditation. I began but I could not concentrate. I was very frustrated. After that I thought I should do a long *kiirtan*. *Kiirtan* and meditation are not so different. So I started a long *kiirtan*. Soon I felt my throat becoming sore. Still Baba did not come.

Kiirtan and meditation were not helping me. All I could think about was that Baba was not coming.

I started to think Baba was not coming because I must not have enough good *samskaras* (consequences arising from karma). I thought maybe that if I didn't have enough good karma I must be a bad person, and then I started to want to be bad. I didn't want to practise meditation or follow the Sixteen Points of yogic discipline prescribed by Baba. I wanted to do what I liked, even if it went against



Baba's regulations. However I found it very hard to stop meditating and following the Sixteen Points.

In the morning when I got up I didn't want to meditate but I felt someone forcing me to do meditation. Finally I stopped meditation in fear.

One night I went to bed without finishing my meditation. When I was half-asleep I heard someone walking in my room; I thought maybe it was a robber who might kill me. I was really scared. Closing my eyes I pulled my bed sheet up and covered myself. I did not want to hear anything or see who was walking in my room. At some point I fell into a deep sleep.

Then I could hear someone calling me, saying 'Look at me'. I knew this voice. I answered Him, 'No.' I felt very emotional. Then he sat beside me, touching my head. I felt a very beautiful peaceful feeling. My whole body was trembling. It seemed to me that His hand was moving very slowly in a fatherly way down my back. He was saying, 'You should not stop your meditation. It is very painful for me.'

When I heard these words I could not contain myself any longer. I started crying loudly and telling him, 'Who could wish to cause you pain?' I said I would not stop my meditation any more.

I got up but I was still crying. I sat in meditation. It was a long time before I opened my eyes. The sun was rising. It was exquisitely beautiful.

I felt newly born with Baba's blessing.

XXI

Tantric Struggles: On a Roller Coaster Towards Heaven

Didi Ananda Udaya

What does it mean to be a Tantric woman? For me, it symbolises a never-ending fight with the forces of darkness which exist both within us and without. The challenges I have met are manifold and the rewards, after passing one obstacle after another, are exquisitely beautiful. In this way I feel I have been 'on a roller coaster towards heaven'.

It is often said that one has to reach a point where one learns to embrace one's difficulties and find the bliss beneath all the struggle. The great yogi Milarepa faced so many physical hardships and tests from his master until he was finally graced with the highest realisation. In my own life, the tests of physical hardship have come in different



ways, either through pain inflicted upon me from outside, or pain experienced from within as a result of severe disease. (I prefer to use this word, 'dis-ease', as it is less static than 'sickness'.) In all these instances, the lesson for me has been to remember that I am just playing a role allotted to me in this great Cosmic drama and to find, beneath the chaos, the calm. It has been helpful for me to remember the words of my Guru:

In reality, I am neither very happy nor very miserable, I am not an erudite scholar nor a fool. I am merely acting a particular role – be it Emperor or beggar. If people remember this they will neither be afflicted with sorrow nor elated with joy.

Shrii Shrii Anandamurti, in *Subhasita Samgraha Part II*, 1991: pp. 80/94.

In 1990 I was bound for India when one of these dramas unfolded for me. It was at the time when Baba had just left his physical body. Many of his students and disciples were travelling to India to bid a final farewell.

I arrived in India at Calcutta airport. After I had passed through immigration, I was called aside by an officer who had found my name on a list of 'blacklisted' persons.

The practice of 'blacklisting' certain persons began under the dictatorial government of Indira Gandhi who tried to prevent unwanted foreign nationals from entering the country under Section 3.2.E of the Foreigners' Act. (I was born in Germany). Ananda Marga had been harassed consistently by the government of Indira Gandhi. The Ananda Marga organisation's opposition to the caste system and its insistence on the protection of basic human

rights brought it into stark opposition to Indira Gandhi's policies. Many members of Ananda Marga in India were jailed, and the Gandhi government also sought to ban members of Ananda Marga who came from overseas from entering India.

So I was detained for several days in Calcutta airport, along with a monk of our organisation (who had been born in India, but who held an Australian passport).

I physically fought with four policewomen, each one holding one of my limbs, to avoid and delay being deported. I shouted at the policewomen, 'Don't touch me, I know karate!' But finally they overwhelmed me and dumped me onto a trolley to take me to the plane. Once we were on board the plane, Dada spoke forcefully to the pilot, who then refused to carry out the deportation order. As a result, the deportation was avoided.

After we were brought back to the airport lounge, I collapsed exhausted, half-dead, onto a seat. In that moment I realised that I could give my life for my beliefs, if ever it got to that point. Even with much physical struggle and putting up with the inconvenience of being detained in an airport without proper facilities, I had many blissful meditations.

After some days, another attempt was made to deport us. This time, I played sick. I curled myself up as if I was in pain, and nobody dared to touch me.

The monk with whom I was detained spoke Bengali, the local language, and was able to convince our guards to support us. Finally we were able to contact Ananda Marga in Calcutta. Our deportation was avoided as we began a court challenge to the deportation order.



During the court case, Dada and I were detained in various hotels around Calcutta. We would be escorted quite a long way, almost 40 kilometres, to the court in the centre of Calcutta. One of the police officers who used to accompany us regularly to the court said to me, 'We know you are not dangerous people. This is just a political case.'

Being in detention was not such an unpleasant experience for me since I had my internal world to sustain me. I did a lot of yoga exercises to improve my unstable health and practiced a lot of meditation. At times, I would cry out in spiritual longing, but then I would feel the soothing touch of the Divine. At these times, the words of my spiritual teacher would come to mind, 'To realise an entity one must possess a loving heart, a sweet intellect, and a free flow of emotion' (Shrii Shrii Anandamurti in *Namah Shivaya Shantaya*, 1989: p. 148).

During that time, several nanny goats and their kids used to come to the back of the place where we were being detained and I fed them food scraps and left-overs. In this way, I became the 'mother of mothers'.

Finally, after three months, I was released and allowed to leave the country. I had the opportunity to make a final remark to the court. I said I was sad that I had come for a dignified purpose to this country with a long spiritual tradition and that I had been treated in such an undignified way. I had never committed any crime and yet my name had appeared in many newspapers, saying I was considered an unwanted element.

In the end it was five years before the case was finally won. Dada was in detention for the whole of that period. Our lawyer, a renowned barrister, said this kind of incredi-

ble case could only happen in India. Our case highlighted the many injustices to which Ananda Marga had been subjected by the Indian government.

Certainly the long struggle was rewarding in many ways. I realised I could no longer feel sad that my master had left physically, because during this ordeal I had felt his presence in so many ways.

One of my heaviest tests was yet to come. Just before my departure, I developed a very high fever. The doctor suspected I had typhoid. Then I also developed an intolerance to the strong antibiotics that had been prescribed for me. Calling on all my remaining strength, I managed to step onto a plane bound for Bangkok, where I stayed in the hospital until the fever was finally under control. By the time I reached the Philippines, my temperature was again very high. I could neither sleep nor eat and felt that I was almost ready to die. Finally, a naturopath helped me with relatively simple herbal remedies.

I remember our master saying to one of his disciples, 'I want to make you great but you will have to pass through some suffering.' I used to feel inspired, or as Abraham Maslow calls it 'meta-motivated', to work under the most difficult circumstances. Be it an earthquake, a typhoon or a volcanic eruption, each of these calamities made me aware of how lucky I was to be able to help others at a time when their need was great. In these situations of extreme hardship I experienced so much love and guidance from within that I always felt protected and knew I would be unharmed. Certainly I had to endure some physical struggles and discomfort but I was extremely alert and grateful to be



without fear and to have compassion for others who were enduring more than I was.

Recently, when I was confronted by the diagnosis of a seemingly incurable disease, I did not feel so shocked, yet other peoples' reactions to my diagnosis made me feel sad. They could not really understand that I did not feel so attached to my body.

I had known intuitively for a long time that something was wrong, and I was upset because I had had to push the doctors to find out what the problem was. Some of the doctors wanted to treat me with strong antibiotics, which I refused to take. From my point of view, I felt I had just entered another phase of my life, moved into another realm, and would be having realisations of a different kind.

After the initial shock and adjustment to the diagnosis, I gradually regained my confidence and began to develop something of the spirit Socrates described when he said, 'I am not lame, my leg is lame.' These tiny deaths are required to be born into the real freedom life offers.

'Die and become,' the great German writer Goethe said, 'Till thou hast learned this, thou art but a dull guest on this dark planet' (Dorothy Phillips, Ed., 1975: p. 45).

I went to a naturopath who said that in order to be fully cured I had to also work through the emotional upset accompanying the disease. And I was led to a place where I could do that. I visited a very spiritual place, which had a strong impact on me. I felt completely insecure, as if my ego had been shattered to pieces. It was like an earthquake was happening in my mind. But at the same time, I remembered the spirit of my *kapalika* meditation, the goal of which is to overcome fear. I remembered that the ultimate

goal is to completely lose one's ego and develop complete surrender, called *prapatti* in Sanskrit, and to be guided only by the Cosmic will.

I feel that with a positive mind I can overcome any kind of obstacle. I am sure I will never give up the fight, no matter how big the obstacle may seem. Where there is a will there is a way, and we just need to be patient enough to let each problem take its course towards its solution, provided of course we live a life in harmony with spiritual principles.

As the great German mystic Meister Eckhart says:

The wood does not change the fire into itself
but the fire changes the wood into itself. So
we are changed into God, that we shall
know Him as He is.

(Colledge, McGinn & Smith
1981: pp. 257-258).



XXII

Didi Ananda Kalika: A Life of Service

Kate Kazony

Didi bursts through the doorway, an excited twinkle in her large blue eyes.

‘I’ve just done something impulsive, on the spur of the moment. I don’t know if I should have...’

I hold my breath and wait.

After a month and a half of working with Didi Ananda Kalika in the Lotus Children’s Centre in Mongolia, I’ve come to know that anything surprising can occur at any moment and that it’s best to be prepared for the unexpected.

‘I’ve brought home eight new children!’ she exclaims, with as much shock in her voice as the shock which strikes my mind.

‘Eight more children?’ I muse out loud. It is a bit difficult to grasp, given that yesterday we were discussing how to fit in the 25 children who will soon return from the Summer Camp in the countryside. The babies’ house is totally full with small infants, and the toddlers will need to move into the *gers* and small sheds which the older children and teenagers are currently occupying. (A *ger* is a traditional Mongolian round tent made of felt.)

So suddenly another eight are to join the family!

Didi smiles at me. ‘I just couldn’t help myself. I took them out of emotion. They were hungry and crying to get into the car. I just couldn’t leave them behind.’

That morning Didi had gotten up early. She had been invited to visit a hospital in the countryside which housed mostly patients with intellectual disabilities. She was to see a three-year-old girl whose parents had left her there, but who had no apparent disorders. The hospital staff was concerned that the girl needed to be moved to a more suitable environment to be able to develop normally. So Didi had headed off with the idea that she may be returning with one new girl for the Lotus Centre.

But when she arrived at the hospital, she found rooms full of up to 20 children who were suffering because there was not enough money to feed them all. Some had slight physical disabilities, and some were also slow in their mental development. But many were able to talk to her, and to ask to be taken away.

The hospital staff were also worried about their charges. They told Didi that the situation for these children was very difficult. There was not enough room for them all. A nurse then led Didi out of the children’s wards and into the



adult section, where younger children were forced to live amongst adults with mental disabilities.

In that ward Didi met a woman who was slightly retarded. She was taking care of a two-year-old child who had been abandoned, but who was normal in all respects of her development. With great feeling the woman pleaded with Didi to take this little girl because if she grew up in the hospital she would have no future at all. Didi agreed.

Immediately the staff began to make requests on behalf of other children, explaining that at the hospital they did not have enough resources to clothe or educate these children and were concerned that the children weren't getting enough to eat to grow up healthy.

Within a few moments, as Didi was explaining she could manage perhaps five children, the nurses had the children lined up and were writing the children's names on pieces of paper and stuffing them down the children's shirts.

Didi was shocked. She had expected the director would prepare five children for a future time so that she would have the opportunity to prepare her staff back at the Lotus Centre.

But no, it all happened so quickly. The children themselves understood this was a chance to go to another home so many began to join the line, pleading with Didi to take them. She couldn't refuse their appeals.

And so, finally, eight were loaded into the jeep. They sat on laps and between the seats to fit in. During the long journey home, Didi had tried to reconcile her feelings with her concerns for her overworked staff, the existing space

problems, and the need for more specially trained staff to work with some of these children who had special needs.

Despite all this, she maintained that something felt right; she was extending the homes' resources to benefit some of the most unfortunate people.

These children had been completely discarded. In Mongolia a stigma is often attached to children who are seen as not normal. This attitude was reflected in the names of two of these children.

'What's your name?' she asked two of the older boys.

'Don't know,' replied one.

'Don't care,' answered the other.

Finding these answers strange, Didi reached into their shirts to see what the staff had written.

Sure enough, 'Don't know' and 'Don't care' were printed on the papers that bore their names.

At the Lotus Children's Centre, we now have around 50 children (in the year 2000)⁵, living in a babies' home, two sheds with three rooms between them, and two family-sized *gers* which usually house five to eight people. The children often sleep two to a bed, or lie together in a long

⁵ The centre has grown considerably since this chapter was written. By mid-2007, the Lotus Children's Centre had grown to provide a home for 150 children. For more information visit <http://www.lotuschild.org/>



row sharing their futons, sometimes with three or four children under one cover.

There is such a need for these children in Mongolia to be in Didi's care. Without a home at the Lotus Children's Centre, some would have to return to the streets where, if they were picked up by the police, they would be locked up in detention centres or delivered to institutions that have insufficient resources to keep them, such as the hospital that Didi visited.

In the past weeks, Didi has been working on a design for a new building, a two-storey home, where all the children can live comfortably together with enough rooms for sleeping, studying, recreation and eating.

As we sit in her office, a small room furnished like a family living room, two toddlers pry open the door. One plonks herself down in Didi's lap while Didi, somewhat nonplussed, continues to talk house designs. Then she suddenly switches track and holds up the small girl for me to see.

'Doesn't she look better now?' Didi beams with all the pride of a mother. 'You see how much fatter she is, since her fever stopped last week?' The previous week Didi had been up most nights, nursing and fretting over this particular child who had suddenly taken ill and was deteriorating dangerously. Whenever any of her children becomes ill, there could be no more concerned parent than Didi. She will sleep in the hospital, take a child into her own bed, stay up monitoring temperatures or drips for nights on end, to keep a small baby alive. Her actions are totally selfless.

So is the plan for the new home. She talks of how to develop the children's minds by providing a library and study and computer areas for the eldest. There will be space enough for the smaller children to play happily indoors during the long winter, giving their bodies room to stretch and develop properly. As she talks about the details of each room, I have to remind her that she also needs a room to live and work in. I think that if she were not reminded to provide for herself, she would just as likely end curled up with a group of these tiny tots snuggling under her arms.

In the centre of this new building will be a space for the children's theatre, to enable the children to sing and express themselves. The minds of the smaller children between the ages of four and seven still dwell in fantasy and magic, and these little ones love to act and sing and dress up like fairies. The older children also enjoy theatre, and now the centre is seeking to employ a trainer in circus and theatre skills to develop the children's self-confidence and abilities. For they have many songs to sing and stories to tell about their lives before and since coming to this large yet unique family.

These children know they are unique too. It shows in the smiles on their faces and, as they grow older, in their expectations that life always gets better.

Today there was a meeting with the oldest teenagers, those between 15 and 18 years of age, to discuss their futures – the studies they want to pursue, the jobs and careers they hope to follow. We talked about how much they have changed since entering the home six years ago, and how



much Mongolia is changing as capitalist systems take over from communism.

And the children reminded me of how much the Lotus Children's Centre has also changed and grown over the years. What had begun as a daily program for street children quickly grew into a home for destitute children, with all the children living together with Didi and a few volunteers in a small two-roomed house. During that time the older children spent their time caring for their younger brothers and sisters. Then Didi helped them to go to the local schools and eventually built a kindergarten for the younger children of the home and locals.

As the numbers swelled, Didi looked for more ways to house them. An infant centre was built for newborn babies where they are looked after by Mongolian staff and overseas volunteer nurses who help with staff training.

As more requests for help continued to arrive on the doorstep each day, Didi began to look for other ways to help the families who were too poor to keep their children. And so the soup kitchen was started to provide a hot lunch each day to local families who cannot afford to eat regularly. With the mothers and children being fed, it becomes possible in some cases for children to remain at home with their families, a much better situation than a child losing its parents.

Didi also found that many people in the area could not clothe themselves sufficiently for the long winter, nor could they afford medicines prescribed by the hospitals. Many of the households cannot afford coal and sometimes have insufficient heating for weaker household members, especially children, to survive the harsh winter conditions of

down to minus 30 Celsius. So Didi also distributes medicine and clothes to people around the area, often making home visits to see people who cannot come to the Centre themselves.

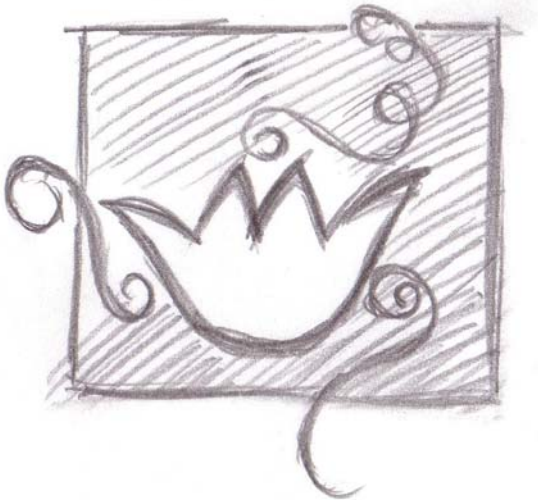
Her work is glorious. She is continually saving and improving the lives of hundreds of people each day.

And, as I come to know her more through daily interactions and working together, I see that this life of total service is full of the unexpected. And I see that Didi Ananda Kalika is herself full of the most wonderful of surprises.



Part Three

Feeling Our Love



XXIII

World Without Walls

Didi Ananda Gaorii

Again a turbulent few days, travelling from Berlin to the far north-east corner of Poland through monochromatic, snow-covered terrain and snow-filled skies. Was it loneliness evoked by the cold scenery, or trepidation caused by unfamiliarity with the arduous route, that made me so vulnerable that day to human approach?

It's true that the bleak day made me contemplate the dispassionate nature of God's love in comparison with the temporary, yet comforting, warmth of human intimacy. I was struggling to resign myself to God's stark stillness, while enjoying the flickering memories of human love, when a doctor who was doing AIDS research struck up a conversation with me. He spoke fine English, and was pol-

ite and refined in his behaviour. I needed to change trains in his hometown, and I asked him to guide me to the right train at the small station where I would make the change.

It was already dark when we arrived. I was thankful for his presence and his command of the Polish language which was so unfamiliar to me. He guided me to my train and, after making enquiries, explained to me the exact times of the subsequent changes I would have to make. Then, as he stood at the door of the carriage I had just boarded, a curious exchange took place.

‘I know it’s strange,’ he said, ‘for you don’t know me and I don’t know you, but I don’t feel good about letting you go on alone like this, in the dark, to a place you don’t know, and in this weather. So if you like, please stay at my place tonight and go tomorrow.’

I was taken aback by the sincerity of his request. I expressed my desire to proceed with my journey, but I must admit there was hesitation in my voice. As I had expressed to him on the train, I was, myself, a little fearful of the unknown way ahead and uncertain of reaching my desolate destination.

‘Please – I really don’t know why I’m saying this, I don’t usually invite strangers home – but please reconsider. You still have time to change your mind. I live with my parents, so you can feel safe at my home. Go tomorrow.’

It was not just an exchange of words. It was an exchange of hearts, of the sentiments of a man and a woman in a peculiarly poignant situation. I was touched by his sincerity and it softened my response. I was mesmerised by the strength of his insistence, and almost blinded by it into a false sense of security to which women so easily fall prey in



the presence of a protective man. I was flattered by his approach and, being afraid of the unknown track ahead of me, I swayed, I vacillated, as I was perched in the open carriage doorway. It took all the strength of my conviction in my path; it took faith in my Lord that He would see me safely to my goal; it took the remaining thin, thin thread of my rationale to, in a hesitant voice, barely demur. The door slammed closed, the train started, and I sank gratefully into the worn seat in the over-heated compartment.

What if I had gone with him? What if we had spent more time exchanging our thoughts? From where arose this flickering fascination to know this stranger, and to let him know me? Could this attraction happen with anybody, with any stranger, who happened to cross my way? Why had our paths crossed so simply and yet so poignantly? And now will that fated crossing just fade into oblivion in the vast Cosmos? How sad! And yet, why not? I meet a million people every day; I cross their paths and they cross mine. Our crossings bear no conscious consequences in our lives, our separations evoke no sadness. What made it sad in this case? Was it just because he touched my female sentiment on that night when I was so vulnerable, that he flattered my ego and aroused my curiosity? Or was it because, in that brief exchange, I genuinely perceived the compassion and depth of his intelligent personality, as he had perceived similar qualities in me, such that our further exchange would have provided food for our souls? Yet that was not to be.

In this age, even those with the purest of intentions cannot escape the influence of the morally degenerate collective psyche and lax social mores. In this age, I had to

forfeit the chance to get to know another sentient soul. Our meeting now shimmers insignificantly across the Cosmic space as a line already sung, a note already played in the opera of this planet Earth, performed unwittingly by puppet players on that particular snow-bound day.

Finally I reached my desolate destination, an isolated farmhouse in the stark and frozen winter wastes of north-east Poland. It was half past ten at night. My sister, a young Filipino nun, was shocked out of her uneasy sleep by my noisy arrival. To wake her I had to shout her name loudly and bang hard on all the windows of the house, because I didn't know in which room she was sleeping. Perhaps at first she thought it was the drunks who had, a couple of times, come knocking around the house at night. She must have been afraid, for she was alone, her usual companion sister having gone to Germany to fundraise in the Christmas markets. However she was expecting me and, as it was her name that I was shouting, in the end she responded and appeared, bleary-eyed and shivering, at the door.

She welcomed me into the house, which was as freezing as the weather outside. She had no heating, except for a tiny fan heater whose warmth extended for only about 30 cm from its face. The coal for the central heating system had run out some time ago, and Didi had no money to buy more. When I arrived, she had only 25,000 zloty to her name – about \$US1.50.

She greeted me warmly and offered me hot milk to drink. Milk fresh from Marguerita, the cow, whom she had milked earlier that evening. I consumed it thankfully. Although the house was cold, I was happy to have reached my destination. All my fears could at last be put aside. I



bathed in the light of her spiritual company, my sister nun, and my own nun's heart opened up in mutual convivial acceptance of the harsh reality of her circumstances.

After our milk, she packed me under a pile of blankets and I slept. In the morning we awoke to a very cold house.

Why? Why would anyone willingly bear the sufferings of extreme cold, pennilessness, tough physical labour and loneliness such as that sister of mine was experiencing? Why? Out of love? Love for whom? Love for God? Love for the world? How does the world benefit by an individual bearing such sufferings? In what way is such penance an expression of love? No doubt she has a dream, my sister nun, as I have a dream, of creating a nucleus of spiritual regeneration and social change in whatever place we are sent to work.

We believe in that dream, in that ideal. We believe that the projects we are struggling to establish – in her case, a kindergarten, a bakery, an organic farm and dairy, an educational centre for ecological, cultural and spiritual concerns – will have a powerful influence on the communities around. That dream, and the struggle to realise it, are expressions of our love for the world, and for God.

Yet it is not really the dream of a better world that sustains us – at least not me. The effect we may have on the world by establishing our projects or by our social service activities may or may not be as great as it is in our dreams. We cannot say that we will change the course of destiny, at least in our lifetime. We cannot even say for sure that we will have any effect whatsoever on this degraded world. And yet, it is enough for me to know that we are working

towards that ideal. In living our lives in this way, we are being true to our ideal.

Let me, in this life, burn like a candle, constantly, irrevocably, steadily, until I burn myself out. The result of my burning is irrelevant, is of secondary importance, to the act of my burning. The burning itself is an expression of my love for God, for my ideal, which is God manifested in me.

In the course of this burning we experience a spiritual peace and spiritual contentment. Through the sufferings and solitude of monastic life we come in close contact with the Divine Beatitude, with the Divine Will that guides the course of the Cosmos and the course of all individual lives, animate and inanimate, within this Cosmos. We are aware of God's constant presence; we thankfully receive God's boundless grace, especially in times of desperation. We touch God's face, and, if we are humble or pure or blessed enough, God embraces us in unspeakable mystic splendour.

In the frozen house of my sister nun, I rejoined the life of the spiritually blessed and pure. It is a life that is so familiar and attractive to me; a life full of hardship, yet charged with spiritual peace and mystic vitality. It is a life, I think, cut out only for a destined few. It is my life. In living it, may I serve to provide spiritual solace, hope and inspiration to others who have different roles to play on this earth, and may I be a beacon for those who feel similar spiritual stirrings in their souls.

*Child,
shall I guide you into mystic realms?
World
without
walls.*



*Mysterious world
of shimmering shadows
and blinding light.
World
of the eternally living
and of the laughing dead.*

*You look to me
seeking life's object.
Yet,
I offer you only
madness.
Sanity
is a facade
which secures stability
in this rigid plane
and serves to attend to a mirage.
Reality
is the fluidity
of dreams.*

*Dear child,
I can feed your dreams
and fan your aspirations
for a mystic world
born of this world
yet beyond this world.
World
without
walls.*

XXIV

The Road to Heaven

Didi Ananda Arpan'a'

I rose with the sun yesterday morning, and meditated in the calmness of the empty farm. The helpers are away. Only our mama-cat was there to see me off as I left for Prague. She'll guard our 18 hectare ecological project here in the Czech Republic from all the mice until I return.

At half past five in the early morning, the tiny village of Sedlecko was still resting, or so I thought. Except for the birds – the restless choir had already been rehearsing, claiming the morning to itself. The sound of gravel under my feet provided a rhythm for the intoxicated band that chirped, cooed and whistled from the trees and bushes all along the road. An unknown neighbour stood at the other end of the bus-stop; we both stood in a quiet reverie to the



unfolding day. I looked down towards the village and the shimmering sun popping above the hills. Someone else was up, watching Nature awaken, an old farmer overseeing his fields, listening to the deer and the fasan's (a beautiful ringed-neck pheasant) call.

How grateful I was that the bus was late – those minutes filled with the sweetest music of the feather-orchestra calling from sky to sky, while the milky softness of the landscape poured like nectar into my hungry soul. Undulating hills kissed my heart like waves, gladdening my eyes with colourful patched carpets. The rape-seed still flashed yellow, and wheat, rye, barley and grass sported all shades of green, while potato and corn meandered stripy brown, all mingling with almost black groves. The lake glittered sleepily at the crystal clear sky and the half-moon still peeped at the sun. I looked at the oak-tree in front of me, and just couldn't, wouldn't, restrain myself: I leaned my chest on it and gave it a hug. Or perhaps it – my long neglected brother – hugged me?

Then the bus came, and we sped down the road towards newer hills and openings. My back straight, and stretching my neck to look around, I gasped in awe at the beauty bursting from all sides. Those fruit trees that just some weeks ago bloomed along the road like white brides, now hung with already pinkish cherries and exhibited tiny plums and apples everywhere. And how graceful were the swans, busy over their morning preening, while we wound around the lake! The veils of mist lingered between the hills hiding breakfasting deer and rabbits, and the falcon had not yet started looking for its prey. The gardens of occasional villages were still pecked by fasans searching for

tasty snacks, hidden amongst flowers and strawberries. The late spring offered riots of colour: the short and tall, climbing and crawling, sticking and hanging, single and mixed, bushy and lonely pinks, reds, whites, yellows, blues and oranges, budding, blooming and blossoming in yards, on porches, from balconies and windows, glorifying life.

And, as humanity also trickled slowly into the bus, approaching its schools, doctors and jobs, everything did become more alive. The mists dissolved in threads, and sparkling dew rose like Earth's breath into the blue sky. How amazing it was to feel the gentle rhythm of the planet, inhaling and exhaling, sleeping and waking, nurturing and absorbing everyone! How exquisite was the soft heartbeat within all! The tears of gladness choked me – so happy to be a part of it, so grateful to be able to see it.

How different this was from the feeling I was often burdened with not so long ago – the miserable notion that I must belong to 'another planet' where there is love and peace, and not to this 'restless, fickle, selfish world'.

Oh, how lonely and unhappy with myself and others I had been – a bottomless ocean of sorrow fed up with living itself, unable to either rise or fall, but hanging somewhere in between, wishing it all would end soon. I didn't know whether a heaven even existed (I hadn't been a great 'seeker', and definitely wasn't a 'finder'), but I was in hell for sure, hurt over and over again. And there was a day when the pain was too much and I hated all, wishing only to destroy.

Then I suddenly knew that the only solution was just the opposite: love. If I could love so much – infinitely – nothing could hurt me again. And my choice was made:



either I'll learn how to love, or I'll die. There was no need to live otherwise.

Was I heard? Shortly afterwards I had a chance to attend a yoga lecture given by a monk of Ananda Marga. There was something in his calmness, a peaceful fearlessness that I had always longed for.

And for the first time, someone spoke about God or Cosmic Soul in a way that made me feel a sense of belonging. It's all logical, I thought. If the Divine is infinite, then I am a part of It. It's everywhere around me, and It's also inside of me. My soul and the Cosmic Soul are essentially one. I am not alone – the Great is with me! There is Something that knows me through and through, more than anyone else, more than I even know myself, and accepts me completely as I am. I am loved! I was Home. And the next day when I learned how to meditate, I found hope.

Still, the old habits do not wither away so quickly. Can years of negativity be erased overnight? Would the cramps in my body and mind dissolve just like that? The worrisome self finds ever-new reasons to worry. Only slowly did the brighter thoughts and activities remove the stains to reveal the sparks of light long buried in my deepest self. Even though I sincerely tried to practice the technique, I didn't really relate much to that Something that was God.

It wasn't until some days or weeks later, while I was simply walking to the bus station, immersed in my miserable grey thoughts, when a realisation struck me 'from nowhere': LIFE IS BEAUTIFUL!

It was as if the veil was lifted from my eyes – from my heart! It was as if the soul in me saw the glory of the shining sun, bright sky, gentle breeze, soft meadow and jolly

dandelions. Everything was so overwhelmingly charming I was shivering with a tingling sensation that made my body-hairs stand on end. Then the next thought popped into my mind from some unknown part of myself: 'It is like this by God's Grace.'

The next realisation swept unstoppably like a wave through my whole being: 'And to know this is also His Grace'. Tears of gratitude came to my eyes. Had I found my 'heaven'?

My heaven has come to me: it keeps unwrapping itself from somewhere deep within. I keep striving to arrive, not to reach. My master teaches me to give, not to achieve. If I can keep my heart open, the Lord of Life reveals Itself in all.

I try to remember that we all belong to each other, and sometimes I do see it through the effort. Sometimes, like yesterday morning and that first fine day, this knowing blossoms unexpectedly by itself, dissolving the boundaries between 'me' and the 'other'.

I travel for a lifetime on this unknown road to heaven, the road within, the path of bliss. Like this road to town, my life journey also goes up and down; there are hills and slopes, highs and lows.

The old wants to pull me back, the new wants to grow up, and I often struggle between straining and collapsing until I'm reminded again and accept wholeheartedly that all is God's Grace. Although everything else might be undulating and oscillating, the 'road to heaven' is not. It goes straight to the core: all is God and God is all. To remember this is my path, my love; to be this, my goal.



How to put into words the subtlest longing of a human soul? Would this suffice:

*It is not that 'the Spring comes',
but the first flowers
that died in their mad rush to bloom
in anticipation of It – they are the Spring!
It is not that 'the Beloved comes',
but the lover – mad for her Divine love – reveals the Beloved
within herself!
My loving makes Him 'come'; my loving gives Him life
Within this existence of mine!
The Beloved comes through the loving of the lover.
The Beloved is the fragrance of the flower.
The Lover is the flower whose joy it is to bloom.*



XXV

Through the Eyes of a Child

Didi Ananda Prajina Paramita

I was born into a spiritual family in India. My family had been initiated into the Tantric path before my birth, so spirituality was always part of my life. Ananda Marga was my parents' chosen path and I followed them along it. At that time, Ananda Marga was just a small organisation and our Guru was very close to us. We would visit him whenever we could in the town of Jamalpur where he lived. It was a different time – we had the opportunity to be very close to him.

Although I was born into a deep spiritual tradition, I still had to go through my own process of coming to terms with my spiritual path and my own relationship with my Guru. This process and these experiences began for me at a



very early age and have continued throughout my life, ever deepening my spiritual conviction. I share here some of these experiences which have woven the spiritual fabric of my life.

The beginning of the blossoming of my spiritual life came when I was six years old. With my parents and grandmother, I had gone to see Baba in Jamalpur. At that time, Ananda Marga was a very small organisation. Many devotees came to see Baba from different parts of India. Every day, Baba would come to the *ashram* in the evening. He would give *darshan* (appear personally) and speak individually with people. Sundays, however, were special, as Baba came twice on that day.

On this occasion Baba was meeting with my family, giving advice about our family problems and also talking about how to develop the organisational work of Ananda Marga through social service and relief work. However, I was feeling very upset with Baba because he never talked with me, so I was not with them in the room.

I was playing at the gate of the *ashram* when Baba suddenly appeared. I had no chance to escape; he caught me by one hand and he embraced me with the other hand. He gently stroked my chin. I was looking at him in a mystical way. He was smiling and looking at me with his charming eyes. For a while we looked at each other without talking. Then he took me on his lap and said, 'Are you very upset with me?' I had no answer. I just nodded.

'Do you know who I am?' Baba said to me. I shook my head.

'You can't know me because you are very young. When you grow up, you will come to know who I am. I am your

nearest and dearest one. Are you happy now that I talked to you?’

‘Yes, Baba,’ I replied.

‘We have become very good friends. Now go and play.’ I did *pranam* (showed my respect) to Baba by touching his feet and he blessed me.

Although I was just a young child, my mind became very blissful. Even today when I remember this incident I still feel that same feeling of divine ecstasy.

As my spirituality unfolded, I felt the need to understand Baba more deeply – to know just how closely he knew me, to know how deeply I could trust him. So a little later that same year, I devised a test for my Guru. My mother had often said to me, ‘You should not do anything wrong because Baba knows everything you do.’ But I could not believe what my mother told me. How could he know everything? How could he know what I am doing in my house? I wanted to test Baba.

I learned that in three or four days’ time I would go to see Baba with my parents. So I made a plan. I went to an orchard and picked some custard apples, and then I hid them in the paddy storehouse. I was thinking that, when I see Baba, if he tells me what I have done today then I will be sure Baba knows everything.

We went to see Baba in Jamalpur. My father and mother did *pranam*, then I also did *pranam* before Baba. Immediately, Baba said to me, ‘I know, you hid custard apples in your paddy store. Is it not true?’ I was surprised that he should know this. From that time, I understood that Baba was so close to me that he knew everything about me.



As I grew, my inquiring mind sought to understand the finer points of spirituality. I had a desire to understand the difference between spiritual dogmas and deep spirituality. On one occasion, I was staying in the home of a family *acharya*. In that family, whenever anything was cooked they would first offer the food and a glass of water to Baba. A special room was kept for Baba in the house. and in that room there was a special bed and mat. They would always put the mat down before offering food, then they would close the door and wait some time until they felt Baba had eaten. After this, they would come and take *prasad* (food that has been blessed because it has been offered to Baba).

I always thought this practice was a kind of dogma. I wondered why they didn't simply say their *guru mantra* over the food, as this would mean the food had been already offered to Baba, and therefore there would be no need to offer it physically.

It was the time of the first harvest. The tradition in India is always to offer the first food from the new harvest to God. So they asked me to make *khir* (sweet milky rice) for Baba. I prepared myself by taking a bath and then I prepared the *khir* in a new pot. I was singing *kiirtan* while I was cooking, putting as much love into the food as I could.

When I was cooking, I thought to myself that I really wanted to see if Baba comes to eat this food or not. So I said to the family that today I would offer the food myself. I decided to place the spoon on the plate instead of in the bowl with the food. If the spoon was used then in this way I would be able to see if the food had really been eaten. I also put a glass of water beside the food. I offered the food to Baba in the special room they set aside for him and

closed the door. While we waited, I began talking about Jamalpur and looking at photos with the family members in the next room.

Half an hour later, the *acharya's* wife, who had been outside, started shouting, 'Baba, Baba, why are you leaving my house?' We wondered to whom she was speaking.

I looked outside. I saw Baba walking quickly away from the house. The *acharya's* wife was running after him, then she collapsed. After a few seconds Baba vanished. Then the house was full of fragrance and the vibration was very high.

I ran to Baba's room to check if Baba had eaten the *khir*. To my great surprise, I saw that someone had eaten some *khir* and drunk the water. Water was also spilled near the plate. Now I felt rather bad, but I understood that when we offer food to our Guru with a pure heart, he will always come to eat.

When this event occurred, Baba was in jail in Patna. A few weeks later I went to see him there. I offered him my garland and did *pranam*. His first words to me were, 'Your *khir* was very delicious.' I immediately began to cry and asked him to forgive me. He told me I had the right to test him. 'When you are going to sacrifice your life for me and for my work, it is not bad to test your Guru.' I continued crying for some time while others spoke with Baba. When everyone left, he called me close to him and blessed me. I promised that I would certainly become an *acharya*. I did *pranam* and left the room, constantly glancing over my shoulder at Baba with tearful eyes.

I did go on to become an *acharya* and Baba has continued to stretch my boundaries. After I first became a Didi, I



worked for several years in India, but then Baba posted me to work in Italy. I had come from a small village in India, and leaving India was a huge challenge for me. It was not just that it was culturally difficult. I also felt so sad to be going far away from Baba. When I received my new posting, I felt extremely sad. Before this I had been seeing Baba twice a day while I was working in Calcutta.

When the day of my departure came, I began to cry and I cried for the whole day. In the evening, I went to Baba's house to offer a garland to him and to seek his permission for my departure. A Dada and Didi were present in Baba's room when I arrived. I was already weeping, but when I saw him I began to cry loudly. Sweetly Baba said, 'I don't want to see you crying.' He asked Dada and Didi to turn their faces away.

'Don't look,' he said. 'I want to say something privately to her.'

He indicated that I should come close. He whispered in my ear, 'I am not sending you to the wilderness. You should always think that you are sitting on my lap.'

Then I laughed and asked him, 'Baba, when will I see you again?' He said, 'I am always with you. I am never far from you. Whenever you want, you can come to see me.' Then he added, 'Now it is time to go.'

I did *pranam* and left with a happy heart.



XXVI

Darkness Before Dawn

Sundarii Earles

When I was 29 years old, I had a nervous breakdown. The signs were already there at the birth of our third child, Simon. The day after his birth, which was normal and drug free, I felt horribly depressed. Everything looked darker than black. As the days went by and I started to breastfeed, things improved slightly.

We had been living in Uganda, in the Queen Elizabeth National Park. Right through the pregnancy I had worried about having to take the long train journey to the hospital alone with two small children just before the birth was due. My husband had promised he would take time from work to give me support at the crucial time, but it didn't happen. I had to make that ten-hour trip unaccompanied.



The depression came on me every evening for months. We moved to England where we shared a two-bedroom bungalow with my husband's parents. In the crowded conditions, with noisy young children, tensions mounted and tempers flared. It was a very trying time for all of us. Finally my in-laws decided to leave the bungalow to us while they visited their daughter in Africa. Peter, my husband, also went away, back to sea to earn a living. I was left to cope with three young children aged one, three and six years old. It was a rude shock after Africa where a 'boy' and an *ayah* had taken care of most of the chores.

After a few weeks, I cracked. I couldn't sleep anymore. I drank brandy in the hope of stunning myself to sleep, but it had the opposite effect. I thought I was going mad. One morning, my next door neighbour found me in a very sorry state. I was packed off to a psychiatric hospital where I was given a series of electroshock treatments. The depression subsided. Although I never completely lost my mind, the treatment affected my short-term memory and I also developed certain neuroses including agoraphobia. I had horrible nightmares.

Peter came back from the sea and went on the dole so he could look after the children. After I had been in hospital for three months, I finally yielded to Peter's entreaties and signed myself out. Strange as it may seem, I dreaded leaving the security of the hospital environment; facing the world out there took a great deal of courage.

The years that followed were a long struggle toward regaining my self-confidence, which had been badly shaken. I was still relying on tranquillisers when I decided to try some self-help techniques. I attended a yoga class where

we practiced different yoga postures, breathing and relaxation. I began to feel the benefit of these. Then, one day, a Chinese woman gave a talk on meditation. I vaguely remembered having heard that the Beatles practiced meditation. I decided to give it a try.

I was 44 years old and now living in Hobart in Australia. It was a turning point in my life. Every Sunday evening, a handful of people gathered together for a group meditation evening. I liked the people, the philosophical approach, and the exchange of ideas. After a few weeks a teacher of Ananda Marga came to town, a monk in an orange turban and robes who wore glasses and had an American accent. Behind the spectacles, the blue eyes reflected peace and compassion. His positive aura added a new dimension to the now regular weekly meditations. He gave us some basic instruction on yogic philosophy and way of life.

Some of us took initiation from Dada Dharmapala. At initiation, we took an oath promising to follow the principles of non-violence and of service to humanity. We were also given a personal mantra to use during meditation. The mantra helped to keep my mind on track while I was meditating. The spiritual meaning of the mantra gave my mind something expansive to contemplate.

I didn't find meditation particularly easy. Having a butterfly mind, it was hard work trying to discipline it into concentrating on one thought, one concept. But gradually I came to realise that meditation wasn't so much about thinking, but rather about feeling and tuning in to the vast energy within and around us.



My life began to change. The first thing I noticed was that I began to sleep at night. I began to feel less nervous in crowds. My concentration and memory also improved. I continued to practice my daily yoga postures and, gradually, my body acquired more mobility. I also decided to keep strictly to a vegetarian diet.

But there were other struggles. My family reacted to my new-found interest and tried to talk me out of it. For some reason, they felt threatened and their attitude was quite negative. But I persisted; the benefits were obvious to me. My only fear was that if I stopped the practices I would revert to the way I was before – timid, lacking in confidence, nervous, hating crowds, and full of fear. Peter did his best to discourage me, grumbling about the time I spent in meditation (some 20 minutes twice a day). He wasn't too happy about the change of diet either. But I persisted with my lifestyle, feeling a growing commitment inside me to my spirituality and my spiritual path.

I had been doing meditation for seven years when the opportunity arose for me to visit my Guru in India. Baba had begun a special program called *dharma samiksa*. He was giving his students the opportunity to accelerate their spiritual growth by having a personal review during which they would receive insights into their personal strengths and weaknesses, physical, mental and spiritual. This would include invaluable advice about important lifestyle changes they might need to make. It was an opportunity not to be missed. I decided to go, together with my friend, Asha, and her son, Vinay.

We rushed around doing all the necessary preparations and, within a week, we were off to Sydney to catch a con-

necting flight to Calcutta. We had two problems to solve in Sydney: Asha was waiting for money to arrive from the US, and I was waiting for my passport which was to arrive by courier. We were frantic as the time of departure approached. Finally, at the eleventh hour, both money and passport were located, but too late. We had missed our connection.

People had told us that we should expect obstacles when embarking on a journey to meet our Guru, but this was too much! We were feeling totally dejected, sitting in the *ashram* in Sydney, when a message arrived from the airport: An unscheduled flight would be leaving at 2.30 pm. We took off in a taxi at great speed.

When we reached the airport, we didn't stop running until we got to the passport control. The man smiled sympathetically.

'No need to run; you'll be all right,' he reassured us.

Finally we were ushered onto the plane. We couldn't believe our eyes when we saw that the great Jumbo Jet was... empty! The only other passengers on board were a young married couple.

The crew came and fussed over us. They were delighted by our bemused expressions. We were put into First Class and offered luxurious service. We looked at one another and the significance of the whole drama hit us. We burst out laughing and couldn't stop for half an hour, as our pent-up tensions were released. (Later, I related this incident to a friend who was a travel agent in Hobart. He couldn't believe his ears. He had never heard of a plane, especially a Jumbo, leaving an airport empty.) We had experienced a miracle, I had no doubt about this.



The highlight of my first encounter with my Guru occurred a few days after our arrival in Calcutta. We usually came to the *ashram* early in the morning and left late at night. We squatted on top of the building throughout the day with so many other people who had travelled from all over the world for *dharma samiksa*. We did our spiritual practices as best we could in the crowded conditions, trying to ignore the smoke from the individual cooking fires and the burning incense.

In the morning and evening, Baba was driven to a park where he would walk in the open air. One evening we were waiting for his return. It was raining and getting quite late, but we decided to stay on. We lined up along the little alleyway that led to his house. It was eleven o'clock and we were soaked from the rain when the usual flurry of excitement that preceded his return warned us of his arrival. The small white figure made his way along the poorly lit path, followed by his personal assistant. His hands were joined in the gesture of *namaskar* to greet us all.

When he came level with me, he turned towards me and, looking into my eyes, gave me a deep *namaskar*. Such was the force of his spiritual vibration that I was overwhelmed with bliss and my legs nearly gave way beneath me as I returned his greeting. To this day I remain in awe of the intensity of this special blessing I received.

I returned to India four times over the years; the last two times with my husband, Peter. The last time I visited Baba was in April of 1990. Shortly after that, on the 21st of October, he left his body. We were in France at the time. The night before I got the news, I had been seized with an overwhelming sadness while I was sitting for my evening

meditation. I cried uncontrollably for a long time, not knowing the reason for such an outburst. When I heard the news the next day, I understood that a great soul had left the earth. There was a terrible sense of loss and disbelief among the people who loved Baba.

Unfortunately I couldn't attend the final ceremony in Calcutta. A last farewell – it would have been too poignant.

Yet his presence and influence still touch my life in so many ways, in dreams, in the rich internal world of my daily meditations, and within the broad social and spiritual philosophy that he so carefully developed during his lifetime.



XXVII

Did You Hear Me?

Didi Ananda Kaomudi

‘Meeta, can you hear me?’

The whirring sound made by the head lamp on my bicycle is too loud in the quiet of the late night. There is no one along this deserted dyke road, but I’m wondering what might be lying in ambush along its steep slopes. A night-time fisherman, a late night drug dealer, a gang of teenagers deciding to party? Or a farmer, called to the fields by the cries of a lambing ewe?

I don’t want to meet anyone. I could not explain myself, because I don’t speak Dutch. Even if I could speak the language, what could I say?

So I turn off the light and continue cycling in the dark. Over a few nights, I have grown accustomed to riding in

darkness along this road, and the bumps in the road are becoming familiar.

The sea calls me. From across its bay waters, small lights mingle into the hazy mist of the light rain that is falling. It's warm and peaceful.

Across the water, Meeta... far, far, far away in another land... you are sleeping I suppose, surrounded by your children, Govinda by your side. At times I have felt like one such as these, so close did you become to me, my sister. At times over the years that we worked together at the school, your guidance was like that of a mother.

Can you feel my mind now? Does it enter your dreams and disturb you with its wrestling? I'm still trying to say goodbye. I'm on my way to Asia to start life again; Holland is my springboard for finally leaving Europe. Half the time my head is spinning with anticipation, fear and excitement, and wondering how I will ever manage without you and those who love me.

A seagull calls my mind back to a beach in Ireland. This quiet Holland sea becomes that pounding Atlantic Ocean. There was nothing tame on that windy beach; the grasses that held tightly to moving sands were forced onto their bellies by the blasts of moving air.

It had been a long fasting day. The twilight pulled me from the caravan, its blue light full of mystery. I wanted to find a way into the heart of this land, for I was on a quest to establish a Master Unit. Baba was asking about Ireland: What were we doing to establish ourselves there?

So together with you, Meeta, and with Govinda, Joshana and Prabhat, who was only just three, we packed up the car and sailed the ferry from England down into the county of



Cork, not sure of how or where, but certain we must come and try.

We had no money and no contacts to help us get started. We just drove along the rickety roads, waiting to trip over some land that would suit what we were hoping for in a Master Unit. There was lots of speculation around that point. Maybe this lack of direction and clarity led to my decision to keep *maonobrata* (meditative silence) for three days. I wanted to keep in contact with my mantra, to let Baba's plan unfold before us.

My silence had had an effect upon the kids; they couldn't understand why I wouldn't talk with them. There was a feeling amongst us all that we were living on a different level from that which is considered normal.

And so I had reached that isolated wintry Irish beach, alone, for my evening *sadhana*. The tide was out. The large expanse of flat sand was space enough for my *kiirtan* to begin to move in a circle. As the waves picked up and the sun began to set over the western sea, my mind decided to continue in *kiirtan* for as long as I was able.

I danced for Him to come, to help me understand how to fulfil his wish for land here. I danced for the land, for the people of this land whom I knew were my ancestors, for my father's great pride in the O'Connor clan that had sailed long ago from these shores to escape the tortures of the British. I sang for the sea, for these same strong waves that I had played amongst since my early Australian childhood, the same salty air that I have sought and found time and time again as I've wandered across this globe, this Universal ocean. I danced and sang in an effort to surrender, to

free my mind of its duty-bound expectations, to allow the vastness of the sky to create an openness in my thinking.

The ocean's thrashing became my own tossing. What was my purpose, how had I come to be here, singing upon this beach far, far, far away...

Now, the silhouette of the windmill snaps me back into the reality of this night. I'm in Holland, not Ireland. Something of the last year of travelling, two weeks here, another two there, airports and waiting halls, I've lost that special reality, and become confused inside my memories.

Now I park my bike and the logistics of the situation take over. I must concentrate hard now. The first gate has to be climbed through without rattling its hinges, for if the sheep wake up the farmer will be alerted. I'm trespassing now, across the flat grasslands of a local farm, in order to reach the nature reserve by the sea. Maybe it's okay for tourists to pass through here during the day, but now, in the middle of the night, there is certainly something suspicious about such behaviour.

The black sheep know me a little by now. As I have moved silently through them during this last week they have become accustomed to my passing, but still the old ones feel concern. I try to walk around them, not to wake the babies. But their blackness is hard to differentiate. Despite my steady movements and attempts to pierce the darkness with my sight, I've come close to treading on them.

They startle, and move swiftly aside. I stand still and we look at one another. Please, please be still, I beg them in whispers and carefully move a step away. One mother calls...



‘It’s okay,’ I respond. ‘Let me pass. I’m going.’ And I continue as best as I can, holding my breath and praying that Baba will keep me safely unseen.

That night back in Ireland, I hadn’t been so lucky. As I moved around the chanting circle, I began to see the lights. High up on the hills and dunes, small red points were appearing.

First one or two, then after a time more and more, until a cityscape of high rise patterns appeared, building up the slope of the hill. I had begun to wonder at them when some loosened their grip and flowed down the embankment towards me.

A hoard of teenage boys! I wasn’t prepared for this. How long had they been watching me, this lonely orange figure blazing a circular trail upon their local sands. Someone had spotted me and called all his friends.

Having grown up in the suburbs of Melbourne during a time when reports of teenage gangs ravishing young women had made regular local news, I was now suddenly gripped by a fear stronger than my sense of reason.

After all, I was alone. I had been alone here for hours. The nearest town was five miles away, and the caravan park was across the dunes. No one would be coming to this beach on this tumultuous night.

Alone, with a pack of young men who began to circle me, mocking me, while I continued, my steps frozen in their pattern, around and around. I didn’t acknowledge their presence. My eyes looked through them across the sea, and my mind began to focus sharply inward, on the need for protection.

Baba, help me...

Did you hear me calling you, Meeta? You and Govinda were only twenty minutes away, in the warmth and safety of the family's caravan? How I needed for you both to come and lift me out of this situation.

I prayed to Baba to send you. The circle was getting tighter; the boys were becoming abusive, angry, because I didn't fit into their understanding of life. I was too weird for them to comprehend.

Some began to yell at me, another tried to block my path, a third urinated close by... They were egging each other on. I wondered if soon I would be slaughtered.

The hill was occupied by spectators. The red tips of their cigarettes betrayed their presence. No hope for escape by that path. The beach stretched into an infinity of darkness. Judging from the muscles that were beginning to twitch in their legs and arms, I had no chance of out-running these young men, and my ability to run for safety would be hampered by my day of fasting.

The third option was the sea... surrender my body to her cold watery embrace and drown quickly, rather than endure any torture under the rough skin of their uncouth hands.

Oh God! Someone save me.

An empty wind wailed its forlorn reply. And my *kiirtan* (chanting) continued...

Baba nam kevalam... Only that eternity exists, everything is You, Your infinite Love... God help me, this is just another *samskara* (karmic test) I have to burn...

The story of Draupidi arose before my inner eye. This fine lady was to be stripped bare of her garments before a



court of roughnecks. She called out to Krisna to save her. The story goes that the sari she wore became never-ending... The kings' soldiers grew tired in their efforts to unwrap her and they gave up.

I wondered what miracle would befall me. Was my sari also magical?

Baba, please don't let me die in this way. Or if it has to be so, please let my mind leave this body to these vultures and find a way to remain with you in safety.

The sheep's cries grow distant, and my thumping heart slows in its pace. Painful memories of confronting my deepest fears and somehow surviving are pulling at me.

That trip to Ireland had been years ago, while I was still a new Didi finding out the limits and boundaries of blind trust and the reality of our existence as workers. As a trainee, I had believed that once I gave my life to my Guru and taken up these robes, He would never let me down. Once in the field, I had begun to test it.

Now I am crossing though the long grasses that swish at each step. Over two more fences, and along the tyre tracks that lead to the open sea. The birds wake up from the water's edge and scream around me. But by now it doesn't matter. I'm far away from the farmer's house, far from the road, and there is no more civilization to disturb me.

Now it is just time for me to be with Him. I prepare myself and the ground for night *sadhana*. There is something comforting in the familiarity of washing myself in the sea, finding my place and flattening the grasses. Preparing my body and mind to be still. By now, all is automatic. Like the paints and mediums of an artist long familiar with them,

this place, too, bends itself to my whims and comes alive to my presence.

Soft rain on my skin, the sounds of night birds calling, mix into an internal reality. I feel Him here, with me, in a closeness that only lovers share. It is something of my inner mystery that can only be experienced by those who live in each other's hearts.

And so I meet my fears and show them to Him. We examine together all the attachments I've gathered, my love for you and the children, my dependence on the other workers who have stood by me, the struggles and joys I've felt with the Margiis as we have woven a deeper pattern through the layers of misunderstandings... the life I've lived as a Didi, its richness and colour astonishing to me.

'Meeta, I'm leaving you, and soon I'll be saying a final farewell. Japan for me is another world, and your task is to continue what we have created here together.'

The night wears on, the darkness deepens as the final heaviness thrusts itself onto the dawn in a last attempt to assert its superiority. Dark, dark, dark deepness...

I was like a flame that had attracted those night-time creatures. All that was cruel and crude inside the human mind had came out to greet me, to challenge me for daring to bring anything of another reality to Ireland.

I surrendered to the idea of sacrifice. I know others workers have died while endeavouring to execute their duties... and I was also willing. Besides, what choice did I have?

Something inside told me to continue my chanting, to just remain steady. Don't run, don't swim, don't panic, and don't speak... Just continue in this circle of hope for the



future of Ireland... Keep singing. The Irish have songs of hope deep in their hearts. Maybe something will awaken.

One grabbed at my arm. I shook him off, and continued to walk. They were at a loss. No one was willing to take the first step in striking me down. I waited, and saw that something of my mind had gained the ground. They were finding it difficult to remain long inside my circle, and gathered around its periphery.

Silence seemed to fall as the question arose in their minds: How to take me? I wasn't moved by their threats...

Finally something happened...

Inside I had reached a level of desperation where I was screaming to Baba to help me. I was tired. The tension of the situation, the fasting, the days of travel, the concentration of silence, had taken their toll. Some weariness entered into me. Baba, whatever is to be, let it happen now because soon I will have to stop. I cannot go on like this much longer.

And then a miracle, in the form of a young girl, stepped into the ring.

My mind collapsed in gratitude. Thank you, Baba, I'm safe. Her entrance was my escape. One of their own, these boys would never debase themselves before her.

I stopped and looked at her. A space of night between us, and Ireland's songs coming across the sea. She smiled wryly, and with a twinge of Irish scorn asked me what the hell did I think I was doing.

It was easy. Just shrug my shoulders and walk silently back through them all, up the hill. Their shadowy forms

hugged the side of the path as I walked steadily on to the caravan and safety.

When I came inside, you greeted me with a smile. I broke my silence: 'Meeta, did you hear my mind calling you? I felt that you did.'

Yes, you had heard me and thought that, in the end, I might prefer to go home to Him, and drown. You and Govinda had wondered whether you should come to find me. But something held you back. You knew I was searching to understand Baba's wishes, and to make my relationship with Him deeper. Perhaps it had been the first real step of devotion I'd taken in my *acharya* life. In your deepest understanding, you had left the final choice to me... to remain with the uncertainty of this life, or to accept defeat and give myself to the ocean. You knew these were my choices.

And these are same choices I face now as I wrestle with future uncertainties and wonder if He'll remain close by to protect me and guide me on.

Through your wisdom, Meeta, I learnt of the love that my Guru holds for me.

How fitting that His name was Prabhat: the dawn. In its new light, I begin to cycle home.



XXVIII

Tantric Reflections

Didi Ananda Nivedita

In 1972, as a young adult, I learnt Tantric meditation as taught by Ananda Marga ('Path of Bliss'). My rite of passage into adulthood included initiation into spirituality, Eastern culture, and financial independence. Looking back I can analyse what occurred, but at the time it felt like white-water rafting along the swift currents of life.

Two years later I left for India to train as a monastic *acharya*. At this juncture I met a great lady who would have immense influence on the form of my spiritual life. She was the first female monastic *acharya* in Ananda Marga. Her name was Avadhutika (Didi) Ananda Bharati; she was affectionately known as 'Auntie.' Auntie was already a grandmother when we met. Before renouncing family life

to engage full time in spiritual pursuits, she raised her children to adulthood. Over a decade she influenced the direction my discipleship took, helping me to envision, through her words and manner, the life of a Tantric disciple. She contrasted with me in many ways. Auntie had been nurtured carefully in the Indian traditions and spiritual practices since she was young. In particular, she helped me understand how disciples must learn everything about their Guru. She explained that the traditional way was for Tantric pupils to live and serve their Guru for years, observing every aspect of the Master's life, habits and teachings. Then one day, when the Master felt a disciple was ready, the disciple would leave to go their own way, possibly never seeing the Guru again. The Guru would have carefully planted seeds that would grow and unfold throughout the disciple's life, living inside dreams and thoughts.

I believed this deeply and wanted every aspect of life, both mundane and supra-mundane, to be connected in some way to my Master (who was affectionately called Baba, meaning 'father' or 'beloved'). In my early years as a disciple I did not even meet Baba, for he was incarcerated for a period of years. So I began to fathom him through dreams, pictures, books, and the stories of other followers. Being a Tantric Guru, Baba lived his life in such a systematic way that even if I had never met him, I could methodically interweave each part of my life with his. From 1979 until 1990, however, I often met with Baba and enjoyed this process externally as well as internally.

What particularly fascinated me was his personality and lifestyle; these were less accessible than the subtler aspects,



which I could garner through his writings and meditation. I was thrilled to watch Baba drink and pat his mouth with a towel in a particular style. The colour of his *kurta* (shirt), whether he had a pen in his pocket, and his gestures all added clues to his mystery.

The interplay between my direct experiences and my desire to know peaked more dramatically when Baba visited Thailand in 1979. He was scheduled to visit Bangkok in August for a few days before touring the Philippines. The arrangements for his visit unexpectedly passed to me, and I was given a list of items to procure for his stay. These provided me with insights into his personal life. A senior monk arrived to help organise matters, and we cleaned and readied the Margiis' house where Baba would stay. I remember washing his room and feeling like a Gopi in Vrindavan, a mythical maiden in Krishna's childhood village.

Sing His Name

I am Radha who sings to the flowers and bees

Your name. Listening to the wind whisper

You're near. I run calling the others

Who laugh and chaff at my giddiness.

Gopiis, please warm your hearts

For how can I tell of him when your face stays dark?

It is my life treasure, his name.

Only in the softest hours can it be spoken.

On the date set for Baba's arrival, many followers gathered from Singapore and Malaysia. While we waited for him, a phone call came to say that his visit was delayed and

a new date would be set. The Margiis were disappointed so the senior monk working with me arranged a spiritual seminar to make their visit worthwhile and meaningful, and then they returned to their homes.

Within a week we learned that Baba would arrive in Bangkok in a few days; however, fewer Margiis were able to fly back. We greeted him at the airport and during Baba's stay enjoyed his *darshan* (spiritual talks) many times. Due to his loving and fatherly manner and the small number of Margiis present, we enjoyed a relaxed and family-like atmosphere. One time, when he left the house to go for a drive, he seemed so close and familiar that, without thinking, I lightly touched his back. Afterwards I was surprised at myself, because I knew we weren't supposed to touch or disturb him without permission. Baba didn't seem to have noticed.

During his stay I was able to do daily tasks such as wash his dishes, shop for him, and carry his plate up to his room. On one occasion I replaced the head nun who toured with Baba (as the official representative of the Women's Department) to accompany a small group of woman during their personal contact with Baba. He affectionately and humorously called me 'his guardian'.

During these days, a growing feeling swelled in my heart to touch Baba's feet. In Tantra, touching the guru's feet is a great honour and a symbolic gesture of reverential surrender. As an *acharya* I knew this was not often permitted, yet my desire grew.

At the end of his visit we went to the VIP lounge at the airport to cherish our last moments together and to sing him devotional songs. One monk sat in front of me, facing



Baba, and sang him a song. After his song, a senior monk called him to the rear of the room for a duty, and I moved in front of Baba. Someone requested permission from Baba to sing *guru puja*, a spiritual song that invokes and praises the guru, and our prayer was granted. A small group of ten to fifteen people began to sing, and at the end when we bowed and mentally offered a flower to him, I reached and touched his feet. He sat in the mystical *namaskar* (greeting) pose and said, 'So nice, so sweet.' Then Baba stood to leave.

When Baba's plane departed, the Margiis returned to where Baba had stayed and asked for mementos of his visit. Many of them had contributed things for his comfort such as towels, blankets, and other things. They wanted some of these items returned to cherish, and the senior monk gave many away. In this spirit I saw that Baba had left his comb on the bathroom sink, and this treasure I kept.

That night I went to the airport to fly to Manila and follow Baba and the activities there. When I arrived at the airport, a monk ran up and said that Baba had been deported from Manila. He, with a dozen monastic *acharyas*, sat in the airport security section waiting for re-entry visas. We heard the local authorities were hesitant because Baba and his monastic companions had been returned as the only passengers on the airplane. Understanding the situation, Baba interceded on their behalf, telling the Thai officials that the officers in Manila did not understand about monks. This moved the Bangkok officials, because they highly revere their Buddhists monks, and they granted re-entry visas to Baba's entourage. I cancelled my flight in order to have more time with Baba in Bangkok.

Baba's stay this time, although in the same Margiis' house, was quite different because most of the articles to make his visit more homelike had gone with the Margiis. Although he had a less comfortable stay, as a gentleman he did not complain. The only item I heard Baba asking his personal assistant about was his comb. I never revealed that I had his comb. I reflected on his inquiry in various ways: a reflection on the host, a teaching on ethics, a personal connection?

Baba remained a week in Bangkok while arrangements were being made for his visit to Taiwan, and he spent much time alone. Since there were no Margii volunteers to assist him, I took up the duty of cleaning his room every day when he went out on his field walk. This was my golden opportunity. I could feel the vibration of his inner sanctum, his bedroom with his personal things, and through symbolic gestures could connect more deeply with Baba. I placed his bathroom slippers on my head, symbolizing my deep love and gratitude. His cane, which he used both for disciplining and gracing his followers, I rubbed over my body to signify my yearning for his teachings. One day while cleaning his vanity I found a whisker from his facial hair; this I kept to enable me to conjure memories of him when we were apart. Perhaps, if I had lived in India and cared for him regularly, this would have been a less intense experience. For me it was a devotee's paradise and I utilised every opportunity to increase my relationship with him in symbolic Tantric form.

Since Baba died, I cherish these memories and find that my relationship continues to grow in a similar manner, only entirely internally. Guru's role is to become very close



to his followers, to interlace his presence with the disciples' life, and the disciples' desire is the same. This interplay encompasses the beauty and charm of the spiritual path of Tantra. It is through deep love that one grows the most, and I gratefully and humbly follow this tradition.



XXIX

The Fire of Spirituality

Didi Ananda Rama

I was alone in my tiny flat, holding my breath almost, with an inner excitement as I settled down to perform my first meditation after initiation. My mind soared, carried by invisible wings to regions high, serene and blissful that I had never known before. I was taken by the deeply stirring sense that I had come upon an inner path. Contemplating the process of initiation, it was clear to me that I made a serious promise, a commitment that was a bit frightening.

I was not interested in an organisation or religion. What I wanted was this meditation technique that would lead me to find myself and my place in the world. I had steadily rebelled against the imposed social conventions of family, friends and society. I was going to give this new practice a



good try. I meditated regularly until I managed, in between my studies and part-time job, to sit for one hour twice a day. I shunned my friends and withdraw into my new adventure.

On my birthday, for the first time I chose to be alone, reading *Autobiography of a Yogi* (Paramhansa Yogananda, 1946). However I was feeling lonely, remembering how I used to celebrate my birthday. I read a passage when Yogananda meditated for days with the inner hope that his Guru Babaji would appear and bless him before he went abroad. And truly, there had come a knock at his door and Babaji had appeared and embraced him and blessed him.

I was inspired and started meditating. There was a knock at the door... The postman came and brought me a huge box of sweets from a distant friend! I began to feel there was an invisible friend with me, encouraging me, and I felt I was making the right decisions.

I made even more radical changes. I left my previous life and friends and moved to the hub of Ananda Marga activity, despite my earlier dislike of groups. I would go to the nearby graveyard for meditation in the early mornings – at times we would also go at night. Meditation was a new elixir that took root in my soul.

I was wondering about my Guru, who was the authority of my mantra and meditation technique. Up to this time I had only seen him in pictures. There was an unspoken mystery about him that no one could explain clearly. It was an almost unbearable torture not knowing who he was and what he was. Then I dreamed of him, and as an answer to my yearning he turned into a jet of brilliant light which

streamed into me and stayed with me for days and quenched my thirst for knowing him.

Soon I left my studies. I took up training to work with Ananda Marga for a period of time, and devotedly embraced the work of teaching yoga and meditation classes. I was filled with a sense of unlimited inner freedom and joy, being able to let go of worldly bondages and drift along in bliss toward an uncertain future. My yogic discipline was perfect, my meditation blissful. It is a daring, almost reckless step to leave one's studies unfinished. But how wondrous is the Tantric Path! Years later I came to be giving week-long seminars and workshops to people with Masters and Doctorates in Education, the field that I had studied for only a few months.

The fire of spirituality that is lit in the very deep inner core of your soul gives wings to thought and inspires the actions that right the wrongs and heal afflictions in this world.

Tantric *sadhana* (meditation) transforms you and you burn to transform the world for all time. The more *sadhana* you do, the more you burn, and there is nothing that can stop that fire. As long as there is vital energy in you, it is being converted into consciousness through the fire created by your longing and ideation. In the process, you burn eons of *samskaras* (karmic consequences of past actions) and your mind lights up with countless tiny realizations. You are a new person again and again, and go on being ever new.

Receiving *kapalika* initiation (special midnight meditation on the new moon) from Baba was like a near-death experience in which I saw my life spinning off in front of me. It was like glancing back and burning any impurities



that were keeping me from being in a greater state of bliss at all times.

In this new chapter in my life I was equipped to face all the challenges in my path. And challenges came, always unexpectedly, surprisingly, to throw me out of my sense of self and to gain a new identity. I could not hold to what I thought was 'me'. I was in the process of becoming something new while my 'I' was dissolving more and more.

This is the Tantric dance, to go and bend with the blows until they find no resistance, until you can live and work as if beyond any blow.

And the bliss is constant and always present, internally in awareness of the Beloved and externally in the world of working with His creation. You must be devoted to the supreme goal and firm in the principles of the ideology. If you follow cosmic rules, cosmic waves will carry you.

When I first arrived in Haiti, I had \$2 for my personal use and \$800 to start a service project. I survived on that \$2 for four weeks, rented a building for six months, trained two teachers, got furniture for the school, enrolled more than fifty children, and arranged free regular lunches for them.

Exhausted and hungry, I had to continue on my tour. I stopped overnight at Florida airport. I was terribly hungry but had no money to buy something to eat, so I decided to set my mind at peace and do a long meditation. I meditated for a few hours. When I opened my eyes, a young couple approached me. They had been waiting for me to finish and were curious to know about my way of life. They were kind people who had just come from visiting their Guru. They were also spending the night at the airport and of-

ferred to share their dinner with me. They were vegetarian, and it was a wonderful meal.

After long periods of trying and wearying tests, I would feel relief when I returned to India, sometimes bursting into tears in Baba's garden under his window. His presence, his words, his passing glance would heal my soul and fill me up with his *ananda*, and I would find I could sail out into the world again.

The Guru is always present, mentally and spiritually, guaranteeing the right amounts of churning and storming and blissful carrying through. He is present as the inner core of our meditation. Guru is truly the one who leads you to final Oneness.

In these last few years now that He is invisible, I feel He is the gentle uplifting wind at my back. He can blow as hard and as strong as I allow. The more thorough attention I give to my *sadhana*, the more I can feel the bracing wind at my back. I can swirl through life and events and action almost without limitations. At times it is breath-taking, but nevertheless divine.

It is a joy to strive to create and transform. I marvel at the daily miracles of life that can only be so because of divine grace. In fact, miracles are the way of life of Tantra.

Tantra is a constant inner process that, once started right, grows and blooms and finally becomes the very breath of life. It is full of life, love, charm and beauty. It is vigour and courage. It is a full cup of life's exquisite nectar. You could never dream up anything better.

In some way, yes, we must pay for it – actually, fully, completely with every cell of our body, every drop of our blood, and every corner of our mind. But then what do we



need to hold on to that could be immortal? Do we want the pain of being robbed of something we do not want to give freely? There is nothing that we can hold in our hands forever.

It is wiser to give voluntarily, to brake all bondages and enjoy the full bounty of the Cosmic *liila* (dance). We can all carry on the rhythm and dance freely with the elements like air and sunshine.



XXX

**On Being Loved by
Lord Shrii Shrii Anandamurtijii**

Garda Gayatrii Ghista

I

What is like to be loved by the Lord of the Lord of Lords?
What is it like to be loved by the Lord of the Universe?

In 1969 I was initiated and began to read His books. Even to read the words in His books – the words of His discourses – even to see those words puts one into an enthralled state, a state of intoxication, and a state of divine excitement, of spiritual ecstasy. Why? Because one can feel they are the words of GOD. GOD is who? Generator, Operator, Destroyer. He is all these things. He is the mightiest of the mighty, the greatest of the great, and the lion of all lions! He is the king of all kings!



But for me, He is only sweet. He is the sweetest, the most charming Entity I have ever met. His words are surely the most humble, most gentlemanly, most courteous in all of the universe.

In October 1971, I waited outside on the tarmac of the airport in Cochin, Kerala (India), waited for the plane to arrive that was carrying my Lord. It was the first time I would see Him. Waiting and watching, waiting and watching – and lo, He appeared at the open door of the plane. Slowly, He came down the steps.

Then He walked, quickly, doing *namaskar* as He moved. Inexplicably, I also moved, and was running silently behind Him, keeping up with Him, unbearably attracted to a Stranger who was also my Greatest Love. As no others ran, I stopped. Then a kindly brother told me, go ahead, run. So I ran still faster to catch Him – that Elusive One, that Glorious One, in simple white cotton clothes and black spectacles. But – He moved faster!

In the next moment, He was sitting in silence, hands folded in *namaskar*. One by one we filed past the Most Illustrious One, most humble, most sweet love of my heart. As I passed, I gazed long and deep at this Stranger, this Unknown Traveller, taking in every detail of His form – the shape of His head, His hair combed back straight and smooth, His eyes hiding behind large glasses.

As I gazed at His silent motionless form, I knew. It is GOD. He knows all. He feels all. He loves all. He controls all. He is Master of the Universe. I knew there is nothing about me that He does not know. As I gazed, I knew these facts. He gave all these facts to me, as I gazed. And receiving these facts, I felt such an unbearable thrill, such divine

excitement – how to bear it! How to keep still! I wanted to scream to the sky His true identity. I wanted to warn all the world of His true identity. But I moved on. I walked on.

Then high fever came and I could not rise from my bed. I wept for missing Him, missing His *darshan*, one day and then the next. Then my loving (spiritual) brother came and made sweet mosambee juice for me, and told me, ‘Baba was talking about you! He was saying, ‘She is my small, small child!’ I asked my brother many times, ‘Are you sure? Are you sure?’ ‘Yes!’ he said, ‘Baba was talking about you with so much love, so much affection!’ Next day I determined to go, fever or no.

Morning *darshan* came. I sat in the front, and sang a song I had written a few weeks after initiation. I sang:

*O Baba mine, Thou art so dear,
O Baba mine, Thou art so sweet,
O take me in Thy loving arms,
and give me all devotion to Thee.
I see Thee walking in the forest,
I see Thee sitting in the field,
I see Thee smiling, eyes half closed.
So full of love, that's how I see Thee.*

I sang this song, full of shyness. Then BABA came. What transpired then? I was completely transfixed. I only remember how beautiful, how magnificent He looked, and how happy and content I felt to do *guru puja* (surrendering body, mind and soul) to Him for the first time.

Then my Baba left. My Baba was in prison for so many years, in such unbearable conditions, in heat and squalor, in a small cell. He was so far away. But He was also so



close. Once I was at the train station in Madras saying goodbye to my elder brother. Suddenly Baba was in front of me, smiling. Stunned, I moved my gaze. But He was still there. Wherever I gazed, Baba remained! So much bliss at seeing Him everywhere – I could hardly move, hardly speak! This was in 1973.

Years rolled by. I was in Houghton, Michigan, a tiny town in America. Baba was so far far away. Suddenly, Baba was free! It was 1978. I sent Him so many bunches of flowers and packets of vegetable seeds – more than 100 packets. One day somebody told me, Baba acknowledged the seeds. He said that 80 per cent of the seeds gave fruit. I was confused about what this meant. I asked my neighbour, a gardener. He said this is an excellent percentage, if 80 per cent come up. I was so thrilled. Baba wanted me to know that He also loved the flowers as much as I did – more even – and that He had taken personal care of their growth! I was so happy.

Later that day I went to a department store. As I waited to pay the cashier, suddenly Baba was in front of me. I could not believe it! And, when I changed the direction of my gaze, He was there again! Everywhere I looked, there was Baba. I began crying uncontrollably, there in the store. It was too much, it was too overwhelming. I felt too undeserving of His grace, of His love. Why, when, where and how He gave His *darshan* – only He knows.

Baba was coming to Jamaica! It was September 1979. By His grace, and due to the kindness of my brother, I was in Baba's house from six o'clock in the morning until midnight daily, preparing food for Him! This was His sweet grace.

In the beginning I hesitated to cook. Then Madhu said, 'Come Gayatrii, you must cook for Baba!' So I began to cook. First I cooked cabbage – the most simple of vegetables, and cooked in the simplest way. It was given to Him for dinner. Next morning, Madhu called out to me, 'O Gayatrii! Baba loved your cabbage! He talked on and on about the origin of the cabbage, the entire history of the cabbage, how it spread to the different countries and continents!' Oh, Baba! How happy I was! Imagine, for Baba to get excited over cabbage!

Slowly I cooked more and more items for Him and watched the tray go into His room, and then come out clean or with a substantial portion missing – I would just jump for joy! On another day, my brother gave me the towel with which Baba had wiped His face. The towel was filled with the most divine heavenly fragrance – it was the scent of purest sandalwood. Never before had I smelled such a divine fragrance!

In 1971 I had had PC (personal contact) with Baba in Cochin. But there in Jamaica, Madhu told me, 'You have to have PC!' I decided not to mention to anyone about my Cochin PC. I decided to follow whatever Madhu and Didi Ananda Karuna wanted. They organised my (second) PC with Baba! We went in together. It was indescribable. Five or six of us were together with Baba, with the Dada who was Baba's Personal Assistant and Didi Ananda Karuna.

As my turn came, I went on my knees at His feet. I began crying. It was too much for me, to be so close to Him, even touching Him. Love was too much. Longing was too much. The intimacy was too much. I cried so loudly. Through all my weeping, Baba was talking so much, but I



heard nothing. He was taking apart each syllable of my name – Gayatrii – and giving the Sanskrit origin and translation. But – I was only crying in bliss to be at the feet of my Beloved. Finally, He made me listen. He said, slowly, ‘Gayatrii... means... mother... of... the...universe!’ I listened. I heard. I remembered it for life.

In all those days, I had not asked Baba for anything. But that day, I asked in my mind: ‘Baba, when you return from fieldwalk, can you not smile at me, as I stand in the line when you walk past?’ And then I forgot my wish.

Later on in the evening, Baba came. And lo, as He approached, He was looking directly at me, with such a big smile on His face! I was stunned! (I had forgotten about making my wish!) Then I was overwhelmed. His love was too much to bear. I had never experienced such love before. It was Infinite love! His love was more vast than the cosmos! Grown men, forty and fifty years old, feeling His love as He passed – they all were weeping! Such was His love. So was it to be loved by Lord Anandamurtiji!

II

Time moved on. It was August 1981 – the time of *dharma samiksa* – the time when Baba gave spiritual analysis to hundreds of His devotees (and removed the stains of so many past sins impeding our spiritual progress)! Here also, Baba graced me with His close, intimate *darshan*. The room was filled with women. One after another, they were called in front of Him. Baba reviewed their work for the Mission. Then He prescribed *asanas*. If there was any severe health problem, very often Baba cured it on the spot! So many miracles occurred during this period of *dharma samiksa*. Finally my turn came. I was feeling so much anxiety, that I

had done so little Mission work, that I had so many faults and defects. Full of conflict, I knelt in front of Him. I hardly listened to Him. I was only intent on getting closer. My Baba allowed me to come so close! I was kneeling just next to Him and finally I put my head on His lap. Then again I cried. I refused to leave that spot. Then my brothers were pulling me off His lap and away to the door. It had been so short! How could I leave! So much pain to leave Baba!

It was 1982, in Patna. Twice daily, morning and evening, Baba would come out and walk up and down the driveway, next to the garden that was filled three feet high with all sorts of flowers – tuberose, zinnias, marigolds, chrysanthemums, gladiolas, lilies, asters – Baba surrounded by flowers. It was paradise! Daily we waited on the verandah for Him to come out and begin His walk. One day He stopped, just in front of me, and spoke in English. He said, ‘This world is for human beings... not for demons.’ He spoke so seriously that I remembered these words forever.

There was a sister there whose husband had just been killed in the *samaj* movement (Baba’s plan to halt regional exploitation by outside capitalists). One evening, this sister fell at Baba’s feet, weeping profusely over the loss of her husband. Then Baba spoke. He told her and everyone present: ‘Let there be no unhappiness in your hearts. Let everyone be immersed in serving the suffering humanity, by doing *samaj* work for the sake of the Supreme Entity.’

After His walk, Baba would sit in the chair, and all His devotees would dance, singing *kiirtan* in bliss around Him. Many times this occurred. As we danced and sang, Baba sat, so quiet, so silent, mostly with eyes closed. He was enjoying! He was loving the devotees all around Him.



Occasionally, He opened His eyes, to look deeply into the eyes of a particular devotee. One must realise that in the infinite depths of His eyes lay the entire universe! It is impossible for mere mortals to comprehend, to fathom, the infinite attributes of the Lord! Can a small ant fathom the intricacies of the human being – the mind and heart of the human being? Similarly, it is impossible for us to comprehend the Lord. But His love was pouring forth to all, causing some to go into ecstatic trances as they danced. Such days with the Lord cannot be forgotten!

In 1984 I was in Calcutta, in the beautiful abode of Baba. The name of His residential house is Madhu Malanch, meaning 'The Abode of Sweet Charm'. And so it was. Daily the devotees waited and waited, hour after hour, for Baba to come downstairs and out to the driveway, to distribute His infinite love and affection by a mere glance or a sweet charming question to a dumbstruck disciple. People came from all over the world to visit Madhu Malanch, his attraction was so great. What He gave to the world over the span of just a few decades was so vast. It will take centuries for the earth's inhabitants to realise the vastness of His gifts.

But this was not the main reason people came from all over the world. People came simply to experience His love. To feel His love. His love was the Infinite Divine love of the Infinite Entity, the Supreme Entity, the Cosmic Nucleus – the Supreme Stance. His love and affection were so great that just a drop put one into ecstasy, into higher levels of existence, into intense great rapture. People came because they could comprehend that Baba was indeed their best friend, their dearest darling. Nay, He was their Only Friend, their true Beloved.

All others come and go, move on in this world. But Baba is always there. Through whatever joys we have, He will be there, silently witnessing. And through our unbearable sufferings, our horrible pains and agonies – He becomes the most intimate companion, never ever leaving us alone, but keeping us so very close to Him. It is for this that we keep running to Him. Once we have experienced His care and His love, we cannot leave it. When we cannot leave His love, it means we have simply fallen head over heels in love with the Lord! We have become mad with loving Him. It is called devotion!

In 1986, some of us were allowed to accompany Baba on a tour of His garden. There were perhaps twelve of us. We collected on the driveway and then Baba came and humbly thanked us for coming to see His garden! His words were the epitome of humility, the epitome of courtesy and politeness, of gentlemanliness, of Supreme Charm and Supreme Benevolence! In His every move, every gesture, every word, and every tone and accent when speaking any word, He was teaching us. He was showing us the Supreme example of how to be in this world. On a practical level, it only made Him infinitely and unbearably irresistible! Then everyone began to move down the path.

By some strange miracle – by His miracle – Baba and I were the last two to proceed on the path through the garden. By some unbelievable miracle – His miracle – Baba and I moved, side by side, down the path. It was a distance of maybe 50 to 60 feet, and then the path took a 90 degree turn to the left. During that time we walked side by side, almost touching each other. We were silent. But – the vibration was overpowering!



How to keep walking! Was I walking? My mind was just spellbound by His close proximity. I do not know why, without my asking, He gave me His close proximity so many times. I wanted to walk with Him forever and ever, side by side, in Divine Peace, in Supreme Shelter. But the path took a left turn and suddenly Baba was ahead. I felt so much pain that He had moved a little ahead. And so much stunned disbelief that He walked with me so far, alone, oblivious to all!

In a short while we were upstairs in His room, sitting in a circle in front of Him. He asked some, 'How did you like it? How did you like My garden?' After a few minutes He pointed in my direction and asked, 'And how did you like it?' I quickly turned my head to the right, thinking He was talking to someone behind me. And then I heard, 'No, you, you!' He was speaking to me! O Lord! Without a second's wait, I simply said, 'It is wonderful, Baba!' And then Baba smiled. He smiled with a closed mouth. But His smile was the biggest smile in the world! Infinite joy was being expressed through His smile!

How many times I was waiting amongst hundreds of devotees in the driveway of Baba's house, but standing so far back that there was no hope of getting close to Him. And I would not push my way through. But again and again it happened that the rain came. With only a few drops of rain, the vast number of devotees would scurry into the garage seeking protection from the rain. The rain became my best friend and ally! The rain allowed me to move just so close to the very spot, say, where Baba would step out of His car, where He would begin His walk along the path, where I could even speak with Him if I wanted!

Tiny, tiny miracles to arrange close proximity to my Beloved – all adding up to His supreme grace! His supreme love for His small child!

Another time I came to Calcutta, riddled with conflict, feeling so unworthy, so undeserving, feeling I should not even be a part of His mission, feeling He should make me an outcast in the farthest reaches of this earth. On that first day I stood in the driveway waiting for My Lord to come. I was full of fear and complex feelings, thinking I could hardly dare to look on Him, at His glorious face.

But lo, He came and walked right up to where I stood, and stopped. He did *namaskar* to me alone! And He smiled – how He smiled! – all teeth showing, smiling from ear to ear! It was such a magnificent, glamorous smile – It was full of His love, His affection! I was stunned. I thought, can this be happening? Why is He smiling at me? Why not others? Others around me are far more important – they are the VIPs of this world. I am nothing. I am nobody. And in fact, I make hundreds or thousands of mistakes every minute of every day – why would He smile at me?

Baba turned and walked back down the path to His door. And then, again He came to the driveway. He walked up and AGAIN stopped right in front of me! AGAIN He did long *namaskar*, and AGAIN Baba was smiling – such a vast smile! This time, in a tiny little voice, I said, ‘*Namaskar, Baba!*’ I was still too stunned, still convinced that I did not deserve His love. To the most undeserving and unworthy, He heaped and continues to heap His love!

Daily I used to play guitar and sing for Baba. I used to sing His *Prabhat Samgiita*, His tender songs. Once it happened that a brother said to me, ‘What’s this! You’re



singing the same songs again and again!’ I felt so hurt, and resolved not to sing again. I went to sleep that night firmly resolved not to even bring my guitar the next morning. Just before waking up, I had a short dream. In that dream, Baba was sitting in front of me. He said simply, ‘You will bring the guitar. And you will sing.’ It was crystal clear, this dream. So when I woke, I felt I should take the guitar. I took my guitar, but with much hesitation and trepidation, worrying that the brother may be tired of my songs.

When I came to Baba’s quarters, so many sisters and brothers were there, singing one song after another, as Baba sat in His chair on the driveway. I felt so hesitant. Finally, when there was a small break between songs, I started to play and sing the song ‘Elo Anek Yuge Sei Ajana Pathik’. But I sang very quietly and they did not hear me. The sisters/Didis started to sing another song and I was drowned out. Not only that, I was gradually pushed by all the sisters right into the garage, still feebly singing and playing, and completely out of sight of Baba. I felt so weak from the heat. I didn’t know whether to continue or to stop. I started to feel some irritation toward Baba, thinking that if this was going to be the state of things, then why had He appeared in a dream with specific instructions to sing for Him!

Feeling full of mental distress, I was almost crying. Suddenly, Dadas and Didis near me started saying, ‘Sing louder! Move forward!’ And they made a path for me to move forward. They told me, ‘Baba is asking, ‘Who is singing ‘Elo Anek Yuge Sei Ajana Pathik’! It means ‘The Eternal, Unknown Traveller Came Today!’ Without any effort, I found I could move forward. I stood just close to

Him, maybe four feet distant, and finished singing my song! How gracious was He!

On my last day of this visit, I was putting a thick garland of flowers over Baba's head and around His neck. (Often on such occasions, Baba would become shy and ask sweetly, 'Are you sure these are for me?') This time, another devotee said to Baba, 'This reminds me of a song, but I cannot remember it.' Then Baba Himself started to sing softly, 'Ajana pathik tamogo kanik Tomay parobo mala.' It means, 'Oh Lord! Please wait and accept my garland!'

One day a very simple quiet lady came to Madhu Malanch. She was around fifty. She had taught yoga for most of her life, but had only been in Ananda Marga for less than one year. Now she had come to see Baba. She had come all the way from the little island of Cyprus, all alone, and was now in Lake Gardens! I used to sit with her while we waited for Baba. I told her where to stand when Baba came. In spite of this, she had not had the chance to do *namaskar* to Baba. One time, Baba came down the path, got into His car and was sitting in the back seat. This time, I pushed this sweet sister in front of me so she could get right in front of the car window. Then I could not see Baba. In this way, she was able to give him a big personal *namaskar*. He responded by giving her a big *namaskar* – just for her! Seeing her like this, I felt so excited.

Perhaps just two feet had separated me from Baba – but as He sat back in the seat, and because I had pushed her in front of me, I had not seen Him. Then, as the car slowly moved out of the driveway, I began to smell the most beautiful scent. The fragrance of the most divine flowers or nectar was enveloping me. The scent was so divine it



seemed almost unbearable. It took some moments for me to speak. Then I began asking others around me, did they also smell that divine heavenly fragrance? But the others said that no, they did not smell anything. Then I realised what Baba had done. Baba knows everything. He knew that even though I myself was longing to see His sweetest smiling face, I had stayed just a little bit behind and out of sight to give my sweet Cyprus sister that opportunity. What did Baba do? He showered me with His own divine nectar!

It was January 1990. Due to His sweetest grace, and due to the sweet kindness of Baba's personal assistant, I was inside the gate of Tiljala – His new residence on the outskirts of Calcutta. I was kneeling outside His door and peeking through a tiny crack in the door. Baba was not well, hence He was not coming outside for walks through His garden. Baba walked slowly from His bedroom to His living room, and there He lay down on His sofa, His couch. Only one brother was with Him, His guard of honour. This was the **ONLY WAY** one could see Baba – peering through a small crack in His door! What was Baba doing? He was telling jokes to His guard. And then? Baba was laughing! He was laughing so much! He would tell the joke, then the guard would laugh, and then Baba would Himself laugh so much – at His own joke! Sometimes, He would laugh so hard, He would roll over onto His back, on the sofa, still laughing and laughing! It was unbelievable! Day after day, for nearly a week, I peered into that crack and watched Baba, talking and then laughing, telling joke after joke, story after story, and laughing and laughing!

To see the Lord in this way, I realised, firstly, that the funniest person in the entire universe is God – my Baba –

that all humour emanates from Him. And secondly, I realised that the Lord wants all of us, all the human beings, to be laughing! He wants to see us all laughing! He does not want us to be sad or depressed. He wants to see us smiling and laughing! But who could imagine the Lord of the Universe, laughing and laughing! This is a beautiful secret! For very few people know that the Lord, our Baba, is the funniest person in the world! So irresistible is my Baba, how can I leave Him for even a second!

Baba's health was somewhat better. He had resumed His daily walks through the garden in the mornings. Evenings He used to walk just outside His room. Baba was so beautiful! After His walk was over, a few of us were allowed to wish Him *namaskar*, and gaze in bliss at His smiling face – a face whose smile was so vast that if we began to comprehend and feel it, we were in tears.

On the last day, just prior to my departure, I had so much desire to kneel and touch His feet – nay, to kiss His feet. But how to dare to fulfil this desire! It was a strong and deep desire that I had had for many months. How to do this? I felt it would be too bold. Hence I decided not to even attempt it. But on that last day, when it was time to garland Him and tell Him goodbye, by His miracle, I stood directly in front of Him. In a flash, I felt myself going down on my knees. In fact, I felt myself pushed down by an external unseen force! Then I was holding His feet in both my hands. Then I was kissing His feet!

You see, *Baba knows everything*. He knows our each and every desire. He must fulfil our each and every desire before we leave this world. It happened so fast. But it happened. I knelt in front of Him, I touched His tender feet,



and then I kissed them. This event would become the greatest treasure of my life. Henceforth, wherever I moved and lived, I would carry this event, this happening, with me in my heart. I had touched His feet. And I had kissed His feet. It was an event unsurpassed by any other. O, Baba! See how it was to be loved by Lord Anandamurtijii!

This had been in January 1990. It was the last time I would see my Lord in his physical body.

III

Today it is January 2000. Where are You, my Baba, my Lord? My most charming, my most gorgeous, most glamorous of all entities – my Supreme destination and desideratum – where are You? I do not know. But I think, and I feel, that You are with me every second of every minute – every minute of every hour – and every hour of every day. This is what I feel. Life is suddenly moving very fast now, *samskaras* (reactions to past actions) are rushing and turning my life upside down, causing immense pain, grief and trepidation. And where are You? You are just here, my sweet One, just next to me, just beside me, holding me tightly as I am holding You tightly.

You are watching, hearing, understanding and seeing all the events, seeing all my fear, pain and agony, seeing my longing to curl up on Your lap, to be enveloped in Your arms. Surely I can bear all pain and agony, can bear all suffering and become brave, because You are just here, next to me! When I cry for You, You come. When I cry in fear and panic, You hush my fear and in a flash remove all danger. When I cry in loneliness, You fill me with unbearable bliss. Your benevolent touch in my life is unfathomable, when given to someone so unworthy. Nev-

ertheless, it is there, every second. Life became a razor's edge, with all kinds of dangerous objects hurtling towards me, trying to annihilate me. But my Lord, most benevolent, most compassionate, most merciful, most loving Entity of this world – You are always there, with me.

You are embedded in me, and I am embedded in You. You are doing all for me, my Lord! You are my everything! You are my father, my mother, you are my husband, my brother and sister – You are my all, my Lord! You are the Supreme Cognitive Faculty, the Nucleus of the entire Cosmos! You are beyond the periphery of all the tiny human minds! You are so grand, so magnificent!

But for me, you are simply my Sweet Saviour, picking me up again and again, putting me again and again on Your lap, and loving me to pieces, loving me until tears rain down my weary cheeks. You change the nature of my tears, Baba – change them from tears of tired suffering to tears of deepest bliss. You are the Supreme Terminus of all my movement, Oh Baba!

Now, I want to see You only – laughing, singing Your songs, smiling in joy. I want to go mad loving You, Baba. Let all separation between us vanish, as I merge with You, Baba. O, Baba! I cannot hold You tightly enough in this form. Give me a form whereby I can merge into Your form – I want to be You.

Tell everyone, all My sons and daughters,
that 'I am yours.' I love each and every particle
of this universe. My love is for everyone.
I am always with you.

(Baba gave this message to a devotee who visited him in jail in 1977.)

Epilogue



Into The Fire

Jennifer Jayanti Fitzgerald

*I burn.
God, how I burn.
Unceasingly, I burn.
There could be no preparation for this.
And there was none.
Without warning,
Without graduation,
I found myself
falling
Into the fire.
Not on the edge
of this fire.
But in the centre.
And not a little fire,
But a raging furnace.
The flames
are everywhere.
They are fierce,
Engulfing me
from all directions.*

My body begins its immolation.

I scream.

I plead.

I bleed.

I pain.

I call Your name.

Not once,

but a thousand times,

on every breath.

Carried on my voice,

through the wind,

through the crackling flames,

in every emotion,

my human spirit can feel.

Filled with total desperation,

I scream.

I scream,

not into silence,

I scream,

into the sound of flames,

into the smell of burning flesh,

into my immolation.

Then I wait.

I wait for You.

I wait for You to come,

to pull my body from the flames,

Lick my wounds with Your own tongue.

Stroke my body,

Soothe my mind.

*But not You.
Not You, the God of Destruction.
It's not Your style.*

*So I curse,
I curse,
I curse.*

*I curse You
for Your uncaring,
for Your neglect,
for Your passivity
in the face of my pain.*

*I curse You for Your style,
Your demands.
Your constant, insistent demands
upon my spirit.*

*I curse You and I curse You
until all my anger is spent,
until my repertoire of profanities is exhausted.*

*And I collapse
into the bed of red hot coals
that has become my home.
And I look at the flames all around me.
And in my exhaustion
I suddenly realise
that in this fire
My pain has been burnt too.*

*So I sit
inside my tantra piitha,
flames licking at my body.*

Burning hard and fast.

*But I feel no pain
(for it is incinerated).*

And I feel only You.

*Then, through the inferno,
I see a form.*

*A form stoking more logs
onto this fire.*

*Huge logs of sandalwood
And buckets of ghee.*

My ire raised again.

Who dares?

Who dares to stoke this fire,

This inferno that is my prison.

This inferno that has become my home.

For just a moment,

A breath of wind

clears the smoke,

And that form appears.

In that moment of clarity,

I see that it is You.

You smile

And walk away.

And then I know.

This is Your style.

*Inside – my heart stirs
with the warmth of Your fire*

And I smile

And walk after You.

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Glossary

acharya: spiritual teacher who teaches meditation; a title gained after intense study and spiritual discipline; in Ananda Marga, *acharyas* are usually monks or nuns, and sometimes family people.

akhanda kiirtan: *kiirtan* danced in a circle for periods of 3, 6, 9 or 12 hours; *akhanda* means 'unending'.

Ananda Marga: spiritual organisation founded in 1955 by Prabhat Rainjan Sarkar to revitalise the ancient Indian tradition of Tantra by linking self-realisation with service to humanity.

ananda: bliss.

asanas: the physical exercises of yoga; the third in Patanjali's list of the eight 'limbs' of yoga – yama, niyama, asana, pranayama, pratyahara, dharana, dhyana and samadhi.

ashram: meditation centre.

avadhutika diiksa: initiation as a senior monk or nun, which includes the graveyard meditation (*kapalika* meditation); nuns and monks initiated to this level wear full orange robes instead of the orange and white of the junior *brahmacharya*.

baba nam kevalam: mantra meaning 'love is all there is'; chanted during *kiirtan*.

Glossary

Baba: the nearest and dearest one; an affectionate term for Guru.

bhakta yogi: a devotee; one who approaches the divine as intimate friend or lover; central to this approach is the sense of a personal relationship with the divine, usually manifested in the form of *guru*.

brahamacharya: junior monk or nun.

chakra: spiritual foci in the human body; commonly considered to be seven in number and situated approximately along the spine from the coccyx up to the crown of the head.

Dada: monk of Ananda Marga, trained to teach yoga and meditation; literally means 'brother'.

darshan: a time when the guru comes before the disciples; the guru's form is sacred, so to see that form is considered a blessing and darshan is therefore an event of tremendous importance.

dharma chakra: group meditation during which spiritual aspirants sing, meditate, discuss philosophy and eat together.

dharma samiksa: a program conducted by Baba in the early 1980s during which he gave his students the opportunity to accelerate their spiritual growth; Baba gave a personal review, providing insight into a student's strengths and weaknesses – physical, mental and spiritual – with advice on lifestyle changes needed for that student to continue their spiritual growth.

dharma: approximates to 'natural propensity' or 'essential characteristic'.

dhyana: ideation/meditation on the form/qualities of the guru.

Didi: nun of Ananda Marga, trained to teach yoga and meditation; literally means 'sister'.

diiksa: initiation in meditation.

ekadashii: The eleventh day after the full or new moon, prescribed for fasting according to the Tantric system.

guru mantra: mantra used during everyday activities to ascribe divinity to actions, thoughts and objects.

guru puja: ritual, performed at the end of meditation, by which a spiritual aspirant offers a series of coloured flowers to the Guru; the flowers represent the colours of the mind; the final flower offered is a pure white flower, representing the purity of one's soul.

guru: literally means 'one who removes darkness'; teacher, spiritual master.

gurukula: the abode or house of the guru; school or place of learning; university.

Hatha yoga: physical yoga practices aimed at disciplining the body and mind and instilling balance and health.

i'sta chakra: chakra of special significance to an initiated meditator.

i'sta mantra: personal mantra given at the time of spiritual initiation (*diiksa*) for use during meditation.

jagriti: place where monks and nuns of Ananda Marga live and from which they run classes and social services; also where followers of Ananda Marga gather for meditation and discussion; similar in function to an ashram.

jinana yogi: one who finds the Divine through the use of intellect.

kapalika meditation: general name for the 'graveyard' meditation, performed at a graveyard at midnight on the new moon; taught to nuns and monks of Ananda Marga after some time spent as junior renunciates, as part of their initiation as *acharyas*; a meditation for conquering fear.

karma yogi: one who achieves Divinity through physical action.

karma: universal law of cause and effect, which works across lifetimes; reframes 'accidents' as 'incidents' that are consequences resulting from past actions (*samskaras*).

kiirtan: the singing of mantra, often combined with a yogic dance (*laliita marmika*), to evoke the name of the Divine and to still the mind before meditation; in Ananda Marga the mantra is usually *baba nam kevalam*; examples of *kiirtan* can be heard at the website www.innersong.com.au

kurta: shirt

laliita marmika: dance performed while *kiirtan* is sung; hands and arms are raised or held in *namaskar* at the heart, big toe of one foot taps behind the heel of other foot as weight is shifted from one foot to the other in rhythm with the mantra.

liila: Cosmic play.

mala: closed string of beads, like a rosary.

mantra: a Sanskrit word or phrase recited during the practice of meditation.

maonobrata: meditative silence, maintained over an extended period to increase strength of mind or to clear the mind of confusion.

Margii: member of Ananda Marga, usually a family member rather than a monk or nun; marga means 'road/path', thus *Margii* literally means 'traveller'.

microvita: living energies that are positive, negative or neutral in essence; the crudest are viral in nature but most exist beyond the capacity of technology to detect them and are sensed inferentially by effect or through meditation.

mudra: significant gesture which, when performed by the Guru, brings special blessings usually of a spiritual kind.

namaskar: spiritual greeting that combines a mudra with the spiritual ideation of 'I salute the Divine within you with all the divine charm and sweetness of my mind and my heart'; the mudra is performed by placing the hands in prayer position at the *ajina* (third eye) chakra and then on the *anahat* (heart) chakra.

Neohumanism: holistic spiritual philosophy that links the spiritual development of the individual with social engagement; sees all matter, living and inanimate, as divine and therefore of equal value; as a consequence, the material universe becomes an experience of love and service.

paincajanya: early morning meditation at 5.00 am.

Prabhat Samgiita: 'Songs of the New Dawn', a collection of 5008 spiritual songs composed by Prabhat Rainjan Sarkar.

pranam: prostration at the feet of the Guru.

prapatti: spirit of complete surrender to the Divine.

prasad: blessed food; may be blessed directly by the guru, or by the act of offering the food spiritually to the guru, or by singing *kiirtan* over the food.

Prout: socio-economic theory based on Tantric spirituality; integrates personal and social transformation within the context of strategies designed to engender justice and to promote collective welfare, sustainable economics and personal and economic fulfilment. For further information see www.proutcollege.org

Sadhaka: someone who practices meditation with sincerity.

sadhana shivir: intensive meditation program incorporating long hours of contemplative silence, *kiirtan* and meditation.

sadhana: mediation; process in which individual mind identifies with and ultimately merges with the Divine; also means struggle or effort to achieve one's goal, in which sense all we do in life that is aimed at personal and social liberation becomes *sadhana*.

samadhi: a state of equipoise or blissful transcendental trance.

samaj: social movement against oppression and exploitation by an outside power.

samskaras: experiences which are the inevitable results of our past actions (*karmas*).

shavasana: yoga asana, also called corpse pose; position of total relaxation.

Sixteen Points: lifestyle rules for Ananda Margiis to sustain spiritual determination and purify the body and mind; practices that develop will.

tantra piitha: place deeply vibrated by the fierce and devoted meditation of a Tantrika.

Tantra: ancient science of liberation developed by Shiva around 5000 BC; sees the world paradoxically both as in synthesis (harmonious spiritual balance) and as torn between ignorance (the repelling force) and wisdom/love (the attracting force).

Tantrika: person who practices Tantric *sadhana*.

varabhaya mudra: special mudra to dispel fear, performed by the guru.

yoga: in Sanskrit, means the union of the particular with the universal; the collective actions that facilitate this union; commonly used to refer simply to *asanas* (postures and exercises).



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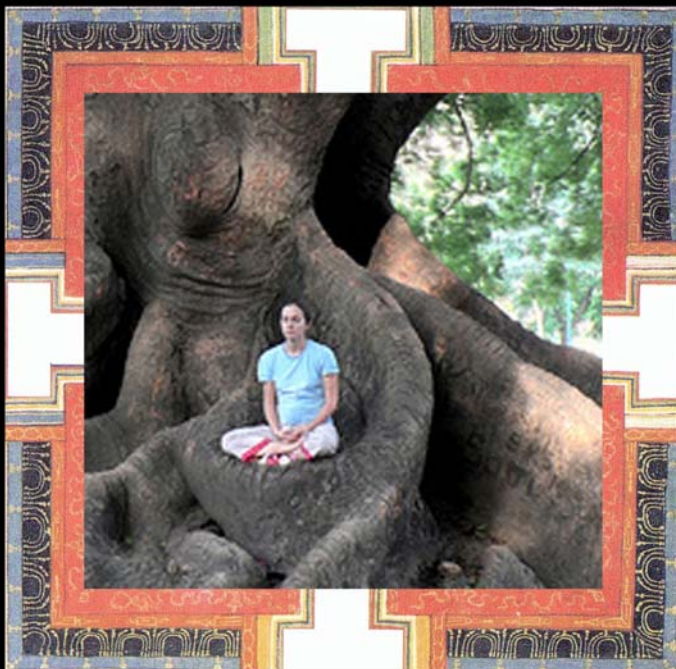
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